

MAINALON

In Search of Arcadia



Matt Stanley

MAINALON: IN SEARCH OF ARCADIA

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In Search of Arcadia

Matt Stanley

Aetos Press

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Many thanks to Ioannis Lagos, who conceived and was the driving force behind the Mainalon trail and the subsequent network of Peloponnesian walking trails.

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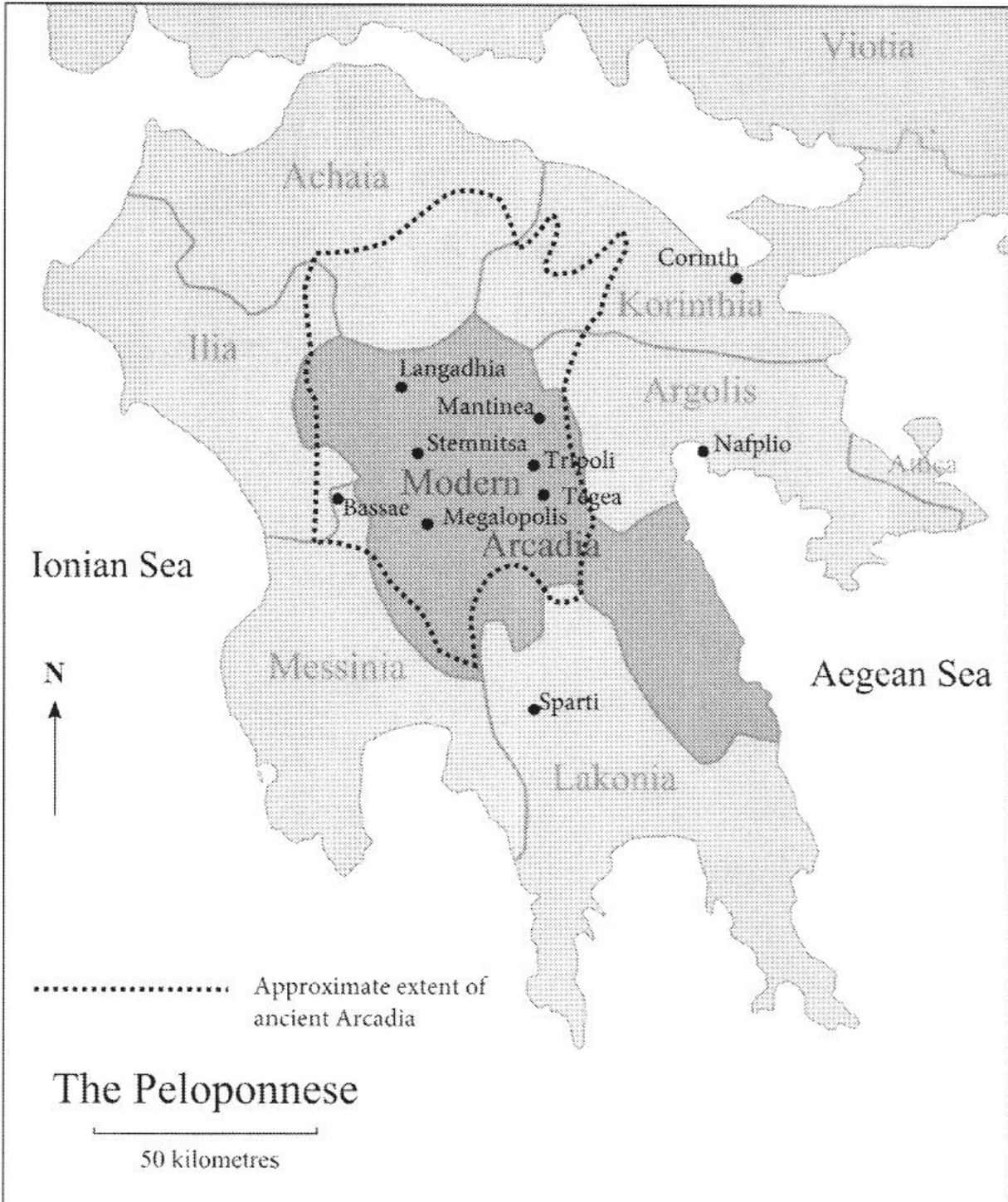
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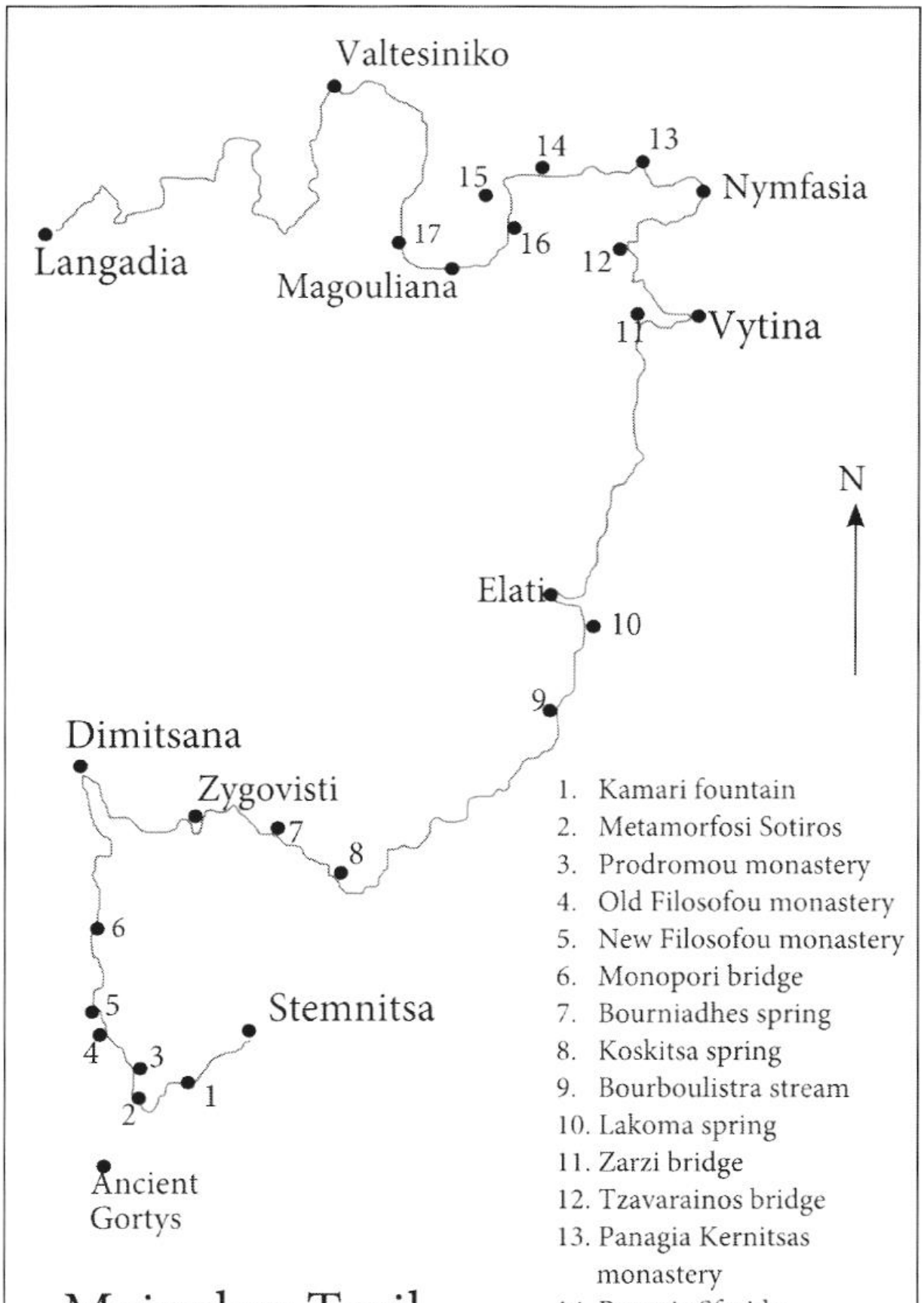
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Today the territory of modern Arcadia extends to the shore of the Aegean to the east. Ancient Arcadia however was

*completely land-locked, occupying the largely mountainous
centre of the Peloponnese.*

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Mainalon 1 rau

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5 kilometres

14. Panagia Styrida

15. Agios Anagyri spring

16. Gavros spring

17. Manna Hotel.

Preface

This book is an account of walking the Peloponnese's Mainalon Trail in May 2025. Though not intended to be a formal guide to the trail, it does provide a lot of descriptive and factual detail about the route and its villages. Anyone who has done the walk or who is thinking about it will hopefully find the account useful and interesting.

More broadly, the book is about Arcadia as a place and as a concept. Its three mountain ranges i.e. Mainalon (known for its ski resort), Parnon and Lykaion. The Mainalon massif is a region rich in history, mythology and cultural associations that have resonated through western culture for more than two thousand years and whose origins go back even further into unwritten prehistory. That story is explored in the following chapters as context to the sites, structures and villages.

Arcadia is also an idea of a perfect, almost mythical rural idyll celebrated by poets and historians for millennia. It was this Arcadia that foreign travellers came seeking from the seventeenth century onwards, comparing their experiences with the accounts of much earlier visitors, of poets and of stories created before writing existed. Some found what they were seeking. Some were disappointed with the reality. Others adapted to and developed the meaning of Arcadia.

In more recent times, Arcadia in general and Mainalon in particular have become popular among hikers and nature lovers for its dense forests, traditional villages, hidden monasteries, Ottoman bridges and historic locations. In fact, those early travellers were the first who sought and mapped many of the routes followed today after they'd been lost to the outside world for centuries.

I am another in this tradition. I came with the same notions of Edenic nature and Elysian ease. I also came looking for a great walk in stunning natural surroundings. The journey - both physical and conceptual - is fascinating and the destination different for every traveller. There is something profound in the notion and the reality of Arcadia that the book seek to discover.

I

Robbers and Ramblers

Robbery and murder were expected hazards for foreign Travellers in Arcadia throughout much of modern history. Its thickly forested mountains and peak-buttressed river canyons made it a natural hiding place for the bloodthirsty, rapacious and desperate until the mid-nineteenth century.

Arcadia was the Peloponnese's outback - its badlands, its Sherwood Forest. When Frankish lords, Venetian taxes, and Ottoman brutality oppressed the towns, Greek and Albanian outlaws fled to the unmapped wilderness to live among the lynx, wolf and bear, preying not only on travellers and traders but also on Greek villagers.

Traveller Bernard Randolph noted in 1689 that, "These Albaneses¹ have often rebelled and kept themselves up in the mountains doing much mischief by robbery. They were so strong in the year 1679 as the pasha went with 500 men to reduce them by granting a general pardon."

¹See the Glossary for foreign or obsolete words.

It was a temporary measure. Frenchman François Pouqueville visited Arcadia in the late 1790s and reported, "a horde known by the name of Laliots, from the small town of Lala where they reside, who disgrace this part of Peloponnesus. They are the outcasts of *banditti* who have escaped from the arm of justice and are more cruel and ferocious than the Bardouniots, for they spread terror and desolation amongst the peaceable inhabitants of Elis and Arcadia." Villagers related a story to Pouqueville of a traveller thirty years previously who was murdered after setting out to visit the ruins of a nearby temple (probably at Bassae). His murderer was never identified but was presumed to be a Laliot.

The numbers of these outlaws and the terrain they inhabited meant that agriculture or commerce were not practical options for survival. Instead, they resorted to wholesale and indiscriminate pillage. They imposed protection rackets on the various monasteries of the region and would even

kidnap high-ranking Turks or Greek churchmen for ransom. Larger houses were ransacked and livestock stolen. When particularly hungry or desperate, these roving klephts demanded payments from entire villages to prevent a mass attack. In such cases, the thieves would bypass the villagers and appeal directly to the district's primate or *pasha*, naming the pay-off and specifying a place and time for it to be deposited - or else ...

The Ottomans attempted to control these bands of thieves, but with varying success. Edward Dodwell in the early 1800s observed: "Very active measures were taken about this time by the Porte for the suppression of the formidable bands of robbers who infested the Morea and had hitherto set the government at defiance. Their predatory force found an almost impregnable protection in the lofty mountains and in the thick and extensive forests of Arcadia, Messenia and Laconia, while it was imagined that they were indirectly assisted by the Greeks of those mountainous districts."

Dodwell experienced the violence first-hand: "We had scarcely quitted the village of Sinano [now Megalopolis] when we saw the women and children rushing into their cottages, driving in their cattle and closing their doors, and heard the cry of thieves re-echoed on all sides." Since his retinue included a number of armed Turks, he plunged into action and went in pursuit of the brigands with an insouciant, "This had now become so familiar to us that we no longer felt any great alarm and were determined to hazard any thing rather than deviate from our plans." It's worth quoting subsequent account at length for the local colour it provides:

"We crossed the river Helisson and, plunging into a thick forest of oaks, in the course of a few minutes found ourselves in the presence of a small party of the thieves who were secreted in the wood. My Turk Ibrahim and one of the villagers of Sinano immediately rushed upon a sturdy ruffian and with some danger secured him, and tied his arms together. "The rest being inferior to us in number fled into the forest without making the least resistance, and, while we were eagerly but incautiously pursuing them, we were unexpectedly drawn into an ambuscade and found ourselves in an inextricable labyrinth of bushes and morasses, and surrounded by a large band of robbers who imperatively ordered us instantly to prostrate ourselves before them.

"Some of our party, however, firing upon the thieves, we were answered by an immediate discharge [of] pistols and musketry and two of our men fell badly wounded. This was the signal for general slaughter and, our escape appearing impossible and resistance useless, we expected immediately to pay dear for our inconsiderate temerity.

"At this critical moment, loud voices were heard, with the approaching galloping and neighing of horses, and in another instant about three hundred Turkish horsemen headed by the *voivode* of Karitena, who was in search of the robbers, rushed to the spot where we stood and taking us all for thieves, trampled some of our party under their horses feet; but as they were not long before they perceived their mistake, they recommenced their pursuit of the robbers and I never beheld a more animating spectacle or witnessed a more singular conflict.

"The Turkish costume formed a striking assemblage of military glitter and this blended with the gay caparisons and gorgeous trappings of their horses moving rapidly along, at times appearing, disappearing, and re-appearing among the trees, and chequering the shade of the forest with sudden gleams of coloured light, formed altogether a rich and interesting picture. We must also recollect that it derived an additional attraction from the danger we had escaped and the security we then enjoyed.

"In a few minutes, we came up with the thieves and although they formed the main body of one hundred and forty Greeks, yet they were so unprepared for this general attack that they dispersed and were indebted for their safety to the dense intricacies of the forests and the precipitous ruggedness of the mountains. Only seven of our men were wounded during the day; several of the thieves were badly wounded; one was killed, and five were taken prisoners and sent to Tripolitza, where they were beheaded.

"They were badly clothed extremely dirty and had very little money or ammunition. They belonged to the great band of Captain George Kolokotrone [Giorgos Kolokotronis]

whom we had so lately seen fighting at the foot of Ithome [near Kalamata]. The thief who was taken by my Turk Ibrahim had only one charge for his musket and twenty paras in his purse.

"At the end of the chase, which lasted about two hours, we all assembled in an open part in the forest near the ruins of Megalopolis. The prize of valour, according to the decision of the voivode, was adjudged to Ibrahim and the Greek who captured the first thief. Ibrahim took possession of the robber's dagger, ammunition belt, his ring and purse. The gun was given to the Greek. The whole of the party and particularly the thieves were extremely surprised at seeing me at the present encounter; for I was in the Frank dress and my hat attracted the notice of every one."

Despite the genuine danger, Dodwell delights in the spectacle of the splendid uniforms, the forest pursuit and the dappled sunlight. The whole thing could have been a theatrical production prepared for the foreigner, who stands aloof in his northern European ("Frankish" to the locals) dress and who appears impervious to harm thanks to his alien status.

Some travellers expected and even seemed almost to desire a colourful mugging as part of the Arcadian experience. Visiting in 1830, Englishman Thomas Trant remarked with salivating glee, "Some of the dells we passed were exceedingly wild and fit spots for the scenes of those atrocities which at various periods have been perpetrated in Greece. I was prepared to see a band of klephts start from behind the masses of rock which at times obstructed our path."

Trant's local guide knew the score and fed his client's thirst for drama: "Anastasius, who was well versed in traditionary lore, had a gloomy tale for every nook we passed, and at one little defile, he pointed out to me a low stone wall or tambour which, being constructed with loose stones, was scarcely to be distinguished from the rocks around; here two determined ruffians had taken post some months before, and from their concealed position were enabled to take unerring aim at the unwary traveller, who, however well armed, could not but fall beneath the blows of his unseen foe."

Such episodes say a lot about Arcadia in the nineteenth century. Even

amid the many mythological glories and historical richness of Greece, Arcadia is a name, an idea that has echoed through art and literature in chimerical forms for more than two thousand years. Like Atlantis or Eldorado, it has been a place anciently recorded in legend but which actually existed and exists. One could visit, and each visitor added to the rich patina or palimpsest of what might be expected there. Eighteenth- and nineteenth-century travellers, usually well-educated and wealthy gentlemen came with clear expectations. Some found what they were seeking because they were seeking it. Some were disappointed with what they found. Others updated and repurposed Arcadia's legend to suit their needs. Anywhere difficult to reach and arduous to traverse can become partially fantastic or imaginary. Each traveller creates the place anew, and their subsequent readers avidly consume news of places they will probably never visit. 'The murderous thieves encountered by Dodwell and expected by Trant were part of the enchantment at that time: a thrilling anecdote for the inevitable travelogue.

Arcadia is still not especially easy to reach or to traverse. No major highways pass through it. No train lines have braved these mountains. In 2025, there was only one direct bus a week from Tripoli to Stemnitsa and Dimitsana. The roads between villages are narrow, winding and occasionally sheep-clogged, snow-bound or blocked by fallen boulders. Some of the higher and more exposed hiking paths are inaccessible in mid-winter. Thomas Trant wrote: "To the Greeks, the difficulty of communication between one town and another is a source of exultation, as they very rightly deem that a spot which is not easily accessible can be defended with but little difficulty; but however correct this reasoning might have been when applied to the time that their country was invaded by a merciless enemy, there is no reason why it should be suffered to operate for the future."

If the transport infrastructure isn't much better nowadays, it's because Arcadian villages have followed the same pattern of depopulation as rural villages across Europe. Young people don't want to stay because it's "boring," there's little work outside agriculture or tourism, and the commute to cities such as Tripoli or Megalopolis is problematic in the hard winter months.

My taxi driver from Tripoli bus station to the village of Stemnitsa took

me on a tour of Arcadia's decline, slowing at various points along the way to show me abandoned houses, a yard full of rusting trucks, a shuttered warehouse. One family had emigrated to America. Another to Argentina. He indicated the distant village of Piana, once with a population of 2,000 - now with only one school-age child. At a low concrete bridge, he stopped the car and gestured at an overgrown river valley that had once flourished with the cultivation of nuts, fruit and vegetables. "Closed ... finished ... gone," he said with each new example.

Then there had been the forest fires of sixteen to seventeen years previously, whose effects were still visible in tree- denuded hillsides only now starting to develop low scrub. The fires had accelerated the exodus to the big cities and abroad. Today, the off-season populations of some Arcadian villages are between thirty and 500 permanent residents. Compare that with an estimated 3,000 residents in nineteenth-century Karitaina.

He asked me where I was from. The UK. "Ah! Peterborough? Leeds? Manchester?" He'd had previous customers from those places. "But if I tell a British person I'm from Arcadia," he said, "do you think they're going to say: 'Ah! Stemnitsa? Vytina? Langadia?' No! Nobody knows this place. Nobody outside Arcadia knows anything about it - this beautiful, historical paradise!"

It was a disheartening story. Even so, the situation seems better now in some villages than it was around thirty years ago. When I first visited Dimitsana in the 1990s, the town offered just two places to stay. Now, there are around twenty-five listed online. Many of the villages have become popular winter and summer destinations for Greeks and international tourists. There are shops and restaurants where previously the only opportunity to eat was an enterprising local with a few rickety tables outside their door.

Part of the reason for the slow renaissance is hiking. The modern traveller in Arcadia is typically not looking to retrace the footsteps of Pausanias, identify ruins or catalogue flora. The key nineteenth-century destinations were almost exclusively the ancient sites of Mantinea, Tegea, Megalopolis, the temple of Apollo at Bassae (Andritsaina) and Gortys. Few strayed beyond Karitaina or Dimitsana.

The villages once used by Grand Tourers as nocturnal stopovers are today attractions in themselves, though sometimes conceived with much the same idealized watercolour charm that previous travellers attached to the

ruins. Walking in twenty-first-century Arcadia is not a means to an end but an end in itself: an inconceivable attitude throughout most of history.

People in the past traversed these mountains with ruminants in search of pasture, or as tradesmen taking wares to market, as pilgrims to ancient sanctuaries, as soldiers marching to put down rebellions or garrison forts. Walking just to walk - for exercise, for reflection, for edification or experience - would have seemed absurd to the villagers and ridiculous to outsiders. Even today, there is a class of Greeks for whom "going for a walk" means driving five minutes to a viewpoint for a cigarette before driving back.

Arcadia's Mainalon Trail is a roughly horseshoe-shaped, 75km route connecting the villages of Stemnitsa, Dimitsana, Zygovitsi, Eláti, Vytina, Nimfasia, Magoulia, Valtesiniko and Langadia. It is not unique in a country of many remarkable hiking paths, but it is the first in Greece (and one of only two) to be certified by the European Ramblers Association (ERA). The certification requires evaluation by experienced hikers from across the association according to certain criteria. Among these are: diversity and beauty, carefully marked and well maintained natural paths through awe-inspiring natural landscapes, historical sites, charming villages and towns, and unique cultural attractions.

The trail certainly ticks all boxes. It has, of course, existed in its various sections since around the sixteenth century and possibly very much longer (see chapter 8). I walked from Karitaina to Dimitsana when the route was a combination of paint marks on rocks and guesswork. The ERA certification, however, guarantees clear and consistent signage and regular clearing of the track, which has attracted a steady but not overwhelming stream of hikers since it was inaugurated in May 2015. Over 20,000 people walked some parts of the trail in 2024 alone (usually the initial and most popular Stemnitsa-Dimitsana stretch), with around 4,000 completing all stages in five to seven days. Some come with walking groups who organise accommodation and bag transport. Some walk solo with a tent.

In tackling the route, my aims were various. I'd revisit places I'd seen at different times in the past; I'd follow the footsteps and reflections of travellers to Arcadia through history; I'd consider the notions of Arcadia and its cultural associations across two millennia; I'd attempt to bring a mindful and even meditative appreciation of walking this renowned hike in spectacular nature. Additionally - if this isn't already apparent - I'd be

nursing a persistent mid-life crisis by leaping into the kind of backpack freedom I'd once enjoyed but almost forgotten. Where better to do that than in Arcadia - the ideal of a simple, innocent pastoral realm?

The region, at least, is no longer known for its lurking brigands. That infamy now lies in the far northern Greek regions of Epirus and Macedonia, whose forests are alleged to be teeming with Albanians illegally immigrating through the forested mountain passes. That was the warning I often received when hiking there in the late 1990s. A lone, mildewed monk at the monastery of Stomiou near Konitsa told me that people sometimes tried to breach the colossal oak doors during the night. I did come across suggestive traces on the remoter forest slopes: empty tuna cans, accumulated cigarette butts and the cold remains of tiny camp fires.

Like the klephts, I was seeking an escape from the outside world and its obligations, its expectations, its numbing predictability. I wanted to get away from work, from screens, from routine - from all of those things you suspect gradually and accumulatively cause cancer. As a fugitive in Arcadia, I'd be free to roam at will with no particular schedule. There'd be uninterrupted time to think. Each day, each hour, would bring new sights and stimulation, possibly new challenges. I also hoped to rediscover some lost pleasures.

I suspect those Grand Tourers felt something similar. At Gortys or Bassae or Tegea, they were following an itinerary set by other travellers in previous books. They knew what they were going to find. They'd read the descriptions and seen the etchings. But they were also seeking adventure in the new. They were braving the robber-clogged woods with a pistol on their hip. They were looking for a lingering gaze from a beautiful and mostly lice-free peasant girl. Or a long-haired, handsome shepherd. Something to remember. Something to make them feel alive.

My intended reader is anyone wanting to relive memories of the trail, anyone thinking about taking on the challenge, or simply anyone with an interest in Greece and a penchant for armchair travel.

2

Stemnitsa: Dogs and Camouflage

I lived in Nafplio in the late 1990s and would sit almost daily with a coffee on the seafront, looking out past the Bourtzi island castle, across the Argolic Gulf to the mountainous horizon. One winter day, those peaks dusted brilliantly with snow and pin-sharp in the January air, I asked the waiter, "What are those mountains over there?"

"That's Arcadia," he said.

Arcadia. The word had, and has, so many associations. On that day, it was a winter realm so seemingly distant and unknowable that it might have been the Himalayas, the Caucasus or Middle Earth. In time, I would visit some of the villages in various seasons, always with the sense of entering a region that was geographically Greek but culturally and historically universal.

When I became aware of the Mainalon Trail in 2024, I had a powerful urge to immerse myself again in Arcadia, straying beyond the villages I knew and penetrating the Mainalon region that is the heart of both Arcadia and the Peloponnese. The central section especially, from Dimitsana to Vytina, promised to be an experience of wild forest isolation: the very core of Arcadia. Apart from the obvious attractions of hiking in such an unspoilt and relatively unvisited area, I was interested in exploring in greater depth the mystique and promise I'd felt in the word "Arcadia" back when it occupied my daily horizon. Thus did I find myself in the back of that taxi out of Tripoli, enjoying the impromptu guided tour and gripping my seat as the driver wove all over the road, his face turned towards me, oblivious to the terrified expressions of oncoming drivers almost cartwheeling into the void on encountering a taxi on a blind comer in the wrong lane.

It was cooler in the village square, as you might expect at an altitude of 1,083 metres. The irregular stone paving and tree- shaded café-restaurant terraces either side of the main road make it a highly attractive space,

dominated by the ornate, white-stone bell tower of St George's church (1877). The church itself standing separately, was built in 1810 on the site of a twelfth-century church where, I was told, Theodore Kolokotronis had been baptised. Other sources claim he was baptised in nearby Piana. A pristine white bust of the old warrior sits before the church, dedicated in 2022.

Kolokotronis was perhaps the most dominant and divisive of the Greek War of Independence generals, and features in the lore of most Arcadian villages. Like Hemingway in Spain, it seems every place has a claim on his illustrious or notorious activities. His family were klephts from Roupaki in southern Arcadia and he grew up in Libovisi in the heart of Mainalon. Locals say that he had a mistress in Stemnitsa and came to visit her on the excuse of getting away from the noise of his military stronghold at Karitaina. He also came here to grieve after the death of his son Panos during the war.

I'd mentioned to the taxi driver that I was keen to eat some traditional Greek food for lunch and he raced off into the places around the clock tower, enquiring about the day's specials. His recommendation was the restaurant offering *moskari kokkinistó* and *fasolakia* (stewed beef and green beans in a tomato sauce), which I promptly ordered. I was taking the first mouthfuls - delicious, sublime - when a bus pulled up carrying two Dutch girl hikers who'd been on the Athens-Tripoli bus with me. Evidently, this bus idling before St George's church was the one that didn't exist according to regional bus operator KTEL Arkadias. A Greek friend of mine had called KTEL to get the timetable for Stemnitsa and been told that the sole weekly bus was on a Tuesday. This was a Monday. Now it seemed that other buses were available - just not direct ones. The taxi had just cost me almost sixty euros. There will be more to say about transport on the trail.

Was it selfish of me to be mildly disappointed that two other hikers had arrived in the village? My fantasies of Mainalon had pictured me alone amid the trail's magnificent silence. The isolation and pristine purity of the place was the point. I wanted it all for me. It was, admittedly, unlikely that we'd find ourselves walking together, but I'd had a few hikes impaired by a couple or a group whose loud and constant conversation had been irritating even at considerable distance (I omit their nationality out of politeness, but they were speaking English.)

Perhaps, like the Grand Tourers, I was expecting too much of Arcadia. It

wasn't just a place to walk; it was a promise of transcendence or enlightenment. It was a panacea, an escape from the world and from modernity. I was heading into the past: my own, Greece's and western civilisation's. I was heading, moreover, into a cultural palimpsest of multiple traveller accounts from the previous two millennia. This was time travel. I didn't want to be reminded of the world outside Arcadia.

Apart from the two Dutch girls and me, everyone else in the square seemed to be local. A couple of agricultural workers - cheesemakers? Goat herders? Beekeepers? - were sitting at the foot of the bell tower and amusedly studying me with my wide-brimmed hat, my colourful walking shoes, my aluminium walking poles. They were both dressed head-to-toe in forest camouflage and wore military-looking boots. Shorthaired and serious, they could have been part of a Special Forces reconnaissance team, except that one of them had an actual wooden shepherd's crook. Was this the modern bucolic Arcadian?

As far back as Homer's *Iliad* and beyond the classical period, Arcadians were famed as good fighters. Many fought abroad, earning better wages and finding more opportunities than in their rural homeland. Here's traveller Christopher Wordsworth in 1868: "The Arcadians were not unwilling to serve as mercenary troops in whatever country and under whatever commander there seemed to be a prospect of the greatest personal advantage to themselves; and instances are not wanting of contests in which some of them were ranged on a different side from others of their fellow countrymen; as Arcadia was the Switzerland, so were the Arcadians the Switzers of antiquity."

Theodore Kolokotronis - himself a military man who'd fought in the Russian navy and for the British - drew many of his loyal and lethal fighters from this and surrounding villages for his illustrious battles at Karitaina, Tripolitsa, Dervenaki and Nafplio. Two hundred years ago, the men of these hills were skilled horsemen armed with long rifles, silver-inlaid pistols, and appropriated *yataghans*. Now, these martial-looking locals drove battered white vans or Toyota pick-ups and wielded chainsaws.

While they smiled subtly, nodding and commenting at my seemingly ludicrous and admittedly out-of-place attire, I wondered if it was strictly necessary for them to dress like Rambo to herd sheep or fell trees. Wasn't it a bit macho? A costume? Who were they hiding from in their camouflage? I began to understand one possible reason only later in my trip. My

accommodation in the upper part of town was what I'd expected and hoped for: solid, dark-wood furniture, wood- beam ceilings, antique agricultural implements as decoration, embroidered tablecloths, and fireplaces adorned with dried flowers - in short, the classic mountain village experience. I'd been on the move since 11.00 pm the previous day. It was time for a rest before exploring the town.

Stemnitsa was anciently known as Ipsous or Ipsounda - names you still occasionally see on maps. Pausanias called it a "savage and brutal settlement" when he passed through. The son of the mythological Arcadian king Lykaon was called Ypsou - the son he *didn't* kill, cook and serve to Zeus, being turned into a wolf for his crime. From the king's name we have the etymology of words like Lycanthropy.

Ipsous became Stemnitsa around 746 AD when plague wiped out a large part of the Peloponnese and Byzantine emperor Constantine V encouraged an already active north-south Slav migration to re-populate the region. "Stemnitsa" has Slavic roots, referring to the dense, forested nature of the landscape. These Slavs became Christianised and learned Greek, blending with the local population as Albanian immigrants were also to do.

The village's history follows a Peloponnesian pattern. The Byzantines gave way to Frank crusaders, who collaborated with the Venetian empire, which ceded to the Ottoman Empire before the Greeks rose in revolution. Just as Karitaina has its splendid, ruined thirteenth-century castle built by Geoffrey de Bruyères, Stemnitsa, too, has its *kastro*. Only the base remains, now with a modern war-memorial obelisk, but the walk to it and the view of the village from there is worth the stroll.

Each village on the Mainalon Trail was known historically for a particular activity. Stemnitsa was a centre of goldsmithing and jewellery manufacture along with bell- casting, though there's little evidence of such activity nowadays apart from a couple of jewellers' shops and the (currently closed) folklore museum, which had exhibits of artisan silversmithing or Chandler's workshops, as well as examples of weaving and embroidery.

The evidence of faded prosperity is everywhere in the grand but ruined stone houses. Walls and windows rise roofless. Arches support nothing but sky. Wooden balconies are gap- slatted. Warped doors hang askew and tumbled masonry shows through the foliage that's reclaimed it. The population in a Venetian census of 1700 was around 920, making Stemnitsa

one of the most populous of the regional villages at that time, compared to 320 people in 2022. Regeneration seeps slowly - two stonemasons were at work in the lower village laying flagged driveway for a renovated mansion.

Non-Greek visitors tend to be less interested in or knowledgeable about Orthodox church architecture beyond the generic appeal of old stonework and smoky gold iconography, but Stemnitsa has a few notable examples beyond St George's. Zoodochos Pigi (15th century), the Three Hierarchs (17th century), Agios Nikolaos (14th century) and Panagia Bafero (12th century) may not always be open for viewing but indicate the importance of village life in keeping the religion alive during the centuries that the Ottomans held Greece. Zoodochos Pigi briefly served as first seat of the temporary government of the liberated Peloponnese after the revolution of March 25, 1821.

Stemnitsa seems poured into the crevices of the hills that contain it, the red rooftops tumbling dice-like along declivities. The village sits inside the landscape and is connected by a network of stone *kalderimia* paths and foot- polished staircases now mostly overgrown. Locals prefer to go five hundred metres in a car or on a moped than walk one hundred metres on the village's steep, centuries-old pathways. The only people I saw using such short-cuts in any of the Arcadian villages were other visitors and the very elderly who had used them since childhood and who probably had little other choice. In Stemnitsa, I didn't meet another person beyond the main road.

Exploring these routes is always a pleasure, following nooks and alleys around buildings in a labyrinth of ancient and modern to discover a medieval church or picturesque ruin. I randomly descended out of town, encountering markers for a path to the neighbouring hamlet of Elliniko. The route was completely overgrown with new grass and wildflowers, but the dilapidated, lichened stone wall and the tiny single-arch stone bridge showed that this was an old Ottoman mule track long fallen out of use. Back before the internal combustion engine, this would have been the road between villages for centuries.

The leaves were bright spring green and fragile, not having existed a week or ten days previously. The scent from the multitudinous wildflowers was heady. It was a presentiment of the trail. I was filled with an urge to keep walking to Elliniko but night would have soon overtaken me. I had no light or extra layers with me.

In early May at this altitude, the evening quickly got chillier. I headed back to the square and the Mainalon Trail information office, which was just opening. I was slightly worried about a dog attack incident I'd seen in an online review and wanted to ask about the current danger level, if any. An Italian couple in June 2023 had encountered a sheep flock on the Dimitsana-Vytina leg of the trail and been charged by three large sheepdogs, who chased them for 500m and had bitten one of them.

The danger associated with sheepdogs in Greece has long been known. There are numerous examples online of brutal and even fatal attacks on people who had no idea they were in danger. These large and fearless dogs are sometimes left unattended with the sheep and are undeterred by the usual tactics of avoiding eye contact, shouting, throwing stones or backing away to take a more circuitous route.

This was also the case for nineteenth-century travellers. Thomas Trant observed the "stout dogs of a noble race peculiar to this country and who are so fierce and powerful that they fear neither man or the beasts of the forest." William Gell in 1823 described an incident that was savage on both sides: "... we were attacked near the river by several sheep dogs, one of which approached so resolutely toward the heels of Mustapha's horse that he cut the skin on each side of the animal's mouth open from ear to ear with his sword, effectually cooling his courage."

I expected Thomas in the Mainalon office to play down the danger for better PR but he immediately told me about a pair of women who'd been recently attacked. Both had been armed with "Dog Dazers" - a small ultrasonic device that produces an uncomfortably dissonant but harmless sound designed as a deterrent. In this case, both women had the devices in their backpacks and didn't have time to access them as they ran away from the pursuing dogs.

Such incidents, though worrying, are rare: just a handful out of thousands of dogless hikes. Other walkers had reported meeting herds and dogs along the path without incident. My advantage, said Thomas, was that my height at 6'2" (188cm) was already a deterrent and that I was walking with poles to fend off any unlikely assault. I didn't feel wholly reassured. If I met the same dogs that had attacked the Italians, it was quite a distance from the nearest village and even further from professional medical help.

I'd had my own experience with dogs in northern Greece. Cycling between villages in Grevena municipality, I'd been chased by a pack of

around six, who'd pursued me for about 500m. I was going uphill and they were on all sides. My only option was to pedal as fast as I could on a ridiculous incline as one of them failed to bite my spinning foot on the pedal and another dangled from the handlebar end, the brake lever preventing him from biting my hand. I was unharmed on that occasion, though it didn't do my heart rate any favours.

The Stemnitsa office for walkers is a great resource and an excellent opportunity to enquire about taxi connections, food or accommodation options. The official Anavasi map of the route (2020 edition) indicates that some villages have no beds and nowhere to eat and drink, though I found even the smallest settlements (Eláti, Nimfasia) had places to eat, even if they were closed when I passed through early in the morning.

Basing my preparations on the map information and inconsistent reports online, I'd decided to bring a tent to avoid problems. The plan was to stay in villages where possible, practical or pleasurable, while also enjoying the opportunity to camp out in the wilds of Arcadia. Ideally, I wanted both experiences.

Wild camping in Greece is a bit of a grey area. Strictly speaking, camping in a tent or a vehicle outside of a registered campsite is illegal. However, some sources suggest that this is the case only on archaeological sites, beaches, public forest edges, and in public areas. Other information suggests that wild camping is prohibited only from sunrise to sunset. In other words, if nobody sees you, if nobody knows, and if you don't abuse the situation, there's some latitude.

Topoguide.gr, a provider of online maps for Greek trails, suggests that the best way to experience Mainalon is alone or in a pair while camping. That's arguable. While a tent does offer more flexibility where rooms are not available or if the weather turns bad, the Mainalon project is partly about helping to regenerate villages and bring new life to Arcadia. That won't work if people don't stop to eat or sleep or shop along the trail.

Not everyone wants to camp anyway. It means carrying more weight in gear, food and water, especially in colder months. It's less comfortable than staying in a nice room. If you really want to camp, it's the same rule as always: be respectful and leave no trace.

I ate again at the same restaurant (*briam*, this time) and bought a few last-minute supplies from the traditional convenience store on the square - the kind of place where you can buy a bucket or a walking staff as well as

some apples or a jar of local honey. Such places are often more like museums than shops. Some decades previously in the village store of nearby Atsicholos, I'd found products of sufficient antiquity that their price or even their currency had been crossed out and updated numerous times.

There's a more souvenir-style emporium further along the road selling attractively packaged pasta, sweets, herbs and suchlike - ideal if you're passing through by car but not so good if you have to carry everything for the next six days. I had no need of some cherry-infused liqueur on this occasion. I was ready to walk the next day.

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3

Stemnitsa-Gortys: Paths and Pilgrims

I woke excited at 6.00 am and went out on to my small balcony to gauge the cold. I'd be camping in the forest for some of the trail and wasn't entirely convinced my sleeping bag was sufficiently rated. The temperature outside was about eight degrees centigrade and dry with no wind. The air smelled of wood smoke. The only sounds were birds, a persistent cockerel and distant dog barks. Time to go.

I stopped at the bakery for a *spanakopita* and observed the brief morning "rush hour" that most of these villages experience around 6.30-7.00 am as the inhabitants head out to their land or to the city in their pick-ups. An unlisted bus also mocked me as it passed - probably a school bus picking up single-figure groups of children from other villages.

Nobody was in the square. All businesses were closed. The trail begins right at the clock tower and heads southwest out of the village, descending past abandoned and ruined stone buildings on an antique stone *kalderimi*. Here on Stemnitsa's periphery, the foliage is subsuming its past: a rising tide of flowers and grasses, a slow wave of leaves and creeping ivy or bougainvillea. Stairs have been built into the centre of this path that now only hikers tread.

The old stone route soon meets a gravel road that runs above a deep, bush-choked and rocky crag to your left. Ahead, the far horizon is a static ocean of green-carpeted waves: deep Arcadia. The real trail begins with a signpost and a left turn onto a single-file dirt track (a *monopati*) that will snake and switchback 800m down to the river Lousios. It is utterly magical.

In May, the yellow spartium (Spanish broom) is abundantly in bloom and intoxicatingly perfumed. Wild thyme releases its scent from under your soles and the spiky Kermes oak bushes create dim tunnels through which

brilliant patches of sunlight silhouette a tangled black calligraphy of branches. The ground is slick and whispery with fallen-leaf confetti: yellow, beige, tarnished silver. Every few steps, the route brings you round to another panoramic view of the gorge you're entering - south towards Karitaina and the striped chimneys of Megalopolis' power generating plant, north towards a still-unseen Dimitsana. The river's rush grows louder.

The Kamari fountain in its shaded dell is a stone-built arch gushing water - a reminder that this is no mere idle path. People don't shape and haul blocks on mules to construct a fountain unless the path is important, unless they expect it to remain in use beyond their lifetimes. This monopati now being used solely by me was once the main thoroughfare between the region's villages. How many people stopped here to fill their canteens, water their animals at a trough and compare notes with people coming from the opposite direction? I wasn't particularly thirsty or short of water, but I splashed my face and head with the icy flow - to be one of those who'd used it.

Was this the quintessential Arcadia I was seeking? The shaded hollows, the gushing spring? The flowers? Other travellers had walked this route and found the same charm. William Gell in the 1820s wrote, "In a short time, we descended into a most beautiful and romantic dell shaded by tall laurels or bays and evergreen oaks, which even in winter almost excluded the beams of the sun and where in summer the additional foliage of the numerous planes bordering the brook must render the obscurity still more remarkable."

I plucked some of those bay leaves and cracked them to smell the perfume as I walked, saving some to cook with later on the trail. However, the natural beauty is marred with something that's become too ubiquitous on hiking trails: the discarded tissues. I started to see them barely a few minutes into the trail and continued to see them all the way to Langadia. These were not tissues discreetly hidden behind rocks or in nooks off the path. Someone had clearly squatted, used some tissue, dropped it and left it where it lay - sometimes in the middle of the path. Occasionally, they'd put a small stone on top. Why? To stop it blowing away?

Is it just me or is there no excuse for this? What kind of person looks around at this splendid natural beauty and leaves a tissue or three in the middle of the track without making any attempt to conceal or bury the evidence? Are they in such a hurry? Would it be so hideous to put the tissue

in a pocket, in a plastic bag or a dedicated exterior backpack compartment? It's not like we're talking about highly corrosive toxic waste that will burn away the fingertips if touched.

The curious thing is that I saw almost no litter on the trail - just tissue. Hikers are ecologically aware enough to not discard a food wrapper or a plastic bottle. They take it with them to dispose of later. But tissues? Maybe the reasoning is that they're biodegradable and will soon disintegrate in rain and wind after a few weeks or months. In the meantime, every successive hiker can see where you had a piss (or worse). Nobody wants to think about that. It's selfish, lazy and arrogant.

I also found a clothing tag on this part of the track. It was a multi-part, white plastic laundry label that somebody had neatly cut out of a Patagonia garment with a pair of scissors or a penknife blade. This gave me pause to think. Had somebody stopped on the descent, irritated by something scratchy in their new T-shirt, and pulled out a Swiss fummy knife to extract it, tossing it on the ground before carefully returning the knife to its correct pocket and continuing, leaving the synthetic fabric to decompose over the next 2000 years or whatever? It's especially ironic given Patagonia's environmental stance.

Maybe I'm being unfair. Maybe the tag had been cut out earlier at the accommodation, falling accidentally and unseen from a pocket along the way. Still ... there's the tissues. No excuse for that.

I continued down the path, spider's web and leaf fragments dangling from my hat brim, until I met an asphalt road. This was the marked trail until the surfacing ended and became a gravel road by the relatively modern-looking and seemingly unused Transfiguration of the Saviour church (Metamorfosi Sotiros). It was here, on the concrete forecourt, that I pitched my tent to sleep one night in the summer of 1997. Behind the chapel is a two-level viewpoint built out over the precipice of the Lousios gorge.

The panorama is spectacular. To the right the colossal green gorge jags its way towards the cliff-clinging Filosofou monasteries and up to faraway Dimitsana crowning its hill with red roofs. To the left you can see the tiny verdant field of ancient Gortys almost at river level. In front, a craggy, earth-stained limestone cliff looms over the unseen, roaring bottom of the void. It's a raw Arcadian view of foliage, mountain and river.

From the church, the path descends on a foot-polished kalderimi to the

monastery of St John the Baptist (Prodromou) and along a staircase under a dramatic cliff overhang like a static wave about to break. It's easy to miss the monastery, which is built into the vertical cliff face as a swallow's nest of rickety supports, fragile-looking wooden stairways and balconies on which hang the monks' coloured towels. Plastic pipes carry waste away from the accommodation, leaving rusty stains on the rock.

The original mid-sixteenth-century structure (possibly built on a twelfth-century original) has clearly been patched and augmented over the centuries, as seen in the different styles of stonework and wood of various faded hues. During the War of Independence, it acted as a medical station and may have been the site of some engagements if the marks at the main door are indeed from Turkish bullets. As with many such monasteries, it has an illustrious library of ancient texts and a dim church populated with smoke-tanned and gilded saints. St John the Baptist paved the way for Christ, hence the name Prodromou: pro ('before') and dromou ('the road, the way').

The traveller Rufus Anderson passed this way in 1829 and observed: "High up in the perpendicular faces of the calcareous rock are seen the caverns to which the people of Demetsana sent their families in hour of danger. Cells of hermits are built in some of the caves but are now deserted. A monastery overhangs the western verge in which are said to be a few monks."

The monks welcome visitors during opening hours with sweets and coffee (or, more traditionally, a fiery *tsipuro*) but on this occasion I didn't enter. I'd been there in the summer of 1997, having been advised that pilgrims were allowed to spend the night for free. The idea of sleeping amid the rushing darkness of the Lousios gorge, the candlelit dorms and the incense-perfumed monastic chants was too romantic to pass up. Alas, I'd arrived on a holy day and the place was swarming with Greek men who had reserved their spots. There was no space for me.

A kindly monk allowed me to pass the siesta on one of the hard steel-frame beds, but I was asked to leave at twilight. The monk suggested I camp at ancient Gortys, but I didn't know where that was (trail signage was minimal or non-existent at the time) and darkness was imminent, hence my camping spot on the concrete forecourt of the church by the road.

The official Mainalon Trail branches north from the monastery and through the gorge towards Dimitsana, but I was keen to see the site of

ancient Gortys that I'd missed almost thirty years previously and which was less than an hour away. It meant a steep descent to the river on a day that was already predicated to be six hours of walking, but my curiosity was too much to resist.

I took the left-hand option at the fork and descended towards the river described by Pausanias around 1,800 years previously: "There is a river flowing through Gortys that the people who live around its springs call the Wash, because it was used for washing at the birth of Zeus, but people who live farther from the springs call it the Gortys river after the name of the village. The Gortys has the coldest water of any river in the world." Lousios was Greek for Wash.

The path enters a twilight realm of such heavy foliage that the sky is lost and pockets of darkness lurk amid ragged sunlight. It is a magical, mythological and vaguely inimical space. Here cavorted the forest god Pan amid the dryads and the naiads. Would the ancient shepherd have followed his errant sheep into this wooded depth? The river rushes close by but unseen: a phantom watercourse, icy from its subterranean passage through limestone caves and divine from Zeus's lavation.

Eventually, a utilitarian wood and steel bridge appears out of the leafy thicket - a replacement for an older stone bridge washed away. Only now does the famed Lousios become visible, foaming white through a tumble of mossed rocks, its depths sapphire blue. A huge but light-deprived fig tree grows beside a ruined stone structure once used by the monastery to supply fresh water. It's a fairytale nook and cool.

England's Earl of Carnarvon could have been writing about this spot in his reminiscences: "... we found ourselves amongst all the beauties of Arcadian scenery. Plane trees stretched out their spreading arms rendering at times the path, which happened to be in little use, almost impassable. Streams of crystal delighted the eye and refreshed us with their delicious waters. The wild pear mingled freely with the holly leaved and the common oak. The pink, the wild violet, the red cystus, bloomed on every bank, whilst fern covered the heights and surrounded the trees, which, as in some English park, often grew in large and rounded clumps."

From here, the path rises through oak tunnels of lace-like light, pink rock-rose and daisy, the river loudly invisible in the crag to your left. The view of Gortys from St John's monastery showed a meadow-like opening in the forest, a clearing with a lot of sky above it, but the path continued

dense, enveloping without any sign of egress. This was the first time since Stemnitsa that I'd seen other walkers: a handful of middle- aged German couples on a group excursion from Karitaina. We nod multilingually as hikers do.

The path tips you suddenly out onto a gravel road of heat and sun. To the right is the grassy expanse of the ancient site and to the left is the tiny Byzantine church of St Andrew, half- swallowed into the grass and wildflowers.

An odd thing about Greece's ancient sites is that many of them ceased to exist for centuries. At least, they vanished for a time. Plague wipes out local populations; occupying powers come; old stones are used to build new structures, and old gods die to be replaced with new. Rivers change course, burying sites in silt (i.e. ancient Olympia), or millennia of windborne soil and leaves simply mask sites' features, turning a theatre into a mere suggestively-shaped depression (i.e. Epidauros) that are re-found only when aeroplanes cross the skies.

Meanwhile, local inhabitants forget. Amid broadly illiterate and/or shifting populations of Slavs, Albanians and Turks, the existence or significance of ancient sites is passed by word of mouth only. Inscriptions are illegible or indecipherable. After just a few human lifetimes, an ancient temple is stripped by builders and reclaimed by nature, leaving only grassy humps and perhaps a corner of exposed masonry. It's origin or purpose becomes a rumour.

In this sense, it's not patronising or paternalistic to say that a traveller "discovers" an ancient site. Of course the locals always knew it was there, but they had no idea what it was. Thus was English traveller Colonel William Leake credited with discovering ancient Gortys in the early 1800s, though he wasn't exactly sure what he'd found:

"At 8.15, we halt ten minutes. On the left, I perceive at a distance of two or three miles to the south west an ancient Greek ruin with walls of the third order. It occupies the summit of a woody hill overhanging the right bank of the Alpheius opposite to and a little below Matésh. It is called the Castle of Leódhoro, or more vulgarly Lódhoro, and is said to have been built by a lord of that name who owned all the adjacent country, which from him was called Leódhora.

This may be a true account of a part of its history, and a castle of the middle ages may have been added to the Hellenic walls, but these belong in all probability to Melæneæ."

His account illustrates the long process of forgetting. The villages have adopted Ottoman names, Matésh possibly being the modern Atsicholos. The Melaeneae ("dark ones") was a mythological family related to river deities, with oracular powers and with connections to the underworld. Local knowledge, meanwhile, points to a dim rumour of a Lord Leódhoro, who may or may not have existed. The name doesn't resemble any of the region's Frankish overlords of the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, though it could be a phonetic malformation of Theodore I Palaeologus (c. 1355-1407), the "Despot of the Morea." Who knows? The locals didn't. They had a story that had been passed on for so long that it had attained semi-fictional status.

Travellers like Leake were following a much earlier visitor whom they'd all read in Latin: the geographer Pausanias (c. 110-c.180 AD), who travelled extensively in Greece. The problem was that Pausanias was often hazy about where certain sites were actually located. Rivers had different names for him, or were misnamed. Villages and the sites themselves were called different things. He had to rely on local accounts just as Leake had, and Pausanias was visiting perhaps three or four hundred years after some sites had been active. They were ruins even in his time. Here is what he says about Gortys:

"On the way from the springs of the river, you find yourself first of all at a place Maratha, and after that at Gortys, a village in my time which in the old days was a city. There is a temple of Asklepios here in Pentelic stone with Asklepios as a beardless youth, and a figure of Health, both by Scopas. The local people also say that Philip's son Alexander dedicated his breast-plate and spear to Aesklepios, and in my time the breast-plate and the tip of the spear were still preserved."

This seems to be the site that Leake identified, not because he was especially perspicacious but because he was one of the first people who'd read Pausanias to pass this way and record the place. He didn't know it was Gortys at the time, but he did know Pausanias had identified sites in this area.

Leake's account was the reason for further travellers to investigate. They were many and tended to come from Karitaina or Atsicholos, following roads above the gorge. Few of them mention the monasteries, suggesting that their guides didn't take them on those kalderimia - perhaps because of lurking robbers, or perhaps because the classically inclined westerners had little interest in Orthodox culture. It's also possible that the Turkish guides weren't aware of the hidden monopatia being used by men who would shortly rise against them.

Here are Edward Dowell's first impressions from the early 1800s:

"After prosecuting our journey for an hour along a very bad road on a high bank by the eastern side of the Gortinios, we crossed it over a bridge, under which the river is rapidly rolled amid steep and lofty precipices that throw a shade of wild horror over the adjacent scenery. In forty-three minutes from the bridge, we reached the ruins called indifferently Marmora or Kachikolo Kastro. It stands upon a high rock rising nobly from the north bank of the Gortinios. The first remains that we reached were the foundations of a temple of the usual form, with some fragments of white marble scattered about.

"We were assured that the pavement, which was of the same material, had been taken up a few years before and burnt into lime at Karitna. Pausanias mentions a temple of Æsculapius at Gortys composed of Pentelic marble. The foundations above mentioned probably indicate its situation. It appears to have been about the size of the Theseion at Athens and was probably of the Doric order. But no fragment of a column or of any architectural ornament remains to corroborate this supposition. As the ruins were probably of marble, they may have been converted into lime.

"The traces of another building, also apparently a temple, are seen in this vicinity. Several masses of the walls, which surrounded the town, still remain, consisting of the second and third styles and composed of very large blocks. There are the ruins of two small gates near each other and also another of a larger size facing Karitna. The lintels have all

fallen. In the time of Pausanias, Gortys, which had once been a considerable city, was reduced to a village."

Dodwell isn't sure whether this is the same Gortys mentioned by Pausanias. His guides gave him different names for the site than Leake's guides had given him, one of them simply being Marmora (marble). In a similar way, the wildly situated temple of Apollo at Bassae was called "the columns" by locals. Dodwell's eyewitness account shows us the site at least 130 years before it was formally excavated by archaeologists. Very little of what he describes is still visible. Most of the Pentelic marble described by Pausanias (the same marble, from Mount Pentelicus near Athens, used to build the Parthenon) has been stripped and turned into lime by generations of local villagers who had no idea what the place was.

We now know that Gortys was an important pilgrimage site where people came to offer votive gifts or prayers to be cured. Olympic athletes passed through on their way to the games. The town around the sanctuary was apparently significant and of impressive antiquity. Pausanias thought it one of the most ancient Arcadian settlements and tentative modern dating puts its founding somewhere between the late Helladic era and the geometric period: 1700 BC to 750 BC. The site had thermal baths with under-floor heating, a temple and fortified walls of up to eight metres thick, most of which seem to have been destroyed by invading Goths in the twelfth century AD. By then, it seems the town was already partially depopulated by the formation of nearby Megalopolis in 368 BC.

In short, this was considered a special and powerful place for more than a thousand years. People travelled here from all over Greece to commune with the gods Aesclepius and Hygieia (Health) and to bathe in the waters in which Zeus himself had bathed as a child. Was the sanctuary founded here due to the myth, or was there something in the place's epic isolation? A trip into Arcadia's interior is not easy even now. Imagine penetrating these gorges and forests three thousand years ago, passing through the same dense thickets and echoing crags that I'd walked that morning.

Today, ancient Gortys sits in a bowl of green tranquillity. The only sounds are bees, birds and the river. The remains occupy two excavated depressions: on one side the blocky grey foundation stones of a temple, and on the other side remains of a bath complex. The most curious feature here is a semi-circle of arched alcoves - possibly places for people to sit in a

steam room or treatment chamber. Column drums lay scattered and wall foundations emerge from the thick cover of daisies, buttercups, lilac valerian and yellow lettuce flower. My shoes raise scents of thyme and wild mint, whose leaves I collect to make an infusion later.

In this place where Alexander the Great came to propitiate the god and where Greece's greatest athletes asked for health, I am alone with the butterflies and curious lizards flitting between lichenized white stone. The sun is hot; the air is still. I'm tempted to camp here just to spend the night among ageless ghosts and watch moonlight creep over the ruins. But it's barely midday and there's a lot more to see on this leg of the trail.

Before heading back up the gorge, however, I take a diversion to see the bridge marked on my map - the same one that Dodwell referred to as the "bridge under which the river is rapidly rolled amid steep and lofty precipices." I had a suspicion that it was going to be one of the elegant stone Ottoman bridges to be found across rural Greece.

It was. The Atsicholos bridge has a relatively unusual pointed arch high above the Lousios, almost hidden by the dense, surrounding plane and oak foliage. The bridge was an important part of a national transport network for centuries but now links minor gravel roads whose vehicles can't cross the span.

It's one of the few places where you can easily get down to river level and test how cold it really is. The water flows shallow and transparent over gravel, glinting tourmaline in its depths. Sunlight scatters ragged through the leaves. It is surely another scene of pure Arcadian beauty and one that has enchanted various travellers. Edmund About was a little further downstream in 1850 when he recorded his impressions:

"There are planes which in spring exhale a luscious smell of honey, tall willows springing from the middle of the stream, which scatter in the air their downy seed and throw over the water the slender shade of their foliage, evergreen oaks whose leaves glow in the spring with a ruddy tint, ash trees with knotty trunks and indented leaves, arbutus trees with their hanging clusters of large green berries, elms, those poor classical elms so despised by the poets of our days and greatly fallen from the high rank in which verse had placed them; there are odoriferous lentisks whose smallest twig if

planted forms in ten years a thicket of leaves, woodbines, sweetbriars, scattering on our heads a shower of petals and perfumes, and in all directions clematis vines and convolvulus of every species."

As if to underline such idyllic transports, a herd of around twenty goats passed by me on the Gortys side, their bells clanking and their sharp caprine musk filling the air. I waited for them to pass, worried that they were accompanied by dogs and knowing that the best opportunity for a mauling was to get among the herd, As I waited, I took out and extended my walking poles for the first time since Stemnitsa. The ascent back to the fork at Prodromou was long and steep and my knees are now half a century old.

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4

To Dimitsana: Saints and Streams

The path onwards from Prodromou to the Filosofou monasteries and Dimitsana had a plasticised piece of 44 pinned to a tree: "Path closed due to falling rocks." This was a problem. No way was I going to walk back to Stemnitsa and get a taxi to Dimitsana, missing one of the most spectacular parts of the trail. So I tentatively walked on in the knowledge that there was nobody to see me. Dying in a rock fall in Arcadia seemed a better way to go than dying of boredom at my desk.

A few metres further on, it becomes clear that the rock fall happened a week or more previously. Stone splinters, disturbed earth, sawdust and a pile of chopped tree limbs show where it happened. The workers must have put up the warning sign before clearing the obstruction then forgot or couldn't be bothered to remove it, confusing subsequent walkers. Rock falls are always going to be a possibility in a gorge like this, anyway. A permanent sign might give people the choice, I suppose, but leaving a temporary sign after it's already happened and been cleared doesn't seem especially useful.

The (new) monastery of Filosofou looked tiny and distant on its rocky outcrop further up the gorge: a fleck of red-domed roof amid the green. Getting there was going to involve a lot of going down followed by a lot of going up. The bridge over the river is a utilitarian concrete structure, no doubt a replacement for a more elegant stone bridge washed away in a flood. Then the relentless climb begins. I'm still undecided whether it's made worse or better by the number of sections where stone or wooden staircases have been built into the path.

There are two Filosofou monasteries. The first was built into a cliff face around 963 AD and acted as one of the secret schools keeping the Greek language and religion alive under the subsequent Ottoman occupation. This monastery is now ruined and officially closed to visitors due to the danger

of rock fall and/or masonry collapse, though the monk at new Filosofou advised me that it was entirely possible to slip through the gate and past the sign forbidding access.

The old monastery is like something out of an Indiana Jones movie. You enter narrow passages between the cliff face and the walls, slipping through arches and entering the church, whose frescoes are faded and wind-worn but still visible. It's sometimes more affecting to encounter Orthodox iconography in this pure, unadulterated form: uncleaned and unrefreshed - untouched since they were painted a thousand years ago. The faded colours are an effect of passing centuries, cycling seasons and untold lifetimes.

The old monastery was dissolved and abandoned in the early 1830s, its valuable manuscripts transferred to Dimitsana. It doesn't seem much in its current crumbling state, but this was a profoundly important seat of ecclesiastical learning in its day, with numerous senior churchmen educated here. It's said that seven patriarchs, including the martyr Patriarch Gregory V and seventy bishops studied within these walls, praying and singing beneath these frescoes.

The relentless ascent takes you on and through a gate to the charming courtyard of Nea Filosofou monastery, founded in 1691 as the new site of the old monastery's scholastic endeavours until 1764. A sole monk now lives here in a small house alongside the church, while a reception area offers tea, tsipuro, bountiful *loukoumi* ("Turkish delight"), postcards, books and religious items to visitors. Of greater immediate appeal, however, is the permanently flowing natural spring, whose water is ice cold and refreshing after the brutal ascent.

The church is tiny but remarkable. Visitors with uncovered legs will need to take a shawl from the back of the door to cover themselves before entering a space that initially seems entirely dark as your eyes adjust. Then details emerge: the glint of brass and gold, the steady candle flames, the carved dark wood, a single beam of light cutting through the smoky air. The walls come alive with frescoed saints, some eyeless - blinded by Turks unnerved by the infidel gaze. The silence is absolute. It is a well of isolation from the modern world.

I sat in the tattered shade of the courtyard's central tree and ate an unnecessary amount of sugar-dusted *loukoumi* "for energy" as the monk showed me a glossy book about Prodromou. He rarely leaves the monastery to go into the city, preferring to spend his time above the earth, outside this

century. Who can blame him?

The path continues north and mostly level as the gorge turns into a gentler, more agricultural valley. Abandoned olive groves descend in terraces and stone houses dot the landscape. Poppies blaze in meadows. Occasionally, erosion or subsidence has sent the right side of the path tumbling into a precipice and a sign advises walkers to keep left. In no time, you reach the Monopori bridge, crossing the river again to walk on the eastern bank.

It was at this bridge thirty years previously that I'd been embarrassed. Walking from Dimitsana to Stemnitsa, I'd encountered a French family bathing. We spoke briefly and I told them my plans before walking on. But then I couldn't find the *monopati* down to Filosofu. It was August and hot. My backpack was heavy and I got frustrated. It would be easier to go back to the bridge, where I'd seen a nice flat camping spot on the western bank.

I walked back to find the French still cavorting there. I felt ridiculous going back so decided to wait until they left, sitting on a rock to pass the time. The hour stretched. When finally they began preparations to leave, the woman glanced around prior to removing her bikini top and looked directly into my eyes up in the forest. She said something to the man and they packed up very quickly, no doubt thinking I was a would-be murderer or pervert. I've felt bad about it all these years.

Standing again on the same bridge, I took out my phone to snap some pictures of the Lousios gushing over sun-bleached stones. I set the camera to video and panned from the distance, following the river's course down to the bridge and then under it ... where a Greek man was standing naked, having dropped his underwear at that exact moment, changing after a swim. His eyes looked directly into mine on the phone screen, his expression one of disgust at this hiking pervert who'd obviously been observing him for a while from the forest.

Again? This bridge was cursed! I hurried on into the trees.

The stretch up to Dimitsana has a different feel, with larger leaves casting shade: oak, plane, chestnut, fig and bay. The small Tzani stone bridge over a brook is an Ottoman reminder that this, too, is an antique route. More than anything, the trail here is characterised by its running water. Numerous streams glitter and race beside, beneath and even along the track, streaming down mossy banks and between stepping-stones. Butterflies flit amid the

shade.

I was alone with the whispering and burbling waters, but this was, again, a path used for centuries by Turks and Greeks and foreign travellers. Kolokotronis certainly come this way with his martial band, as did those illustrious holy men moving between library and monastery. I was walking in the footsteps of traveller Rufus Anderson, who came from Dimitsana in 1829, writing: "We were an hour in descending to the river's bed. The pretty, spicy scented laurel still known to the natives of the country by the name of daphne, grows by the path among perennial cascades, which tumble down the green sides from copious fountains above."

This abundance of rapidly moving water was important to Dimitsana's development as a centre for fulling fabric, milling flour, hide tanning, alcohol distillation and pounding minerals with giant wooden pestles to produce gunpowder. All of these skills are exhibited at the open-air water power museum before reaching Dimitsana - a worthwhile diversion from the track, though closed on the Tuesday I was passing.

The woods begin to open out and flower meadows appear as you come closer to the village. Waves of spartium, valerian, lilac lettuce flower and poppies glow amid the hum of bees. A series of staircases alongside a gushing water channel takes you past the museum and ever upwards until you pass through the arched lower tiers of the town to emerge on to Dimitsana's main street.

My arrival was less colourful than Anderson's in 1829:

"Demetsana is situated upon a spur of the mountains on the left, running nearly across the ravine, and the deep precipices on almost every side make it one of the strongholds of Greece. As we climbed the steep, the boys came running and shouting towards us, and when we pitched our tent they crowded around and could hardly be persuaded to allow us any retirement. The cause of this eagerness we afterwards learned to be this: our friend Mr King had been in the place some months before, had distributed books among the boys, and promised them others; and the children, seeing us approach in the dress and manner of our friend, naturally

supposed we had brought the books, and their shouts proclaimed our arrival to each other."

At that time, noted Anderson, the village consisted of "about 350 houses generally two stories high and better made than any we had seen in the interior of the Peloponnesus." While the rest of Greece had spent centuries under the Ottoman lash, Dimitsana had received various special privileges by paying a 2,000-piastre annual tax to a Constantinople mosque. Consequently, it was permitted to exist as a kind of tiny republic, electing its own *demogerontes* responsible for governing the populace. The five churches were allowed to ring their bells and it was said that no Turk lived among them. Such unusual autonomy was no doubt a critical element in the village's later role in the revolution.

French traveller Buchon was here around ten years after Anderson and recorded his impressions: "I found in the streets evidence of a great work activity. Everyone seemed to be a craftsman. I stayed for some time in the square waiting for my *konaki*, which was designated for me by the secretary of the municipality."

I had booked my accommodation online in a wonderful converted stone house with a grand arched entrance, an internal courtyard and a balcony overlooking the village to the north, but travellers through the centuries experienced very different practices and standards. In the larger villages during the Turkish occupation, certain larger and better-maintained properties - a *konaki* or *khan* - were designated for traveller use. In smaller villages, the traveller often had to rely on the generosity of locals, which was not always forthcoming. Peter Laurent in the 1820's had some particular trouble: "It was late when we arrived at Scináno [Megalopolis] anxious to find a shelter for the night as it threatened to be so stormy. The behaviour of the inhabitants here gave us no very high opinion of Arcadian hospitality. Not one would receive us under his roof. After having galloped about in vain from hut to hut, pursued by a pack of yelling mastiffs, we at length, partly by threats and partly by entreaties, obtained a lodging at the house of the village papa or priest. Excepting the *pyrgo*, or tower, a "Turkish country house in the village, it was the best and the largest of the houses but we found it a most miserable and dirty hovel."

Giffard had similar problems in the 1830s: "We went from hovel to hovel seeking admission for the night but in vain. I had a bad headache and

from that cause, as well as fatigue, could scarcely keep my seat [on his horse] so that I was little inclined to put a favourable construction, if any could be found, on the inhospitality of Tragoge [Dragogi]. I began to be a little less enthusiastic about Arcadia and I muttered."

Accompanying Turkish guides would sometimes force inhabitants out of their properties under threat of a beating so that travellers could spend the night. This was unpopular and the superiority of some travellers didn't help the situation, as Gell recorded: "No people on earth ever equalled these peasants of Greece in this unwelcoming species of sullen and ill-natured as well as ineffectual spite. Allowing that a Turk may sometimes abuse his power and, entering a cottage in an arbitrary manner might also retire without paying, it can never have happened that a European has rested at any house in the country without leaving the inhabitants the richer for his visit."

The 1894 Baedeker *Guide to Greece* recommends the *khan* of Miltiades just outside Dimitsana, "with tolerable fare at moderate prices," and suggests that, "Good accommodation may also be obtained by means of an introduction at one of the better class houses in the town." Still, the guide warns that such accommodation comes with some challenges:

"The inns, sometimes calling themselves *xenodochía* blur generally content with the humbler title of khans, are usually miserable cottages with a kitchen and one large common sleeping room. Nowadays, some of them also possess a few separate rooms which are, however, destitute of furniture, glass windows and fire places. The traveller must bring his own coverings with him, as the rugs presented him for bedclothes are almost always full of vermin. For a similar reason, a sleeping bag of linen or cotton cloth tying tightly round the neck will add to his comfort."

Traveller Henry Baird stayed in Psofida in the 1850s and wrote, "... we had in the khan not only the discomforts of a windy chamber, but the apprehension of being kept awake all night by a number of sick children under the same roof, all of whom were afflicted with the hooping-cough." Those selfish children!

Dimitsana is arguably one of Arcadia's success stories. Its plentiful accommodation - every second building seems to be a guesthouse - chi-chi souvenir shops, cafes and six or seven restaurants suggest healthy visitor numbers. Like other villages in central Arcadia, it lures walkers, motor

tourists stopping at Olympia, and Greek people seeking a cosy winter vibe. The stone mansions, crooked cobbled alleys and amazing views are highly picturesque.

But Dimitsana has something else. It is a touchstone of Greek nationality and identity. Theodore Kolokotronis recruited fighters and sourced his gunpowder from here. Indeed, The Old Man of the Morea had a house in Dimitsana and arrived in town at the same time as the Frenchman Buchon, intending to spend a month away from the blazing heat of the coast and the plain.

We've already seen the monasteries of Filosofoi and their role in preserving Orthodoxy. In fact, the church was fomenting revolt before the soldiers rose from these valleys. Bishop Ananias Lakedaimonias in the mid-eighteenth century established a cottage industry of gunpowder manufacture in Dimitsana and was murdered when his efforts were discovered. Around the same time, a monk established a library and school/seminary here that would grow to become one of the most important collections in the country. One noted seminary alumnus and son of Dimitsana was the martyred Patriarch of Constantinople Grigorios V. Another was Metropolitan Germanos III of Old Patras, whose famed proclamation of a Greek uprising against the Turks in March 1821 was one of the catalysts for the War of Independence. His Dimitsana house is now an ecclesiastical museum.

The library grew to around 5,000 volumes, including ancient authors, and religious texts. However, Kolokotronis established it as his bullet manufactory during the uprising and used the pages of countless rare books to make cartridges, the projectiles formed from melted metalware collected from the villages. There's a certain metaphorical colour in the idea of Turks being literally killed with pages of Christian liturgy and Orthodox wisdom, but the Greek victory saw only 500 volumes remaining. The figure has now risen to around 35,000 thanks to international donations.

Buchon visited the library in 1840: "It has undoubtedly declined greatly because there is now only one teacher. He received me with the Dimarchus and several papas in the library room. I examined the 800 or 1000 volumes which compose it. There are many good editions [...] There remain two pious manuscripts in Dimitzana: a Gospel book and a prayer book which seemed to me to be from the fifteenth century. A manuscript of the Gospel on vellum which they possessed and which they say is very old was sent to

the public library of Athens."

The library and school changed location in the mid-nineteenth century as detailed in the Baedeker guide: "In the principal square opposite each other are the church of Hagia Kyriaké [Agia Kyriaki] and the imposing new Public School, both buildings presented by a wealthy native of the town resident in Russia [Nikolaos Makris]. The school, which has been reorganised, has regained under the competent management of the priest Hieronymos some of its former renown." Both remain in this quiet corner of the village and can be visited.

Baedeker then effectively summarises the history until almost the turn of the century: "The freedom loving people of Dimitzana were among the most determined participators in the War of Independence. They took a leading part in the massacre at Tripolitza and to the present day they boast that the Turks never set foot in their town. Dimitzana has now little life and many of its houses are in ruins. As in many other of the mountain communities of Arcadia, its inhabitants have become more numerous than the land can maintain and many of them emigrate to Athens and other large towns of Greece or even abroad as traders, cattle dealers or artisans, tinkers or shoemakers."

The population at that time was 2,500 according to Baedeker, compared to around 420 today. Pouqueville offers a shocking further insight from his travels in the last quarter of the eighteenth century: "This part of Arcadia before the disasters of 1770 [the failed Orlov Revolt against the Ottomans] was the most populous of any in the province and it makes one shudder to learn that those who escaped from the sword of the Albanians were sold to the corsairs of Barbary who came into the gulph of Arcadia to partake of the spoils of the Morea." In other words, these villagers were sold as slaves to North African pirates.

However successful Dimitsana has been in recovering some of its glory, that glory remains firmly in the past. Ruins still proliferate beyond the main road and the only people you tend to encounter beyond the cafes are other travellers wandering the streets at random. Houses of illustrious past residents - churchmen, lawyers, soldiers, doctors, merchants, parliamentarians - have in many cases been renovated but stand closed and unused, small plaques informing the visitor who once lived there.

Dimitsana is also an interesting study in the arc of touristic activity. I noticed a slight tension in some of the shops that is characteristic of nascent

tourist locations. The owner has invested time and money in stock, expecting that the imminent horde will gleefully consume expensively packaged figs or honey. If you don't, there's an tacit sense that you're wasting their time. You've failed to fulfill your role.

Maybe I'm being oversensitive, but my first visit to Dimitsana in the late 1990s was different. There was only one shop (the same minimarket as now), very little accommodation and maybe one or two places to eat. When I got off the bus, I was accosted by three old men occupying a bench in the shade at the foot of the photogenic cobbled street. They kept me there for maybe fifteen minutes asking me where I was from, where I was going, and what I thought about Greece. After each question, they stopped me from answering and guessed among themselves what the answer might be. "He looks French ... No, he's German - look at those boots ... No, that pallor is definitely English." When finally I was permitted to reply, they shouted, laughed and slapped each other.

At the *kafenio*, another old man told me that he'd returned to this ancestral village after 40 years working in Australia. He bought me a coffee and offered me a mattress in his house if I couldn't find anywhere to stay for the night.

Dimitsana is not unfriendly to visitors. That's not the case. But I felt a little like a ghost in comparison to my first visit. I drank coffee, ate in a restaurant, bought supplies at the minimarket, had breakfast at the bakery and strolled most of the streets, but I felt transient, incorporeal - occasionally invisible. I represented either income or irrelevance.

I believe this is a natural part of the touristic arc - an early iteration. As places receive greater numbers of visitors at a more consistent rate, they relax and evolve a slicker, sometimes less sincere approach. The income is more assured and business owners learn to deliver whatever imagined concept of Greece visitors are looking for. Alas, a proportion of visitors to Dimitsana and to all of the villages on the trail are walkers who can't afford to load their backpacks with honey or liqueurs or dried figs. I saw a lot of things I wanted to buy but didn't want to carry for the next sixty kilometres.

Dimitsana is older than old Filosofou monastery. Some have associated the village with the Teuthis mentioned by Pausanias as the site of two classical temples. Buchon found many ancient silver and copper coins in the fields around Dimitsana and bought about thirty more from the shops and houses.

Ancient masonry can still be found, as Leake discovered:

"All round the crest of the ridge occupied by the town are the remains of a Hellenic wall, some parts of which are intermixed with the yards and walls and foundations of the private houses; in some places there are several courses of the masonry remaining, which is partly of the third order but contains also some fine massy pieces of the polygonal kind."

If Pausanias' suggestion is correct that Teuthis' inhabitants took part in the Trojan war, its possible some of the old masonry was Mycenaean. At the very least, there were probably structures here in the sixth century BC. Amazingly, the walls documented by Leake are still visible and just as he described them more than 200 years ago. You can find one example if you walk up the famous cobbled street, past the Proselinos guesthouse and onwards. The ancient wall supports the garden of a newer house, though no sign tells the visitor that the large stones have stood here for over two millennia.

All sites in the village are easily visited in an afternoon. The greatest pleasure is perhaps ambling randomly and enjoying the views. I ate rooster in tomato sauce and fried zucchini balls at the restaurant overlooking the village and the valley, treating myself to an ouzo over ice because I'd just walked for seven hours and I deserved it.

The village was subdued after dark, most of the visitors having left. The night smelled of smoke as locals lit fireplaces and woodburners. Until now, I'd walked paths I knew from before. From the next day, everything would be new. The next leg of the trail would take me deep into the western Mainalon mountains: the longest and remotest stretch through thick fir forests. I fell asleep to the clank of sheep bells in the lower village - the most Arcadian of sounds?

5

Dimitsana-Zygovitsi: Dragomen and Dutch Girls

Early travellers didn't venture into the Arcadian countryside alone. This was partly because of the high likelihood of being robbed or murdered, partly because they didn't know the terrain or the paths, and partly because the Ottoman rulers were highly suspicious of letting outsiders stroll at will among the Greeks. Fears of espionage were rife.

William Gell summarised the situation in the 1820s: "The impossibility of obtaining any information on the subject of the internal geography of the country compelled us to commence our journey into the interior of the Morea without acquiring any previous knowledge of the places we were to visit: a misfortune the inconvenience of which I afterwards endeavoured to diminish by the publication of a considerable number of routes."

Peter Laurent described the process of organising a trip under the Turks:

"It is usual for travellers to visit the pasha when they pass through Tripolitzà and to conciliate his friendship by a present of a shawl, a watch, a pair of pistols, or what they prefer above all: a cut glass jug. The Bouiourdou, or passport of the pasha, may thus be easily obtained; it may in some cases be of use because it enables you to obtain horses at the posts and even food gratis. [...] Quitting the palace, the visitor is pursued by a crowd of harpies: dragoman, cook, porter, coffee maker, pipe bearer - all must have a *bakshish* or present, and happy is the visitor if he can escape their pursuit at the expense of three or four Venetian zechins."

Even after the end of Ottoman rule in the Peloponnese, the dragoman remained an important figure in Arcadian travel. Baedeker, as usual, was

full of useful advice:

"Those who are not conversant with modern Greek should not attempt to travel in the interior without a guide. The best and most detailed guidebook cannot supply his place. The most comfortable way of travelling is with a Courier or Dragoman. [...] In return for a fixed inclusive sum of 40-50fr per day for each traveller, the courier takes upon himself the entire cost of the journey. His functions begin when the party leaves the hotel at Athens and end on its return to Athens or arrival at any other point agreed upon. He pays all rail way steamboat or carriage fares, hires the saddle horses and pack horses, provides all meals, including wine coffee etc., secures accommodation for the night, and is generally responsible for the comfort of the travellers under his care."

Such people were generally reliable, as their future work depended on good reports from the foreigners they escorted, though Baedeker does advise, "Half of the sum agreed upon is generally paid to the dragoman in advance to enable him to purchase the necessary stores. The other half should be retained to the end of the journey, its retention sometimes acting as a spur to the inborn Oriental indolence of the Greek." This was travel for the wealthy, as most of the Grand Tourers were. But there was another way described by Baedeker:

"Less exacting travellers, especially those who are young/vigorous, may dispense with the expensive luxury of a courier and content themselves instead with the services of an *agogiates* or ordinary horse boy. They will diminish the expense by one half and at the same time be more independent. They should, however, have some of the modern Greek language and must be prepared to put up with the want of many comforts and conveniences which the ordinary European regards as almost necessities of life. The *agogiates*, except perhaps in Central Greece, generally knows the way as well as a dragoman and, like him, finds quarters for the night. He takes charge of the traveller's

baggage, bringing, if necessary, extra sumpter for this purpose and carries the provisions brought by the travellers."

The highly educated, upper-class gentlemen travellers often found their native guides disagreeable. Here is Anderson in 1830:

"We had employed the same company of muleteers ever since we left Argos, but as the leader of the party was exceedingly profane and had of late been less attentive to our wishes than was becoming, we here dismissed him and his company. The passions of this man kindled and raged like fire among the dry thorns and often made him very unhappy. He was vain and self willed and thought much of his former preeminence when he was captain of a band of klephtes, for the klephtes were wont to glory in their profession. [...] Through the agency of a clerical friend we now procured a company of Demetsanian muleteers, who proved to be more obliging and civil than those from Argos."

Richard Farrer in 1880 had a different sort of problem with his guides:

"The soil being soft and level, the occasion seemed favourable for improving upon our ordinary rate of progress, which on the average might be estimated at two miles an hour, so we urged our steeds into a sort of amble and overtook the advanced guard, who at once began to run in order to retain the lead. The sight of the poor fellows pounding along at the double, burdened with their rifles and greatcoats, was grotesque in the extreme. At last, in sheer pity, we pulled up and pointed out the needlessness of their exertions, but they answered that they had received strict injunctions to precede us. Now, it was exactly this obedience that we were anxious to discourage because the wind was blowing full in our teeth and made us painfully aware of much garlic moving before us so that there was no chance of escaping the infliction except by ourselves getting in front of the nuisance."

There was no doubting, however, the expert local knowledge of the guides. Giffard in the late 1830s became quite lost in heavy snow but his guides employed skills now lost in the age of phone and GPS: "They made the welkin ring with their shouts to find if any one was within hearing, and, after a few trials, were answered by a voice from some distance, which set them right but without our having a glimpse of the informer's person; his direction guided us to a village in one of the wildest spots imaginable. We were obliged to halt when within sight of and not fifty yards distance from the village which our invisible informant had indicated until we could get some one to show us how to reach it; the natural difficulties of the ground with the superincumbent mass of snow rendered it, without such aid, impossible to advance."

It would have been inconceivable to those nineteenth-century travellers that I was now about to venture into the Arcadian mountains alone with just a backpack. I was, in truth, a little apprehensive. When I'd told Thomas at the trail office in Stemnitsa that I was walking alone, his face had flickered with concern. "Have you no friends or family you could walk with?" he'd said. Anything could happen out there. The wolves and bears of Pausanias' time were long extinct, but wild boars were active. I could break an ankle, tumble into a void or be crushed by a rock fall. I could run out of water and stumble disoriented for a few days until I died. I could be mauled by a shepherd's dog.

I had my phone, a printed map and a compass in addition to the plentiful waymarkers. I had a whistle, food, water and a tent. I'd also seen a few other hikers in Dimitsana and it seemed likely that at least one would be on the trail at the same time. Someone would probably stumble on my half-chewed or mangled body should the worse happen.

Four school children were waiting for the early bus when I bought my spanakopita and Greek coffee for an al fresco breakfast looking down the gorge towards Karitaina. One of them ran up to me and shouted "Hello!" I asked him in Greek: "Do you speak English?" "No!" he said and ran back to the others. Would his future lie here in Dimitsana?

The route out of the village runs upward and to the southeast, revealing the best view of Dimitsana atop its hill. The path beyond the streets is initially over soft earth and lichenized rocks leading up to a scrubby landscape. The amount of fresh dung and the clank of bells were the first

indicators of what became very quickly clear: I was leaving town at the same time as a flock going out to pasture.

I saw the dog just after seeing the first straggling sheep. It must have heard me following and was waiting. It barked and I stopped, avoiding eye contact as you're supposed to. What now? I'd only just started the trail and it was blocked by a flock. I knew I wasn't supposed to enter. Was there a shepherd? Or was the dog the only supervisor, as is often the case?

I sat on a rock with the idea that they'd move on within half an hour and I'd be able to go around them. It was frustrating. I didn't want to wait. On the other hand, wasn't I trying to relax and adopt a more tranquil frame of mind? I had my tent - I could stop anywhere, anytime. Maybe this obstacle was just what I needed to learn some patience. I made some notes, sharpening my pencil with a knife, and was obliged to observe the landscape - to be in it rather than merely passing through it. It's too easy to get caught up in where you're going when the point is the bit in between.

Barely five minutes later, the two girls I'd seen get off the bus in Stemnitsa appeared from Dimitsana and saw me sitting on a rock above them. I noticed their brief hesitation. There's a reason women often don't hike alone. Here was some guy who seemed to have been waiting for them, who was now descending to the path as if he'd been waiting for them.

"There's a dog," I said, pointing ahead. "It's better if there are more people to pass it."

I'm not sure they believed me but I shamefully allowed them to take the lead. They were fit-looking Dutch girls and apparently unafraid. Maybe they had dogs at home and were more comfortable than I was. One of them picked up a rock for defence.

The dog was lying across the path: a large but flabby looking Greek sheepdog. It barked half-heartedly, obediently following the hiker-sheepdog script, and stood, but ceded the path to the confidently striding girls. We passed among the reeking sheep, scattering them to higher ground amid bleats and rustling hooves. Then we were free.

"We'll let you go ahead," said the stone-wielding girl, meaning, "We don't want you pursuing us for the next few hours, trying to engage us in creepy conversation, perving at our asses, making us nervous." I felt like a degenerate, but this is the reality for women worldwide. Men are occasionally degenerates. Any woman encountering a man in a remote place immediately imagines the worst. It's an instinct validated by

experience. Just because you're in the middle of nowhere doesn't mean you're safe, as various cases on Spain's Camino de Santiago have shown.

From this point, the majority of people I met on the trail were women. All but one were walking in pairs and all showed that same instant of hesitation, that same nervous pause before passing me where I was making notes or shaking a stone from my shoe or just enjoying the view. Some of them waited a little further along the path for me to pass so they'd know I wasn't still behind them.

So I strode on, faster than I wanted to go, the monopati snaking through a patch of purple-blooming milk thistles that scratched at my pack. The path initially curls back on itself to follow the edge of the Lousios valley I'd ascended the day before, offering higher views into the forested crags. The landscape then changed into something new.

This is a plateau whose overgrown terraces, fallen stone walls and grassy threshing floors reveal its previous agricultural usage. There's a sense of being above everything, a massive arc of blue arc surrounding the wheel-rutted gravel track. Uncultivated fruit and nut trees stand amid meadows of violently purple hairy vetch, poppies, valerian, daisies and pink hawks-beard. A hundred years ago and for probably thousands before that, this land would have supplied much of the villages' food, carried by mule and horse on the same paths I'd been following. In the twenty-first century, the only human activity was hikers.

Zygovitsi is two hours from Dimitsana according to the map. My plan had been to take a leisurely pace and arrive there for lunch. A faded sign along the path had advertised food and drink (with photos as proof) and I was keen to fill up before the long stretch into the heart of Mainalon. But the village appeared after barely an hour of strolling. The tavern was built on the edge of the trail and its female proprietor was leaning over the fence calling to me siren-like: "Coffee, tea, breakfast, Coca-Cola ..."

I've never been a fan of the hard sell but I'd arrived much earlier than anticipated so I decided to at least have a coffee after checking that this was indeed Zygovitsi rather than some intermediate hamlet. It was a tiny place with about thirty buildings, the largest of them an elementary school closed in 1979 and now converted into a cultural heritage museum with local crafts, agricultural implements, traditional costumes and suchlike. I had no idea it existed while I was in the village and information online is scarce.

The village also has four places to stay, contrary to the information in the

map. The Mainalon Trail website also doesn't list all options. Such discrepancies, though potentially confusing, are a sign of the Mainalon Trail's effect in regenerating villages. My map was the 2020 edition, whose description of the route claims various villages have no catering or sleeping facilities when most of them have at least one of those and sometimes both. Evidently, the locals have accepted that there will be a flow of visitors and have responded to the opportunity.

Such was the case with this taverna in Zygovitsi, where I drank my coffee and looked through the menu. I'd have to wait a couple of hours, but my planned breakfast was going to be a lunch. It was, I reflected, another chance to relax. I had nowhere to be other than here. I could have a drink and fill my vision with the wildflower landscape, enjoying the gentle breeze and the silence.

The Dutch girls arrived about ten minutes later and it was a different context. We were in a public place. The owner was also a woman. We got talking. The girls were planning to take a taxi from here to Eláti before walking on to Nimfasia - supposedly the most attractive leg of the trail. They thought the six-hour section from Zygovitsi was probably longer than that and they didn't fancy a slog.

I ordered *gigantes* and *keftedes*: stewed giant beans and meatballs. It was good traditional food that would give me plenty of fuel for the coming section. As I ate, I looked at Zygovitsi, which seemed to be mostly modern or well-restored stone houses. The existence of such villages suggests something vestigial. It wasn't a religious centre for the Byzantines or a military stronghold for the Franks. Its foundation by a single family in the sixteenth century was a distant fact, leaving Zygovitsi on the bank of a history that had changed course. If people still lived here, it was because the land and the property had remained in the same families across generations. Many of the houses were empty, to be occupied only in the summer or on festival days when the descendants of those old farmers would return from Tripoli, Megalopolis and Athens to reopen chambers of static time.

More visitors were now coming thanks to the trail and the village was becoming an archetype: the "Arcadian Village," with its stone houses and its church amid the wildflowers and the wooded peaks. The museum reinforced the construct of a place that still existed but whose activity was mostly in the past. There were few opportunities for future growth except a future that mined the past as an ideal, an idyll. In its heyday, the place

would have been terribly poor by today's standards. Now, it's the kind of village that hikers like me observe over a relaxing drink and think, "I could live here - get away from it all. The silence. The simplicity."

Except I'd had enough after three hours. It was time to move on. I pulled on my pack and decided to see some of the streets before continuing the trail. Within minutes, I was in the village square, a beautiful space - shady, cool - with a church and an aged, spreading plane tree and a stone-built taverna with old men sitting at a wooden table outside. It was a traditional village square, largely unchanged since Kolokotronis came recruiting his personal guard here.

I immediately regretted having eaten at the other place. The food had been fine and the welcome warm, but I realised I'd been entrapped by the Arachne proprietress and her web of coffee, Coca-Cola and cold water. I didn't know there were other options. I would have much preferred to be here in the heart of the village, At least, I could have stopped at both, taking a drink at the village's edge and lunch beneath the plane tree. Or vice versa.

It was too late now. The forest was waiting.

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6

Zygovitsi-Eláti: "Arcadia" and Arcadia

One of the pleasures of the Mainalon Trail is how the scenery constantly changes. The Kermes oak tunnels of the deep Lousios gorge gave way to the large-leaved trees, streams and flower meadows of the upper valley. The scrubby hills outside Dimitsana gave way to the broad-skied agricultural plateau towards Zygovitsi. Now I was entering the highlands.

The route leaving the village soon turned into a dry and stony riverbed that begins its ascent into the firs before joining a gravel road. This brings you to the church of Agios Georgios (St George's), whose rear has a rudimentary picnic area beneath an aged and mossy oak. It's a great place to stop for a picnic or a nap.

The path thereafter continues into a landscape that feels vaguely cataclysmic. The earth is riven, angular and occasionally stripped of foliage where landslides and dramatic erosion have taken bites out of the forest. It looks wild and remote, though the village is just a few minutes behind. You walk along the snaking apex of the gravel heaps with a sense that you've left civilization. This is not the common conception of Arcadia's bucolic idyll. It wasn't what I'd expected.

Many of the earlier travellers to Arcadia felt the same. American Bayard Taylor observed in the 1850s: "One to whom poetry has made the name of Arcadia a golden sound, the key to landscapes of ideal loveliness, skies of perpetual Spring, and a pure and happy race of men, will be bitterly disappointed as he descends from the gusty Parthenian Hills. in this bleak region, surrounded by cold naked mountains, with its rough barbaric Slavonian population and its filthy den of a capital, he will not recognise one feature of the Arcadia of his dreams."

Frenchman Edmond About was there in the same decade and wrote,

"Arcadia, which the poets have so much sung about, is not a landscape for the opera. Forbidding scenery, steep mountains, deep ravines, rapid torrents, few plains no cultivation, this, in a few words, is Arcadia. The Styx, which the natives now call the Black Water is a river of Arcadia so violent so noisy and so terrible that the ancients made it one of the streams of Hell."

Charles Hanson in 1886 discreetly quotes an unnamed English traveller four years earlier rather than say the same: "The next few hours unfold all the hideousness of central Arcadia. True that, on the north, Mount Cylene and other snow capped peaks give a far distance, which leaves nothing to be desired, and that the same may be said of Taygetus on the south, but unless the day be unusually clear, they are invisible, and, in any case, there is no pleasing object in the foreground or middle distance on which the eye can rest. Clouds of dust on the road, marshy flats on either hand, shapeless hills without vegetation, no signs of life but the endless chorus of countless frogs; such is the central Arcadia of today - a bleak, unlovely tableland."

William Gell was more succinct: "The past is possibly the only sense in which we can now speak of Arcadia."

At issue here is the entire cultural heritage of Arcadia. When I'd dreamily observed those snow-dusted peaks from my waterfront café in Nafplio, the name of Arcadia embodied a host of associations and sources whose afterimage I'd absorbed without knowing its provenance. Arcadia is like a Beatles song you think you haven't heard but, on hearing it, realise you've been hearing it all your life: on TV, in film, on the radio. It's a cultural skein, a conceptual foundation.

Arcadia is what, exactly? Sunny dells, sparkling streams, singing shepherds, dancing locals, the trill of panpipes, perpetual summer and a life of ease. An Edenic, perfect place. This is the version that's come down to us - but from where? One of the key sources was Polybius.

Polybius was a Greek historian who lived c. 200- 118 BC and who wrote about the Mediterranean and Near East. Importantly, he was an Arcadian from Megalopolis. His account of the region played on a few essential tropes:

"Everyone is familiarly acquainted with the fact that the Arcadians are the only people among whom boys are by the laws trained from infancy to sing hymns and paeans, in which they celebrate in the traditional fashion the heroes and

gods of their particular towns. They next learn the airs of Philoxenus and Timotheus, and dance with great spirit to the pipers at the yearly Dionysia in the theatres, the boys at the boys' festival, and the young men at what is called the men's festival. Similarly, it is their universal custom, at all festal gatherings and banquets, not to have strangers to make the music, but to produce it themselves, calling on each other in turn for a song. [...] Their young men again practise a military step to the music of the pipe and in regular order of battle, producing elaborate dances, which they display to their fellow-citizens every year in the theatres, at the public charge and expense."

Thus did Polybius help to fix the idea of a carefree, dancing existence. He does, however, add that the people were not solely hedonistic. Their life as agricultural labourers was hard and the winters were tough, so the singing was with "a view of softening and tempering this natural ruggedness and rusticity."

His suggestion that "everyone is familiarly acquainted" with the nature of Arcadia indicates that the region's legends were already well established in poetry and history. The Greek poet Theocritus (c. 300-260 BC) mentions Arcadia in his bucolic poetry with shepherds playing their pipes and singing beautifully in captivating landscapes. Roman poet Virgil (70-19 BC) then used Arcadia as romantic bucolic idyll in his *Eclogues* and *Georgics*, influencing the later Latin poets Calpurnius and Nemesianus to follow the same themes. Greek philosopher and historian Dio Chrysostom (c. 40-115 AD), meanwhile, gives Arcadia as an ideal of the simple pastoral life in his first *Oration on Kingship*.

In the manner of Polybius, however, such ancient writers generally alloyed their praise of beauty with the hardships of mountain life. Only Polybius of the ancient writers had actually seen Arcadia. The others were building on lost sources or a cultural mythology with deep foundations even in 300 BC. They were writing at that early stage of a place and an idea whose truth or origins was entirely unknown to them except as a poetic echo, a historical rumour.

That might have been the end of the Arcadian legend, but Latin and Greek - taught in grammar schools and in universities - remained the

language of intellectuals and the ruling classes long after the ancient civilizations had been absorbed or faded, The Arcadia ideal filtered through the centuries into subsequent drama and poetry. Italian poet Iacopo Sannazaro published his pastoral poem *Arcadia* in 1504 (though written around 1480), influencing European poets such as Philip Sidney and John Milton.

Sir Philip Sidney's *The Countess of Pembroke's Arcadia* (begun around 1570) was a particularly influential pastoral romance invoking all of the idyllic tropes mentioned by the ancients but without the alloying element of wintry hardship. A sample:

"There were hills which garnished their proud heights with stately trees: humble valleys, whose base estate seemed comforted with refreshing of silver rivers: meadows, enamelled with all sorts of eye-pleasing flowers: thickets, which being lined with most pleasant shade, were witnessed so to by the cheerful disposition of many well-tuned birds: each pasture stored with sheep feeding with sober security, while the pretty lambs with bleating oratory craved the dame comfort: here a shepherd's boy piping, as though he should never be old: there a young shepherdess knitting, and withal singing ..."

You get the point. Such saccharinity threatens diabetes in the sensitive reader. Sidney had absorbed the Latin and Greek texts written predominantly by people who had not visited Arcadia but based their knowledge on a cultural inheritance. It was many times removed from whatever Arcadia had looked like, but this was the new Arcadia: the Arcadia that existed solely as a concept. None of the modern poets had been there. Arguably, they had no idea whether it still existed or had existed in any real sense. It was incorporeal and eternal like the Mount Olympus of Zeus and family.

Perhaps the most famous expression of Arcadia in western art is Nicolas Poussin's painting of 1637-38 *Et in Arcadia ego*, sometimes known as *Les bergers d'Arcadie* (the Arcadian shepherds). It shows three muscular shepherds (they're carrying wooden staffs) draped in colourful fabric and gathered around a stone tomb they've discovered amid Arcadia's greenery.

They are showing the tomb to a classically attired female figure who may be another shepherd or who may represent some abstract concept.

The usual interpretation of the picture is that death exists even in the heart of paradise. There is no escape from mortality. Poussin was following the Italian painter Giovanni Francesco Barbieri (Guercino) whose painting of the same name had appeared c. 1618-1622. Guercino's interpretation was more explicit, showing two shepherds discovering a naked skull in the woods.

It was a challenge to the Arcadian archetype, suggesting that the perfect idyll could not be separated from real life. It was, essentially, the same as anywhere else - just prettier. Various artists and critics have since sought to reinterpret the painting, with some noting that the pointing shepherds are indicating not the tomb itself but the shadow of one of them cast on the stone. The shepherd on the right points to the shadow's head while the middle shepherd points to the shadow of his own finger, almost recreating the nearly-joined fingertips of Adam and God on Michelangelo's Sistine Chapel ceiling. Is the focus of the painting - the Ego, the 'I am' - actually the shadow rather than the tomb?

This interpretation has its basis in Roman naturalist Pliny the Elder, whose *Natural History* notes: "As to the Greeks, some say that [painting] was invented at Sicyon, others at Corinth; but they all agree that it originated in tracing lines round the human shadow." Accordingly, the painting is said to represent not the inevitability of death but the triumph of art over death. In this case, the female figure may represent art herself born in the heart of Arcadia. It seems like a bit of a stretch, but the shadow is one of the main differences between this version and an earlier one Poussin painted of the same scene.

Another interpretation focuses on some discrepancies or translation latitude in the Latin title of the painting, which could mean "Even in Arcadia, there am I," "Also in Arcadia am I," or "I, too, was in Arcadia." This has led some critics to infer that the "Ego/I am" is not Death but the nameless dead person in the tomb. Are they speaking from heaven, which is Arcadia? Or are they nostalgically remembering their happy life in Arcadia - a prompt to the viewer to enjoy life's pleasures while they last?

Heavyweight German intellectuals Herder, Schiller and Goethe put the words in the mouth of the painting's viewer. We are the ones reflecting that we are all born of Arcadia: inheritors of Greek civilization and the ideals

represented by the notion of the Arcadian ideal. Yes, we all die, but we came from Arcadia and we return to it. Arcadia is eternal.

Such debates are abstract, but they show the cultural value of Arcadia throughout history. This was the baggage carried by the Grand Tourers when, for the first time in living memory, the educated young men of Europe began to visit the places they'd merely read about in Greek and Latin, using Pausanias as their guide. As we've seen, some of them simply couldn't reconcile the millennia of art with the geography and the conditions in the villages.

Richard Farrer noted that, "The Greek poets never speak of Arcadia as the acme of picturesque beauty, the chosen home of faun and nymph and satyr. Such attributes originate with the Italian poets and not even amongst the earliest of these. Neither did Greek pastoral poetry spring up amid the rustic swains of this country as many persons suppose." It seems he had not read Theocritus, but that poet was an early outlier. Traveller Bayard Taylor was pithier: "But so it is - the *"bella età dell' oro"* of Tasso and Hesiod never existed and never can exist and Arcadia, which is for us the musical name of a beautiful impossibility, signifies no more to the modern Greek than Swampscot or Sheboygan."

Others decided to maintain the blinkers of literature and see what they had come to see. Earl Carnarvon and others were enchanted with Arcadia's forested crags, and here is Pouqueville at the end of the eighteenth century attempting to reconcile what he sees: "Nothing can exceed the beauty of the vallies and finely cultivated fields in Arcadia, notwithstanding the inequality of its soil the height of its mountains, and the number of its lakes pools and marshes. The inhabitants experience nothing but fine weather after the winter season, which often brings abundance of snow."

It was the Irishman Mahaffy,, however, who supplied the clearest synthesis of legendary Arcadia and its reality - due partly to a cultural change in notions of nature as a real place that could be beautiful in a sense other than as a fictional ideal:

"The whole scene is wild and grandiose, far different from the Arcadia of the poets, essentially the Arcadia of history. It is remarkable that the picturesqueness admired when the men of the Renaissance began to study Nature has now passed away with the recovery of a truer taste, and that the

real Arcadia is not less delightful to our minds than was the imaginary one to those of the sixteenth century. It is not very long since the Alps were regarded simply with fear and horror, as hideous wastes of snow hostile to civilisation and to pleasure; rich lawns, well kept forests, orderly agriculture strict form in landscape was the only beauty appreciated. The researches of Friedländer have shown that it is not much more than one hundred years since the delights of wild rugged majestic Nature have become generally appreciated. Arcadia has been fortunate enough to maintain its reputation under these vagaries of aesthetic taste. [...] The gloom of some of the Arcadial gorges is indeed enough to make the human heart dark and sullen. There are two such places known by their waterfalls - the falls of the Styx not far from Megaspelion and the falls of the Neda not far from Bassæ, which are perhaps unique in Europe. Immense forest trees and rich evergreens people the slopes, wherever soil is to be had. Among them stand out bold rocks and the river is hidden if not (as in the case of the Neda) by superposed rocks, at least by such a wealth of vegetation that only its clear fall through the air is visible. But both these wonderful scenes are very far from roads very difficult of access and seldom visited even by the adventurous traveller."

Experiencing the physical reality of Arcadia allowed these travellers to compare and combine it with what they'd read. Some of it certainly seemed idyllic. Some of it, less so. Their collective experience was adding to the concept of Arcadia - still a beautiful and naturally captivating place, but also remote, vulgar, dangerous, primitive. Though a real part of modern Greece, it remained distant and isolated. You could visit, but could you ever really *arrive* in the Arcadia of your mind? Did the place, in fact, require constant reformulation?

That was my process as I moved beyond familiar villages into the dense and unknown forests of Mainalon. The sky now became a fractured web of light glimpsed between countless lichen-patched trunks. Wherever the path skirted a ridge or crested a rise, a vast panorama of repeating peaks and valleys was revealed, every contour spiked with dark-green firs whose new

growth showed as a centimetre of lighter green. No villages were visible. It felt remote.

My plan had been to fill up my water bottles at the Bourniades spring indicated on the map, but it turned out to be an aged concrete structure with a kicked-in iron door, an interior of standing, dust covered water and the merest muddy trickle down the slope. This wasn't safe to drink. Moreover, the sign pointing to it had led me over a loose earth-slide that must have obliterated whatever path had been there. Unbalanced by my pack, I almost went tumbling into the crag and chastised myself for such stupidity as a lone walker. There is a safer, though heavily overgrown access to the spring just a few metres further up the track.

This was a minor problem. I'd planned to camp somewhere in the middle of this section and I needed all of my water bottles full. The next spring on the map was at Koskitsa. If that one was also dry, I might have to go all the way to Eláti: an eight-hour walking day. It wasn't impossible but it wasn't what I'd planned.

I was sitting in the shade of a tree, eating an orange, when an Anglo-Spanish couple came by. We spoke briefly and the woman (Spanish) recommended the Camino de Santiago in winter. A lot of rain but fewer hikers. They were seated when I passed them a little further on and I foresaw three or four more hours of trail leapfrogging unless one of us changed the pace.

A wooden arrow on a tree indicated a πηγή. Some residual knowledge of the language from thirty years previously told me that this meant "source" or "spring." Maybe I could make up for the Bourniades fiasco by filling my bottles off-trail. This variant was a waymarked track south back to Stemnitsa, which, curiously, was now not much further away than my departure village of Zygovitsi. Why not?

This track was different, possibly due to some quirk of its south-facing aspect or the alignment of contours. The trees, rocks, fallen trunks and path were thickly padded with spongy green moss, while a spidery grey moss hung from twigs and branches. It was darker. It seemed that nobody had walked here in a century, though more likely nobody had passed since the snows had so recently thawed. This was primeval forest still emerging from winter. Though clearly marked with red-and-yellow plaques, it felt otherworldly - the kind of dell inhabited in ancient times by dryads. Such nymphs were as old as the landscapes they inhabited. Were they present

even now, undisturbed for centuries, observing this weirdly attired human?

I didn't find a spring. The only indication of one on the map was a single tiny blue drop. Bourniades had at least had a name. I couldn't hear a spring. It was better to go back to the main path rather than walk for longer than necessary.

A descent through the same heavy forest brought me to the surreal Koskitsa plateau. Here, the woods give way to a basin of huge, open flower meadows - wells of light and sky bordered by fir-dense dimness. It was here that I met two women coming from Eláti wearing bear bells. I assumed they were bear bells, having read about such things being used on the long-distance American trails, but they sounded the same as goat bells. Maybe this pair had simply bought some goat bells at a village store and decided to wear them as a novelty, however insane that seemed to me. There were no bears. If anything, the sound might have attracted a savage dog mistaking them for stray sheep. And wasn't it quite irritating walking for five or six days with that ceaseless clanging? Both of them were grinning happily as we passed. Perhaps they were high.

A further surreal element: someone had parked a bus in one of the large meadows. It was so unexpected, so incongruous that I initially assumed I was hallucinating the form of a bus when in fact it was some kind of structure. But as I got closer, it was indeed revealed as a bus, possibly from the 1980s. Had somebody airlifted it here by helicopter? How else could it have appeared in the middle of the Mainalon massif?

I later checked the map and saw that a spidery-thin network of inadequate lumber roads and gravel tracks populated the area. Still, driving a bus along them would have been no easy journey. And why? Had it been some quixotic quest to get off-grid and escape to the middle of nowhere, turning the bus into a kind of caravan? All of the windows were now gone and its wheels had vanished into the earth. I didn't cross the meadow to investigate because in my experience such things tend to be disagreeable up close.

Surrealism aside, the Koskitsa spring I'd pinned my hopes on was even dryer than the Bourniades spring. A trail information placard in Zygovitsi had shown a photo of a hiker kneeling to drink from a gushing spout that emptied into a long concrete trough, but both spout and trough were dust dry. It seemed inconceivable that both sources were dry after weeks of rain and snow. This wasn't July or August. This was May and the beginnings of

spring. A symptom of climate change? These meadows were an ideal, a beautiful place to camp, but I wouldn't be able to pitch my tent until I found a reliable water source, the nearest of which seemed to be 6-8 kilometres further on - almost in Eláti.

I walked on and discovered more unusual activity. An abandoned grey Audi, its windows smashed, its paintwork faded, its tyres flat, stood beside a collapsed structure of wooden supports and polythene. The forest had partially swallowed whatever this had once been. The car and the structure together suggested some element of criminality to my overactive imagination. An old marijuana farm? Most surreal of all: the car had two Audi badges on its front grille, the second one positioned above and slightly over the original one. That's to say, somebody somewhere had purposefully obtained an Audi badge and returned to the forested nothingness of the Koskitsa plateau just to stick it on this car. Explain that. Warped humour? A votive offering to an automotive deity?

Could it be that, to some Greeks, this part of Arcadia is something like Alaska for Americans: remote enough - in concept if not in distance - and unpopulated enough to be a place almost out of the world, where nobody is watching, where strange things happen?

My legs were starting to feel heavy. I was clearly not prepared for the trail, despite a relatively active lifestyle of swimming and cycling at home. The previous day's exertions had left me with stiff knees and aching thighs. Each time I stopped, I began again with a stiff zombie gait until mobility returned. There was a big climb ahead so I sat on a log and ate half a *pastelli* bar, the traditional Greek treat of sesame seeds and honey. Good for short bursts of intense energy. As I crunched, a single cuckoo's call rang through the meadows. My map showed a possible stream in the next valley - somewhere, finally, to replenish the water bottles.

To Eláti: Primitive Myths

I walked on, passing the highest point of the trail: the 1,550m saddle between the Pliovouni and Fragovouni peaks. It's a small, grassy area with wildflowers and a sign but no spectacular views and no indication of such altitude except a breeze whose chill, wintry humidity seemed to come from distant, still snow-capped peaks.

The path re-enters the forest for a long descent amid timeless firs. Moss clogs fallen trunks and dangles from boughs. The earth exhales a rich scent of rotting wood and leaf mulch. Many parts of the path had been excavated by rooting boars. Unseen birds whistled, chirped and twittered. There's no sound of modernity here - no distant car, no passing flight, no power-tool whine. I was maybe only six or eight kilometres from another person but it felt like I was alone in a world unchanged for centuries.

It could have been a forest anywhere in Europe, Russia or North America. It's not as ancient or as lush as Australia's Daintree Rainforest, say. I didn't see any trees as palpably ancient as California's 4,000-year-old bristlecone pines. It's not as remote or as vast as Canada's boreal forest, nor as wild as Bulgaria's wolf-roaming Rhodope Mountains. But it's Arcadia. The name gives it something that none of those other places have: a patina of myth and legend stretching back before documented time. You're walking in a forest like many others but also conceptually unique - a cradle of civilisation.

Ancient tradition suggested that Arcadians were an aboriginal race that shared no commonality with the rest of Greece - literally a distinct ethnic group. Hanson wrote that, "successive tides of Achaean and Dorian conquest passed them by, for their wild hills and primitive villages offered few temptations to an invader. They had never been driven from their ancestral seats and were therefore accustomed, with some show of reason, to consider themselves the most ancient people in Greece. The old Hellenic

historians, in fact, spoke of them as indigenous and believed them to be the representatives of the Pelasgians, who long before the dawn of history, had been the dominant race in Hellas."

Arcadians were seen as primordial people even in ancient times and called themselves *proselinos* - people who had existed before the moon itself. Some ancient Greeks believed that Pelasgus was the first man, a child born of the earth to occupy the land. This was the myth recounted to Pausanias by Arcadians when he visited in the second century AD. Pelasgus, it was said, established the worship of Dodonean Zeus and introduced his people to the earliest forms of civilisation such as fixed huts and animal-hide clothing at a time when agriculture didn't yet formally exist.

Pelasgus's son was the king Lykaon we met in chapter two, who cooked a son and established the city state of Lykosoura, seen by ancient historians as the first city and the model for all that followed. His daughter Kallisto was raped by Zeus - a habit of his - and turned into a bear by Zeus' wife Hera, but not before Zeus managed to rescue his unborn son Arkas, who gave his name to the place and the people.

All of this was hearsay and inherited oral folk history. None of it was written by the Arcadians, perhaps because writing didn't exist at the time of these semi-mythical events. The majority of ancient historians documenting Arcadia's origins were not from there and hadn't visited. Thus was Arcadian identity woven beyond the source from the amorphous, rootless accounts that came out of the mountains and forests.

The stream I'd been hoping to use was just a muddy patch. No running water. I'd have to continue walking almost to Eláti, it seemed, before I'd find any source. This was the kind of walking I'd hoped to avoid: the kind where you're just on autopilot through fatigue or impatience to arrive. I'd rushed the last part of Stemnitsa-Dimitsana because I'd been hungry and had specified a check-in time. Now I was just walking to find water. I hadn't come to Arcadia to tolerate it or rush through it. So I stopped, sat on some moist moss and checked the map. I was close to two springs, though I wasn't optimistic after the previous ones.

Finally, in a twilight forest gully, I came across the Bourboulistra stream, which had a healthy flow of cold, transparent water. I'd have to boil it to be sure, but now I had enough to camp. All I needed was a flat place to pitch my tent - ideally an attractive one that wasn't on private land and that had a

pleasant view.

The track reached the asphalt road going into and out of Eláti. A waymarker plaque pointed to various destinations but somebody - a child? An idiot? - had used a marker to turn the arrow indicating Eláti into a black square, hiding the direction. The route was evident anyway thanks to the metal markers on trees (and the map) but I did wonder what son of mentality would make somebody do this.

A hiker had mentioned in his blog that there was a good place to camp near the Lakoma spring, close to the turn-off for Eláti, and indeed there was a lovely flower meadow in just that spot, bordered by the forest and the road. Unfortunately, it looked like somebody had very recently constructed a chain-link fence around the land. The paint and the plastic looked brand new. Had the owner noticed its popularity among hikers and decided to block access? There was a horse paddock next to the land, also private and fenced.

Dusk was approaching. It had been a long day. My original plan had been to camp somewhere near the saddle mid-route and arrive in Eláti for lunch the next day. The new plan: camp wherever, have breakfast in Eláti and maybe buy a few supplies before continuing for a sumptuous and ludicrously indulgent lunch in Vytina. Alas, I couldn't find a flat spot that was also concealed from the road. If the locals were already suspicious of campers, I didn't want to flout my presence.

I erected the tent and set about cooking my supper: a home-prepared zip-lock-bag of quinoa and dried soya protein chunks with my own blend of curry spices. It wasn't the supper of my dreams, but it was healthy, filling, lightweight and potentially tasty. As it bubbled away, I used the inverted lid of my titanium pot to make an infusion with the mint and thyme leaves I'd picked at Gortys.

I would certainly have been more comfortable in the accommodation in Eláti, but camping was an important part of this trip. It's why I was walking instead of driving, solo instead of in a pair. I wanted to immerse myself wholly in nature wherever possible - not only to pass through the forests but to be inside them in the dead of night and wake to their heavy dews. Cosy accommodation had been a treat at the start and would be again at the end; now, I wanted to sleep as ancient Arcadians may have slept.

There's also a pleasing ritual to the camp: the order of unpacking and repacking, the preparation of sleeping gear - the making and furnishing of

the temporary home. I've always liked the idea of carrying everything you need on your back, the freedom it brings and also the necessity to be prepared.

I'm not a gear freak. I don't obsess over the relative merits of Gore-Tex vs Pertex, Cordura vs rip-stop nylon or whatever. I'm not an ultralight evangelist, sleeping beneath a handkerchief-sized tarp or cutting down a foam mat to cushion just my pelvis because it saves me 21 grams (and eight hours of rest). But forethought has always been the hallmark of the serious traveller.

Godfrey Levinge in the late 1830s offered his readers a long list of suggested travel equipment and provisions, some of which seem surprisingly familiar to the modern hiker:

An English saddle, a thickly padded saddle cloth, and bridle.

An umbrella is requisite not only as a protection from rain but from the sun. For the latter purpose it should be lined or made of double silk.

A straw hat with a wide brim is the best in hot climates.

A green veil or blue spectacles will be found great to protect the eyes from the glare of the sun on white rocks and sand of the desert.

A small carpet is indispensable in countries where there are no chairs.

A hammock is not only useful in ships but to hang under a shed or between trees to sleep in. A small tent that is easily put up should be taken. Some travel is impossible to be comfortable without one.

Take bedsteads of brass or iron.

A mattress spread on the ground and a piece of oil cloth of the same size placed under it to prevent the damp penetrating. The oil cloth thrown over the baggage in the day time affords effectual protection from the rain.

A basin of block tin, a looking glass, tablecloths sheets, towels, a thermometer.

A case of mathematical instruments, a telescope and every thing requisite for scientific pursuits.

Drawing paper, pencils and Indian rubber.

A camp stool.

A measuring tape and a pedometer, which is necessary in countries where distances are not accurately ascertained.

Small lamps are preferable to a supply of wax lights. A gun may be very useful, as well as amusing if the traveller is a sportsman.

At that time, one of the greatest banes of long journeys was the amount of vermin (lice, rats, fleas, mosquitoes) to be found in inns, caravanserais and village homes. "Greece and all parts of the East abound with vermin of every description," wrote Levinge. "No Oriental tourist who has written on these countries ever omitted to relate what miseries he endured from this host of perpetual tormentors." Fortunately, like any experienced traveller, he knew how to improvise and designed a sleeping bag-cum-mosquito-net, whose details he was pleased to share:

"It is constructed in the following manner: the sides and foot of a pair of sheets six feet long are first to be sewn, thus forming a sack. To the mouth of the sack must be sewed a mosquito net of fine strong muslin, at the same time sufficiently thin to admit air, is to be closed at the top with a running string which be tightly tied and then suspended from the ceiling against the wall or fastened to some stick or branch a tree as chance may offer. The sheet pan is then to be spread over the mattress. All of the openings have drawstrings and the sleeper is sealed inside."

Levinge had been where I was - if not the exact spot, then the position of trying to make the best of his travels. I hadn't brought my mathematical instruments or hunting rifle on this occasion, but there were a few items whose use I was gleefully anticipating. I'd already used some of the duct tape wound around my walking poles to seal a bag of lentils bought in Dimitsana. And I'd used the scissors on my new Swiss Army knife (aluminium scales - *very cool*) to trim a part of my insole that was rubbing a heel. In my mind, such activities practically made me Rambo. I also had a needle and thread in case I needed to suture a gaping wound in my arm or a rip in my backpack.

It was a cold night. I estimate the temperature dropped to around seven degrees. My sleeping bag's limit was nine, with a comfort rating of thirteen. Waking periodically according to some preservation instinct, I heard an owl calling from the woods, but otherwise it was pure silence after dark. No cars passed. An almost-full moon cast shadows on the tent fabric. Such nights had been the same for Pelasgus and his race.

I woke around 6.30 am, dawn, to the cuckoo's call. The tent was heavy with dew and condensation. I shook off some of the water but would need to dry it in the sun later if I didn't want to carry a few hundred extra grams to Vytina. My urge was to march directly to Eláti for the imagined spanakopita or four but nothing would be open at this time. I ate some pastelli and brewed some coffee by throwing the grounds directly into the pot - gritty and disappointing, but warm and oddly soothing. The pain in my knees and thighs seemed to have vanished - an effect of that dull but protein-rich supper?

Eláti was barely twenty minutes distant. The path branched in the forest: one way indicating Vytina with a carved wooden plaque and the Mainalon Trail markings, the other up to Eláti. The latter path emerged from the firs into flower meadows and followed a ruined kalderimi past an unfragrant sheepfold (dog obligatory) directly into the village, where I found a gushing stone spring by the church.

This is perhaps the smallest village on the trail: around twenty stone buildings, a café-taverna and a tiny wooden hut selling local honey. Both the hut and the taverna were closed at 8.30 am, suggesting that their existence was dedicated more to passing motor tourists and the occasional hiker than the population of around twenty people. Stemnitsa's bakery had been open and serving customers at 6.30 am.

I didn't see one person in Eláti, though somebody somewhere was cutting wood with a chainsaw. The name of the town in Greek means "firs" and its heritage is wood-cutting/lumber. One of the current residents has earned attention for his artisan woodcarving using the various trees of the region. I decided to wait a while to see if the café opened.

Sitting beside the church, I considered that Eláti was Arcadia while Dimitsana was "Arcadia." A fair comparison? Both are legitimately in Arcadia. Both have their genuine histories. The difference is that Dimitsana has evolved a packaged and branded identity as a particular kind of Arcadian experience. It has accrued a series of now fixed associations:

Kolokotronis, Germanos, the old library, the nearby monasteries. Photos of that curving cobbled street and the views of red rooftops crowning the hill have almost become memes. Eláti, meanwhile, is all but invisible: quietly going about its business in the heart of the forests as it has for centuries.

It's not that Dimitsana is fate or somehow dishonest. Rather, it's become a more polished iteration of what Arcadia means in the twenty-first century. A tourist iteration, perhaps. In high season, there are more visitors than residents, which seemed an unlikely proposition in Eláti.

There's a kind of gazebo on the edge of town looking out over the mountains: varied deciduous trees in the foreground and serried evergreen peaks to the horizon. Eláti is one of the remoter settlements in terms of distance from other villages. It is not on the main road system, which forms a ragged loop around Western Mainalon, linking Alonistena in the east, Vytina to the north, Karkalou and Dimitsana to the west, Stemnitsa and Chrysovitsi in the south.

There was still no sign of life. Lunch in Vytina was calling to me like the sirens' song.

I descended back into the forest and took the left-hand path along the thickly wooded gully of the Mylaon River. This was unlike anything I'd seen so far. The river spilled over small falls and among tumbled rocks, forming black depths along a corridor of firs so thick that barely any sky was visible. Ivy-wound trunks swelled like lurking torsos and branches were lichen daubed. Webby moss dangled from twigs. Glistening green moss upholstered banks, stones and fallen trunks. It was primitive. Like those Stygian dells in the depths of the Lousios gorge and that uncanny offshoot towards Stemnitsa near Zygovitsi, this landscape made me think of Pan.

The god Pan was born of Arcadia: the guardian of flocks, herds, and beehives - a protector of shepherds. Though music loving, gregarious and lusty, he was also partially infernal, occupying the darkest dells and caves. If disturbed in his sleep, his roars spread panic among the forest's fauna and humans. The earliest depictions of Pan on pottery of the fifth century BC show him wholly animal: a prancing goat with long, curved horns playing a double syrinx (panpipes). It is the image shown on the cover of this book but is also recognizable as subsequent depictions of Satan.

The name is said by some to derive from the Greek word ὀπάων (opaon) meaning "companion," though others believe it derives from *paein*,

meaning "to pasture." Both work. Pan was evidently an ancient deity, the only one of the Olympians to retain animal characteristics and very probably an example of humanity's earliest grasping for the divine. Nature and the elements were an unknown and inexplicable force. The untracked forest was vast and dark. It echoed with crashing boughs, erupted occasionally into fire, roared with rockslides and flooded valleys. It harboured bear and wolf and lynx even in Pausanias's time. A god was necessary to accompany humans into that realm, to be their representative amid the unknown. He shared their aesthetic pleasures, but he was also unpredictable, violent, vulgar. Pan was clearly a human projection of an ancient religious instinct: an amalgam of civilization and nature's savagery just as a vaccine is a reduced form of what afflicts you.

Pan's image featured on Arcadian coins of the fourth and fifth centuries BC, while Pausanias in the second century BC found Pan's shrines, altars, caves and sacred mountains still active. Some were as simple as an oak tree with offerings of stones or carved wooden sculptures, but there were also stone sanctuaries featuring colonnades and an oil-lamp eternal flame. The Pan cult would quickly spread from the dark heart of Arcadia across the Greek and Roman worlds as far as modern Israel, with a more humanized form of Pan continuing to represent an intercessor between nature's unpredictability and civilisation's order. Whereas Arcadia had developed formal temples or sanctuaries, the rest of the Mediterranean tended to worship pan in grottos or other liminal places, befitting his status as a nature deity.

I paused in the mossy hollow of that green and shaded Mylaon defile. The river gossiped. The birds sang. The beauty was undercut by the darkness and the promiscuous trunks. It wasn't difficult to imagine I was being watched by the slit caprine eyes of a forest god - accompanying me through his realm.

To Vytina: Ruins and Roads

The forest track emerges into a light and grassy flatland of wildflowers: swelling mounds of brilliant yellow blooms known as basket-of-gold, and hawthorn trees so heavy with white blossom that they appear snowbound. The Mylaon runs through it and natural springs gush from stone façades.

Methydrion hill to the right once held an important ancient town called Methydrium that was still an inhabited village when Pausanias visited. Many of the more remote Arcadian towns were depopulated with the creation of Megalopolis around 370 BC, but Pausanias tells us that, "the Methydrienses, indeed, before they belonged to the Megalopolitans, had their victors in the Olympic games." The place was significant enough to be mentioned by historians such as Thucydides, Xenophon, Polybius and Pliny the Elder and was excavated in 1910. Today, a hamlet of five or six stone houses remain.

Pausanias also tells us that "There is a shrine of Horse Poseidon at Methydrion on the Mylaon" and, in fact, there is a piece of land beside the trail that has been identified as a temple of Poseidon Hippios (Greek Poseidon became Roman Neptune). There's nothing to see today but a fenced-off plot of overgrown, grassy hummocks that might be pieces of masonry consumed by nature. There are no signs and no indication that this was once dedicated to an ancient god, but excavations have shown evidence of an early sixth-century BC temple under the foundations of a limestone Hellenistic temple.

Researchers have attributed it to Poseidon Hippios due to nearby finds of bronze horse-headed dancers - apparent votive offerings. Poseidon was important to the Arcadians as the father of their most worshipped deity, Despoina. The Arcadian myth of her birth has Poseidon lusting after Demeter. To escape from him she changed her form to that of a mare and hid among a herd of other mares grazing in Arcadia. Poseidon transformed

himself into a stallion and caught her. The result of their union was the goddess Despoina (the Mistress) and the horse Arion. Pausanias tells us that this event led to the name 'Horse Poseidon' being used for the first time.

This site, like ancient Gortys, reminds us that Arcadia once had a thriving ancient civilisation. Most of the Grand Tourers were following Pausanias as their travel guide, aiming to visit the principal sites identified by the Greek geographer two millennia before: the temple of Apollo at Bassae, nearby Phigalia, Tegea, and Mantinea. Tegea was mentioned by Homer in the *Iliad* and appears to have been continuously inhabited ever since, even through the fourth-century AD Goth invasions. You can see its excavated ruins in the modern village of Alea on Tripoli's fertile plain. Bassae, meanwhile, is definitely worth a visit if you have a car. It is the best-preserved complete classical temple in Greece along with the Theseum in Athens's ancient agora, but perched on the top of a mountain inside the vast white tent that protects it.

The landscape here by the Mylaon has surely changed little since those ancient villagers came with offerings for Poseidon. The river flows gently by as it has for thousands of years and the flat river basin, with its rich alluvial soil, is still cultivated by farmers. Then, as now, it is a peaceful place: a sanctuary.

Except for one thing: this stretch of road is where dogs had attacked those previous walkers. I could hear the sheep bells in the pen and smell the animals. My poles were extended, ready for onrushing assault. I tried to walk on the gravel road's verge to mask my footsteps. It looked like it would take me right past the sheep, but then the trail rises to the right and circumvents the pen. You don't even see it, though I could hear the shepherd shouting: arguing with someone the whole time I skirted his property.

I barely breathed as I crept past this place I'd feared since I'd read about it in my research, but the path took me further away and I began to realise that I was probably safe. When I emerged from the woods again to arrive at the east-west main road, it was to a vista of Arcadian perfection. The great basin between forested peaks was a paradise of blossoming trees and flower meadows: a lush, benign landscape that was surely what most people imagined when they thought of Arcadia. One could imagine the place in a state of perpetual springtime beneath a faultless blue sky. Birds, bees and the river were the only sounds.

The trail from here to Vytina is supposed to be the most beautiful on the

entire route. I'd thought that difficult to believe after the Lousios gorge and meadows of the Koskitsa basin, but this was a genuinely captivating prospect, as if nature itself had been landscaped as in Edgar Allan Poe's story "The Domain of Arnheim."

The path continues under a road bridge to follow the river and, sure enough, the terrain is exquisite: a monopath along the riverbank in a narrow but gentle cleft with a vastness of blue sky. Transparent water flows almost silently among rocks in the fractured shade of leaves that seem only days old in their pale-green fragility. It is a fairytale scene in the real world and I realised something I'd been grasping to formulate since walking out of Stemnitsa two days earlier.

So much of this trail had stirred a genuine feeling of happiness, wellbeing - joy. The landscapes are so beautiful, so varied, so colourful. It seems that all of the wonder we expect and hope to find in nature - whether in its awe, its drama or its harmonious tranquillity - is here in Arcadia. Each day is a submersion in multiple stimuli: the flowers' perfume and colours, the hum of the bees, the birdsong, the texture of moss and the scent of rotting wood - the chill of flowing springs and the shifts from sun to shade. Is this feeling at the core of what Arcadia has come to signify?

I took off my pack and sat with my naked feet in the river. The vegetation was a wild tangle forming a corridor for the Mylaon without blocking its light. Maybe in summer when the leaves are bigger and darker, this becomes a shadier dell. But in spring, sunlight predominated. I didn't want to move on from the place, whose paradisiacal air was reminiscent of the ancient Greek Elysian Fields: that idyllic landscape after death in which sunny spring is perpetual and life is trouble-free. Homer evoked Elysium in *The Odyssey* and Virgil wrote of it in the *Aeneid*:

In no fix'd place the happy souls reside.
In groves we live, and lie on mossy beds
By crystal streams, that murmur thro' the meads:
But pass yon easy hill, and thence descend;
The path conducts you to your journey's end.
This said, he led them up the mountain's brow,
And shows them all the shining fields below.
They wind the hill, and thro' the blissful meadows go.

It was difficult to leave my Elysian riverbank but the scene became even more idyllic further downstream when the river broadened to plait its way through a flat limestone base patterned with the lacelike shade of oak and plane trees. I wished I could picnic there in that sparkling naiads' playground rather than in Vytina, but the food I had in my pack wasn't adequate to the setting. I'd need a selection of traditional cheeses, sliced sausage, artisanal bread, ripe fruit and a fresh white wine chilled in a Mylaonian pool to do justice to the setting. All I had was half a pastelli bar and more bloody quinoa for the next camp.

I didn't want to leave this part either. I sat in the intricate shade, Arabic text inked on white limestone, and took out my map. The official trail branched right away from the river and up to Vytina, but a variant continued along the Mylaon to a bridge that I hoped would be a stately Ottoman construction. It was an opportunity to stay close to the water and also a mildly thrilling diversion - a minor adventure. I'd feel like I was discovering something.

The slender monopati rises above the river and goes into a narrower part of what will become the deep Mylaon gorge west of Vytina. The foliage closes in and the Zarzi/Zarziou stone bridge seems to materialise through a tangle of leaves, branches and shadows as if it has grown from the landscape rather than been built. I've seen a few Ottoman bridges across Greece, including some of the truly spectacular ones in the north such as the Aga Aziz and Portitsa bridges on the Venetikos river, but this one - smaller, less dramatic - seemed the most magical, nestling in this forested pocket of the Mylaon.

There's one graceful main arch and a higher, smaller one for floodwater. The bridge's path is somewhat dilapidated but you can still walk over the grassy cobbles and peer down. As with many of these stone bridges, it seems to go nowhere and to exist entirely out of context - a disconnected conduit like a door without walls. Yet this was once a highway of empire, the main route between Vytina and Magoulia, trodden for centuries by straggling mule trains, by traders, soldiers, monks, pilgrims, foreign travellers, thieves and fugitives.

These paths referred to as monopatias or kalderimia that today seem nothing more than dirt tracks represent an ancient transport system that has been largely reclaimed by nature. The researcher Yanis Pikoulas has spent almost two decades researching ancient Greek road systems and traces the

origin of Peloponnesian roads to the seventh century BC, some of which remained in use until the fourth or fifth centuries AD. These were not Roman roads. as the Romans had no need of trade or military routes through this territory.

The Mycenaean civilisation (c. 1600-1100 BC) built road systems in the Argolid region, as evidenced by four still-existing 4,000-year-old stone bridges, the most famous of which is the Arkadiko/Kazarma bridge between Tiryns and Epidauros. However, the central and southern Peloponnese had a distinct network of cart roads constructed with a surface of dirt mixed with gravel or potsherds on a bed of soft soil. Inclines, curves and junctions, meanwhile tended to use rockier soil or even to carve cart tracks of a relatively standardised gauge - 0.05m to 0.15m wide and 0.01m to 0.30m deep - directly into the bedrock.

Traveller William Leake saw these in the early nineteenth century and made a note: "MAY 20. Quitting Tripolitzá at 4.10 pm by the Karitena road, I enter the pass of Mount Maenalus or Manalium at the back of the town. At 4.25, see tracks of chariot wheels in the rocks." He must have assumed that they'd been worn by traffic rather than carved by design.

This is to say that cart traffic in the ancient Peloponnese followed a fixed course - what Pikoulas calls a "negative railway" - that included points in the manner of a railway for carts to change tracks at junctions. Since two carts could not use the same track in opposite directions, it appears that there must have been a system of regulation and possibly of permanent watchmen in mountain passes to ensure that two vehicles didn't meet head on. That would require one of the carts to be unloaded and lifted out of the tracks for the other to continue. On the plains, it was easier to carve two parallel tracks.

Classicists will recall the story of Oedipus, who meets his father (unknowingly) at a road junction and kills him after an argument, fulfilling a prophecy and sealing his fate. It seems a hot-headed and exaggerated reaction until we understand that one of these carts was obliged to unload due to a breakdown in the transport system. Who was to blame? Who was going to accede?

This was not an arbitrary or ad hoc road system. It was a state-sanctioned and well-funded infrastructure that entailed laying surfaces, maintaining them and constructing bridges or supporting walls wherever necessary. It was an investment in the future of a civilisation.

For Pikoulas, "the Peloponnesian League, with Sparta as its motivating force, must have been the central authority which created and supervised the cart-road network in the Peloponnese. [...] The reputation of the Spartan army for its ability to cover distances at a remarkable speed and its administrative efficiency owes much to the road-network. I may note that nowadays there is only one highway in Lakonia leading north, to Tripolis-Korinth, whereas ancient Sparta had at least three. Moreover, more than a hundred cart-roads intersected Spartan territory."

Evidence of these roads remains in their stone-carved tracks, but most have been lost, covered or superseded by subsequent road systems of the Middle Ages and beyond. The next great road-building scheme in Arcadia occurred under the Ottomans, from around the mid-fifteenth century to the mid-nineteenth century.

The Ottomans preferred mule-train caravans to carts - arguably a better solution in mountain and forest landscapes. Thus, the Turkish authorities invested considerable time and money in a comprehensive system of stone-paved *kalderimia* of one to two metres in width depending on terrain but generally wide enough for two laden mules to pass each other. Attendant structures such as staircases, retaining walls and bridges were built wherever necessary and the paths followed contour lines if possible, using switchbacks to ascend or descend. In some cases, trees would be planted alongside the path to shade travellers.

Chateaubriand described them at the start of the nineteenth century: "Roads of this kind were denominated ladder roads in Arcadia. I was not able to discover in the Morea either any Greek roads or Roman ways. Turkish causeways two feet and a half broad carry you over low and marshy spots. As there is not a single wheel carriage in this part of the Peloponnese, these causeways are sufficient for the asses of the peasants and the horses of the soldiery."

The style of stonework varied according to the administrative region and according to the stone available. Approaching Dimitsana, you find large, rounded stones with intermittent steps spanning the whole path. In the initial stretch out of Stemnitsa, the stonework is flatter and more like paving. In the north of Greece, some Epirot *kalderimia* are made with flat stones bedded vertically with a kind of corrugated surface that would work well in ice and snow.

As with those Spartan roads, the Ottomans were building for the future

of an empire. Their bridges still stand and are crossable. Landslides, floods, subsidence, abandonment and cannibalisation of the stone have seen many kalderimia vanish, but much of the Mainalon Trail follows these antique routes even if the stones have disappeared underfoot. You know it's an Ottoman kalderimi when the path crosses an arched bridge, when a wall supports the track below or to the side, or when a tunnel of trees joins overhead.

Not all travellers saw the charm. Thomas Trant experienced Arcadia's kalderimia in the 1830s and observed:

"The road, if such it could be called, was the worst, without exception, that I had ever passed. It was a mere sheep track and, having never been cleared from either the shrubs or rocks which encumbered it, could only have been traversed by the little ponies on which we were mounted. [...] A person unaccustomed to mountain scenery would have viewed the road we crossed this day with a pardonable degree of alarm, as one false step might have hurled him down a steep declivity of several hundred feet."

Farrer, meanwhile, identified a weakness of kalderimia necessarily carved into a steep incline:

"Progress is necessarily slow, the road being formed of bare rock and following the picturesque, though scarcely convenient windings of the mountains. Once in the open, we encountered a peasant with a long train of pack beasts. A deadlock appeared imminent as there was no possibility of passing and neither party seemed anxious to retreat. Moreover, a sudden disagreement between one of our horses and one of the enemy's mules promised to land both those animals several hundred feet below the level whereon they then stood. Luckily, our escort came forward and, having succeeded in convincing the obstructionist that he was in the wrong, assisted him to retire backwards with his train into a spot sufficiently wide to admit of our passing."

Many of these paths fell out of use in the 1970s, when gravel roads were driven into the mountains to accommodate greater use of agricultural vehicles. The gravel roads are often much longer as they switch back and forth to handle inclines and the Mainalon Trail constantly crosses or follows them. In a curious twist of history, however, the accounts of these early travellers have been instrumental in helping to create not only the Mainalon Trail but also the series of connected Peloponnesian trails unveiled in May 2025 that encompass around 1,700km of hiking options.

The Hermes Trail, the Hercules Trail, the Pan Trail and the Sparta Trail, among others, have been championed by the same man behind the Mainalon Trail, Ioannis Lagos. Identifying these routes has been a combination of local knowledge (often shepherds) and the accounts of the Grand Tourers, who were the first and only ones to record detailed itineraries of the routes they took between ancient sites. Their books and maps were the first time in many centuries that anyone had attempted to follow and connect the wider series of ancient pathways. In their attempts to act as historical cartographers, they became the progenitors of the modern hiker.

Consider it: today's walker with her high-tech footwear, aluminium or carbon-fibre poles and durable synthetic backpack is tracing routes that Alexander the Great, Pausanias, Theodore Kolokotronis, European Grand Tourers and thousands of other nameless people have trodden through three thousand years of history or more. They came with bronze-horse offerings to placate a god of horses; they waited in ambush to rob and murder; they led their herds under the protection of a Boat god.

This silent bridge above the whispering Mylaon connected people and places during multiple lifetimes and will stand here still when we are gone - more anonymous travellers whose footsteps passed briefly and continue no more.

I got briefly lost as I continued to Vytina. The path reached a three-way junction whose markings didn't make clear which way the town was. I started on two of them without seeing any markers. Finally, I got out my map, oriented it with my compass and realised that the correct direction was straight to the Nimfasia-Vytina main road.

As I emerged from this track, a quartet of German walkers was descending out of Vytina on their way to Nimfasia. They saw me huffing and sweating out of the bush and one of the women said to the others "*Das*

ist der trail?" Their bearded leader scoffed authoritatively that it was certainly not the official trail as marked on his GPS route and that I was probably lost (I understood the tone if not the words) and they strode purposefully on. I smiled. I'd seen the Zarziou bridge and they hadn't!

Vytina arrived like culture shock: a large square surrounded by shops, tavernas and cafes, parked cars, moving traffic and even a bank! I felt exposed as I entered the town, telescoping my walking poles to appear less conspicuous and feeling the eyes of café proprietors luring me towards their terraces. My first priority, however, was to replenish supplies so I continued past the shops selling honey, walking poles, carved wooden bowls and woven folk art to a small store whose proprietress was dressed and coiffed as immaculately as if she had a starring role in 1980's soap opera *Dynasty*.

It was still only 12.30 - early for lunch. Nobody was eating in the tavernas. But I was hungry for Greek food after the meagre sustenance of my camp kitchen. I chose a place down a side street whose sea of laid tables seemed to be awaiting an imminent invasion of diners. Was it too early for lunch? I asked.

They were expecting a school group of 100 within the next hour but they could grill something if I didn't mind eating inside. How about half a chicken, some fried potatoes and a Greek salad? A bottle of ice-cold Alfa beer? Deal!

I sat next to the kitchen and listened to the family have a screaming match as they prepared my food. Somebody had done something wrong and the operatic recriminations saw women leaving the stage in tears or muttering oaths, pacing the dining room to recharge and returning to the drama. I imagined my meal arriving with a bloodied human ear or finger on the plate, but it was perfect, generous and extremity-free.

I ate too quickly as usual. Everything was so good. I'd already eaten all of the bread, pressing it into the salad's liquid profundities, before the hot food came. No other diners arrived and I'd paid before three motorcyclists pulled up looking for a place to eat. My plan: waddle bloatedly to the square to soak in Vytina's atmosphere and an ouzo over ice.

The café, too, was empty. It was low season for this large village that thrives as an accommodation hub for the nearby Mainalon Ski Centre - the closest ski centre to Athens and therefore very popular in winter. Walking, mountain biking and horse-riding attract a more international but less numerous clientele.

The touristic profile is relatively recent. As with many of the Mainalon villages, agriculture was the main activity for centuries. Vytina's setting and altitude of around 1,033m also made it a healing centre with two sanatoria dedicated to respiratory diseases. Mass depopulation left the town virtually empty after the Second World War but it's now thriving in a way that other Arcadian villages are not. Dimitsana rests on its heritage and exists as a vestige, a living museum; Zygovitsi and Eláti continue much as they have for centuries, broadly ignoring the outside world. But Vytina has rebranded and embraced the "mountain culture" vibe that Dimitsana is still tentatively exploring.

The village is notably stone-built, though few of the houses seem to be older, renovated structures. Rather, the stone and stone cladding is a feature of the mountain brand along with wooden beams and carved wooden business signage. It's partially a stage set, but it works. There's genuine life and activity here. There are cocky youths with stupid hair and loud motorbikes. Three buses pass through as I sip my ouzo, two of them containing a hundred students, who pour chattering along the street like a flood permitted by Poseidon Hippios.

Here was another face of Arcadia - something akin to the Scottish Highlands, the Spanish Pyrenees or Italy's Dolomite villages. A classic mountain escape destination. "Traditional." Rooster stewed in red sauce was on a lot of menus: a shibboleth of the rustic kitchen that Athenians and Corinthians can talk about when they return. "Oh, yes - I had the rooster. Very traditional. You really only get it in the mountains" etc. I'd had it in Dimitsana. It had been tough and less tasty than chicken.

I didn't dislike Vytina. Nor did it care whether I liked it or not. It was doing very well without my presence or opinion. But I did miss the trail's tranquillity. I'd got my supplies, filled my stomach and enjoyed my ouzo, which had been served with a generous small plate containing green olives, local cheese and rolled ham slices. It was time to move on to tiny Nimfasia, which had no sleeping or catering facilities according to my map and, apparently, no sources of spring water along the way. I'd have to carry a lot.

Vytina-Nimfasia: Sounds and Shepherds

The trail descends out of town, passing the place where I'd emerged before lunch and continuing past Old Vytina, which is now just a handful of houses. The track begins on a well- preserved Ottoman kalderimi whose original shape and paving is still well delineated. It later turns into narrow earthen paths above the river valley and this is where I got lost.

The profusion of monopatia in this area was confusing and the brief absence of waymarkers was momentarily distracting. The principal path seemed to go straight ahead, with the Mylaon river far below to my left and a horizon of bald, stony mountains ahead. However, the continued absence of waymarkers showed that this wasn't the route. I had to go back to the last one I'd seen to start again. A yellow marker seemed to show the way, but a quirk of the Mainalon Trail is that its markers change colour three times: red/orange from Stemnitsa to the middle of the track between Dimitsana and Eláti, yellow from there until Vytina, then green from Vytina to Langadia. Was this yellow marker a different route?

In fact, it was a one-off and the others thereafter were green. The route descends into a valley of blossoming trees among which the throb of bees is intense. This is a noted honey-producing region and the bees must number in the millions. The air vibrates with their noise, though they are mostly invisible. Much further ahead and far below, a tiny, red-roofed structure stands alone in the forest. A picnic site? A monastic building?

A stone in my shoe obliged me to stop by a large rock to remove and I used this as an excuse simply to sit and listen. The thought gave me pause. Did I need an excuse to stop? I should have been stopping more often to do exactly this: breathe, smell, observe, feel. It's why I came. I wasn't walking to Nimfasia; I was walking in Arcadia. It was only 2.00 pm and the next

village was only an estimated two hours away. I didn't want to set up my tent hours before dusk - I needed to make the most of my time.

So I wrote notes, sharpening my pencil with a blade like Rambo. I did a little more surgery on my shoes' insoles. I listened to the Mylaon rushing unseen in its impassable gorge. I brushed my teeth, staring at distant peaks rather than at myself in a mirror. Nobody else was on the trail.

The red-roofed structure I'd seen from afar turned out to be a picnic shelter on a narrow ridge between two valleys. To the west is a terrifyingly vertical drop to the Mylaon, whose waters are too deep to see in the precipitous and overgrown chasm. To the east is the humming and fragrant valley I was going to skirt.

After the hot stillness of the descent, the air was brisk and refreshing at this panoramic spot. I lay in the shade along the wooden picnic bench, my shoeless feet elevated, and I pondered whether I should camp here even though nightfall was more than six hours away. The most attractive camping spots seemed to appear too soon or too late.

As I dawdled without purpose or guilt, a middle-aged German couple passed. The guy wore a small backpack and form-fitting activewear, but the woman looked like she'd dressed for a quick trip to the supermarket: white cotton shorts and a strappy top that left all other shoulders and arms exposed. She was red and sweating. No hat. They nodded a greeting, spent thirty seconds looking at the view and continued puffing up the trail, the guy a few metres in front.

The onward path rises sharply through some out-of-control undergrowth to a flowery bank, where I extended my still-damp tent to dry. A pair of German girls approached as I was placing stones to stop it blowing away - again the flicker of hesitation on finding a lone man being weird on the trail - and I indicated that the path went down to where the Mylaon showed as a thin blue strip through miniature trees. The tiny fleck of something pale there promised to be another antique bridge.

Often, the only sounds on the trail are the birds, the bees, the wind in the trees, running water. The most oppressive intrusion is the crunch of your boots or the clink of a walking pole on stone. Those eighteenth- and nineteenth-century travellers were never alone on the road. They had their dragoman, their cook, their agogiates and their attendants. They were accompanied by the constant clop of hooves and the dragoman's shouted orders to keep up, to hurry up. Still, that style of travel had its charms and is

now lost in Europe. Here's François-René de Chateaubriand writing in 1806-7:

"The sun scorched us. From some thinly scattered and parched bushes were suspended grasshoppers, which were silent at our approach but renewed their chirping as soon as we had passed. Nothing was to be heard but this monotonous sound, the trampling of our horses and the plaintive notes of our guide. When a Greek postillion mounts his horse, he begins a song, which he continues till the end of the journey. It almost always consists of a long story in rhyme with which the descendants of Linus beguile the tedious hours. The stanzas are numerous, the tune melancholy and very much like the airs of our old French ballads. Were these tunes introduced into the Morea by the Venetians or did the French, excelling in the ballad, happen to chime in with the genius of the Greeks? Were these tunes ancient? [...] I can still fancy that I hear the songs of my unfortunate guides in the night, in the daytime, at sunrise, at sunset, in the solitudes of Arcadia ..."

The Tzavarenas Ottoman bridge appears head-on. That is, the path meets it as if you're going to cross and continue, but there's no path on the other side. It's another phantom kalderimi lost through abandonment. The sturdy arch sits amid mossy-trunked plane and oak trees over the Mylaon's placid pools, arboreal shade patterns camouflaging the masonry so that the structure blends into the landscape as the other bridges have. There's really something magical about these structures, which, in a city, would be registered and protected, labelled and listed in guidebooks, perhaps with a visitors centre. Here in Arcadia, among the bees, they simply exist.

I left my pack under the arch and rinsed some clothes (no detergent), draping them from oak branches to dry. The bank is grassy and the Mylaon runs almost silently around lichenized rocks. A broad flower meadow to the east of the river is a perfect place to camp, but the chill of the previous night made me think it might not be advisable to pitch my tent. The humidity and dew would be considerable. Again, I'd have to leave a picturesque campsite hoping something better would appear.

The path continues along the right bank almost at water level among the brilliant greenery of spring growth. Alas, the idyll soon turns into the longest and steepest ascent of the trail (so far) on a track that barely continues straight for a few metres at a time. Each turn promises some alleviation, some brief horizontal respite, but the climb continues mercilessly. Left: up. Right: up. Straight: up. The shirt I just rinsed was wet again with perspiration. There wasn't a square centimetre of level ground on which to put a tent.

When finally I reached a level stretch, I was beside a minor gravel road, almost in Nimfasia. The good news was that I'd spent so much of the day in pleasant distraction that it was time to think about supper. A relatively flat area in an oak-tree clearing was less attractive than the meadow by the bridge, but adequate. Parts of it had been rooted up by wild boars, though their activity didn't seem recent. I'm not too concerned about boars, even if one did rip the corner off my tent in Corsica because I'd left an apple there. I'd learned to hang food in a nearby tree overnight.

Tent up and supper eaten, I sat on a stone as the forest darkened. The previous night near Eláti, and at various times along the trail, I'd experienced a strange phenomenon provoked by Arcadia's intense and unaccustomed silence. Away from modernity's ceaseless noise, hearing becomes more attuned, more analytical, more interpretative.

A roosting bird's wingflutter sounds like a horse's nicker. Other birdcalls, a distant dog bark, a car engine or invisible plane sound like scraps of human speech: disconnected syllables brought ragged on the breeze through fracturing branches. My own rumbling viscera occasionally made me stop breathing and investigate the night in search of some additional inchoate phoneme. Was this an ancient instinct?

I'd imagined this trip as an opportunity to "centre" myself to tune out the existential noise, the responsibilities, the counterfeit concerns. I expected that I'd somehow identify and purify a core, distilling my sense of self into an essence of what really mattered. Instead, the opposite was occurring. The compressed core was expanding to the horizon, reaching into the woods, searching the air for smells and sounds and signs. The walking self was not essence but diffusion.

That feeling of wellbeing and joy I'd experienced barely out of Stemnitsa and since was more than just mere aesthetic pleasure. Descending into a

valley or a gorge, feeling the landscape fold around you and entering tunnels of undergrowth creates a sense of security. You can't be seen among the shadows. Similarly, ascending a ridge or approaching a cliff edge puts you in a position of dominance. You survey the landscape, you orient yourself - but you are also protected from the surprise approach of anyone. High and low are advantageous states. We are arguably less comfortable on a wide-open plain, visible to all but with nowhere to go.

I'd smiled at those men wearing camouflage in Stemnitsa village square. It had seemed like an affectation. Now I appreciated that their clothing helped them to be a part of the landscape rather than impositions on it. They didn't need to hide, but they did need to blend in. Maybe it wasn't even a conscious decision; they were just more comfortable and more assimilated in the camouflage gear.

This relation with nature was human existence for countless millennia before the Neolithic Revolution of c. 10,000 years ago, after the last ice age, when people began to domesticate animals, plant crops and live in permanent settlements. Our instincts were more animal. We were hunters and gatherers whose survival depended on symbiosis with and a deep understanding of nature.

Such impulses haven't simply vanished from our biology. In the same way that a kitten displays hunting behaviour, or the way a fish immediately knows how to swim, or how a bird will sing without ever hearing other birds, we retain that sense of being animals in nature. In some small way, I was exhibiting similar traits as those ancient humans. Hadn't I collected leaves to make infusions? Hadn't I bottled water from natural sources? Wasn't I scanning landscapes, constantly alert for the trace of a track or a place to camp? Hadn't I washed in rivers, slept according to the patterns of the sun and carried on my back what I needed to subsist? I realised that I could remember each spot on the trail where I'd been briefly lost and which route was the correct one. I wouldn't make the same errors again. I remembered where I had picked bay leaves, mint, thyme - which springs were active and which not. I was actively but instinctively mapping my environment so that I could pass through it again with more knowledge. I also smelled quite Neanderthal.

I'd camped very close to the village again. After packing up my condensation-heavy tent and leaving the campsite as I'd found it, I needed barely twenty minutes to walk into Nimfasia: a scattered settlement that's

grown around a traditional core. Many of the houses are modern concrete structures rather than the renovated stone houses that predominate in other small Arcadian villages. It seems prosperous without giving much clue why, though the amount of traffic at 7.30 am - mostly beat-up trucks and 4x4s - suggested an agricultural economy.

The stone-paved central square is delightful, its spreading plane and chestnut trees providing shade. A gazebo looked like the kind of place that'd be full of convivial locals during the holidays, and an adjacent taverna had tables waiting for diners - though closed at that early hour. Apart from the brief flurry of traffic, there was nothing happening and nobody walking the streets. I felt like a ghost haunting the place.

The travellers of the past had diverse experiences on entering Arcadian villages. William Gell wrote:

"Our [mule] train was by this time become so numerous as to occasion a sensation wherever we went in unfrequented districts, and we afterwards heard ourselves described as one great milord who went about seeing the world with immense riches, a janissary, ten horses and a dragoman. The people of the village assembled at our door to catch a sight of the strangers, none of them having, in all probability, ever seen a Frank or European dress before. We permitted them to gratify their curiosity till our repast was ready, when Mustapha dispersed them using the expression 'Sirrahs! Dogs out of the house!' without the smallest ceremony."

Giffard initially had difficulty securing accommodation but eventually found himself in the home of villagers where he:

"soon experienced something like comfort, ensconced on one side of a large fire hearth, the other being occupied by the family consisting of grandmother, husband and wife, wife's brothers and sisters, and the children of the house - in all about fifteen. The grandmother enacted the part of wet nurse to all the younger branches when they were uproarious, from the age of five years downwards.

"The eldest sister wore her long black hair down the

back, interlaced with strings of pieces of silver. In addition to this and a long necklace, she had a silver band round her throat, which she allowed Mr Newton to take off and examine in gratitude for some little coins presented to the little squaller in her lap. It was curious and not inelegant. A very handsome zone of plates of embossed silver overlapping each other confined her waist. This was the only pretty Greek girl of the lower orders that it was our fortune to meet. They were generally, in our estimation, very plain and seem to have resigned their share of beauty to the men who are I think I may say the handsomest race I have ever seen. Their beauty is not of the countenance alone but likewise of the figure, which exhibits proportions such as we admire in the works of their ancient statuary and is endowed with the greatest suppleness and agility. It would really be almost as difficult to find a plain man as a pretty woman."

Peter Laurent was another obliged to accept accommodation where he could find it:

"In one corner of a long dark apartment, without a chimney, and the only one in the house, were seen six Greek labourers squatting round a wood fire, the smoke of which added to the already jetty blackness of the roof: from the joists hung many skins now exhaling an insupportable smell and drying to make wine casks. The only articles of furniture were a brass pot and a fire shovel; with this latter, the mistress of the house was scraping the embers from the top of a maize cake, which was cooking under the ashes, and after our arrival was placed on the floor and divided steaming and doughy among the men only; for here, as among the ancients, the females eat separately. In this place, we spread our beds and passed a restless night, almost devoured by vermin of different descriptions and disturbed by the snoring of seven or eight Arcadian peasants who were strewed about

on the floor in all parts of the room, the common dormitory of the cattle and the family."

Historians and poets since Polybius had created an image of Arcadia as a carefree, music-filled place with perpetually dancing and probably attractive people. It was this version the foreign travellers were implicitly, if unrealistically, seeking. Nineteenth-century Englishmen in particular tended to highly praise the beauty of Greek men while denigrating the women, but the general reaction to living Arcadians was usually disappointment. One traveller reported locals sitting in the sun contentedly picking vermin out of each other's hair like apes.

More than any other Arcadian archetype, the piping shepherd was the figure most travellers expected and hoped to meet - ideally reciting epic verse among his snow-white sheep. I'd met shepherds at various times in Arcadia and they hadn't been poetry reciters. They'd been dishevelled and vaguely deranged looking older men in shabby clothing. Back in the 1990s, I'd offered one of these a drink from my water bottle, which was aluminium and looked a little like the metal jugs traditionally used to serve homemade or barrel wine in restaurants. He'd sniffed the opening and handed it back to me on realising it was water.

Just outside Dimitsana on this trip, I'd heard but not seen a shepherd with his flock. His shouts, trills and whistles were clearly some kind of communication with the sheep or with his dog and I wondered if it was a system passed down since the days of Polybius. But flocks were not as plentiful as I'd expected nor, it seemed, as common as they were in the nineteenth century. William Gregg in the 1830s had written: "Wherever the mountains afforded sufficient pasturage, large flocks of sheep, almost the sole wealth of the Arcadians, were feeding along their sides."

Were these animals under the care of Polybius' piping poets? Thomas Trant, as we might by now expect, was frank in his appraisal:

"Several villages were visible on the slopes of the hills around, and the plain was covered with flocks of sheep tended by rustics bearing the true pastoral crook in their hands. This, then, was a real Arcadian scene, but how different from what the poets describe. Instead of being covered with shady forests and watered by murmuring rills,

the mountains were bare, parched and rocky the plain in lieu of a verdant turf enamelled with anemones and daisies barely afforded a scanty and withered herbage for the sheep which were browsing around, and the shepherds, who ought to have been seated under some majestic tree playing the flageolet to their coy and beautiful shepherdesses, were ugly, miserable wretches clad in sheepskins and so bronzed by the sun and by dirt as to resemble in complexion the tints of an Ethiop. Thus, at every step a stranger makes in Greece, the veil of romance is forcibly rent from his eyes; all that in childhood he read of as grand and imposing gradually fades in his estimation, the delightful fictions of the poets after playing upon his imagination for years are suddenly denuded of their charms and exposed in all their deformity, and the visions of goddesses, demi-gods and heroes of former ages, becoming gradually less distinct, are at last if not forgotten, divested of the romantic mystery which hung over them, and degraded by comparison with what exists in the present day."

It's significant that the language of the literary Arcadian ideal has seeped into Trant's assessment. His striking image of "verdant turf enamelled with anemones and daisies" draws on Philip Sidney's "enamelled with all sorts of eye-pleasing flowers." Trant does admit, however: "Though uncouth and brutal in his manners, the shepherd who calmly looks on whilst his enormous dog is tearing you to pieces will gladly offer what hospitality his hut can afford to the weary traveller who seeks admittance, for hospitality is a virtue which generally is to be found amongst people in a savage state. But his churlish manner and uncivilized habits render him the fit representative not of those Arcadians of whom the poets have sung."

Other travellers were persistent in their willingness to believe the legend regardless of the reality. The Earl of Carnarvon in 1868 wrote:

"A young Arcadian shepherd with very handsome features and great natural grace of manner, he wore the *fustanella* and red gaiters, a long shaggy coat of wool, which, however, did not conceal the embroidered edges of a white vest, and a

figured cotton handkerchief bound round a tasselled fez. In his belt, he carried a knife, in his hand a long shepherd's crook. Altogether, he was a very picturesque being."

Giffard in the 1830s went further:

"Shepherd's pipes and garlanded crooks I had hitherto thought of as the mere official appurtenances of a pastoral poem, and the rustic's answer to the sentimental lady's inquiry where his pipe was, that he had left it at home cause he had no baccy, seemed very natural and probable; but here in Arcadia, on the very territory of Pan himself, we heard and saw the pipes and crooks actually in use ..."

We find the quest for Arcadia between Trant's measured cynicism and Carnarvon's idealizing urge. Both arrived with a detailed superstructure of expectation that would be proved, modified or ignored when faced with reality. A footnote in Carnarvon's book adds an interesting spin:

"It is curious to observe how rarely travellers of the most unimpeachable truthfulness agree as to the number of columns or trees or similar objects when it is a question of mere counting. No two travellers of authority out of the many who have written on Syria have, so far as I am aware, been able to agree upon the actual number of the old cedars still left standing in the Lebanon above Baalbec."

What many of these travellers didn't realise was that the Arcadian shepherd had, for many intervening centuries, more likely been Albanian. These people migrated south into Greece from the fourteenth century onwards, many of them ending up in Arcadia during the reign of Theodore I Palaiologos (c. 1355-1407). They tended to live a nomadic, pastoral life that was still in evidence when Bernard Randolph visited in 1689:

"The Province of Arcadia is all surrounded with mountains, most of which are covered with woods. Yearly, they bum the grass and briars to clear the ground against the spring, then very good pasture grows up in its stead. There hath been

many villages, some have been cities, but now the Albaneses (who are the shepherds and three times the number as the Turks and Greeks which are in these parts) live most in tents, removing their tents and herds according to the season of the year. In the summertime, they are up in the mountains and in the winter they are in the woods by the seaside."

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Nimfasia-Magouliana: Sanctuaries and Soldiers

There was really no reason for me to stay in Nimfasia so I walked out of town to continue the trail, passing a fire station where the young firemen were smoking as they hosed down the forecourt and antique-looking engines. After passing a couple of large stone churches and the village cemetery, I was in the countryside amid the smells of unseen sheep, horses and cows. It's a different landscape again: almost English with its benign deciduous valley, its grassy verges, gravel track and open sky.

The path branches off the road into a more familiar terrain of close Kermes oak, ivy-choked plane trees, lichen and moss: another kalderimi descending once again to the Mylaon. You turn a corner and another old bridge sits before you, spanning a narrow gorge. The foliage is so dense and twisted that it's difficult to see the stonework - a fantasy-like nook whose ancient oaks and planes have woven the bridge into their embrace over centuries. Ivy drapes it; leaves carpet it. The river curls through limestone convolutions below, only partially visible as deep-green pools or patches of rippled sky reflections through the rock. It would be only mildly surprising to glimpse dryads and naiads sporting in this verdant twilight, or to encounter Pan's grinning face between the leaves.

The bridge is not Ottoman, though it may replace an earlier Turkish structure. It's dated to the beginning of the nineteenth century and was built to access the Panagia Kernitsas monastery. This renowned establishment was founded in 1386 on the edge of a dramatic precipice, as so many Greek monasteries are. Why? We might imagine the reason is to be closer to God, to enjoy the silence of altitude, or to provoke awe in nature, but the reasons were often more practical. Arcadia's wild setting made it a lawless place; a high, inaccessible setting made a monastery's treasures safer.

This monastery, like many others, played a role in the revolution. It was apparently a secret school during the Ottoman occupation, keeping the Greek language and Orthodox religion alive. Once the uprising began in 1821, it became a refuge for the freedom fighters and reportedly a sanctuary for Kolokotronis' own family. Ibrahim Pasha set fire to the place twice in reprisals for aiding the revolutionaries and its treasures were looted or destroyed.

The path up to the monastery from the bridge is steep and had been comprehensively rooted by a large number of wild boars the night before. In no time, you're out into the sunlight and among the stone-paved holy precincts: stone fountains, small plots of land given to vegetable cultivation, chicken coops. A convent since 1940, the place appears completely new and pristine, painted in various pastel shades and heavily renovated with donations.

Nobody was around. I felt vaguely like a trespasser as I walked through empty courtyards with pouring springs, through a narrow, arched passage between buildings and out onto the viewing platform with spectacular views above the Mylaon gorge. It was reminiscent of the Lousios near Prodromou monastery: a place to contemplate and enjoy the distant river's sighs.

If you're not Greek, not Orthodox, not even a believer, and not well versed in iconography, the monasteries tend to appeal more for their epic settings and a romantic sense of mysticism or spirituality. Whether you have faith or not, such places have absorbed centuries of prayer just as the ancient temples of the Olympian gods have absorbed their prayers and sacrifices. They feel special even if you can't quite understand or express the feeling.

It's different for the Greeks of course. The faithful consider these places closer to God. The monks or nuns have spent years in communion with scripture, with the sublime. The aged icons, the dark naves, the holy relics and the candle flames represent a mere veil between earth and heaven. Even the rational modern Greek - for whom churchgoing is a rare or non-existent activity and for whom science is the only truth - even he respects the monastic tradition because the Church, the iconography, the liturgy and the monasteries are the foundations of Greek identity and struggle. The War of Independence was a war waged by swordsmen and priests fighting arm in arm, and the monasteries were often the staging posts, hospitals,

storehouses or meeting places. The monastery of Agios Nikolaos of Kaltezes in southern Arcadia, for example, was the site of the first meeting of the Peloponnesial Senate in May 1821, with Petrobey Mavromichalis the president.

My plan was to reach Magoulia, around three hours away, by lunchtime. First, however, I had to find the trail again. A green waymarker inside the monastery precinct suggested that the route continued through and out the other side, but the descent it seemed to indicate was locked. I had to briefly sit with the map and compass to understand that the route onwards began outside the monastery gates and up into thick oak forest. I immediately got lost again, following what seemed to be the trail along a well-worn level monopati when the actual path had been up to my right. The map's scale and my bad eyesight caused a few such confusions.

A brief ascent brings you out into a high plateau that feels almost Alpine: wooded peaks, flower meadows and higher mountains on the horizon. The air is cool and petal scented. A series of older, hand-painted wooden waymarkers in Greek point towards the sanctuary or hermitage of Sfyrida. I unrolled my tent to let it dry in the sun.

You're soon back in a mixed forest of fir, oak and plane on a path that falls away dramatically northwards into the gorge of the unseen Kakorema ("bad stream"), a Mylaon tributary. Fallen trunks occasionally block the path and once again the forest feels close, dark, primeval. The sky is a tattered pattern through leaves and curling limbs.

You hear the spring before you see the flight of stairs to the left. Is this the Sfyrida sanctuary? There seems no sign of a building until you look up through the trees, almost vertically, to see a patch of masonry built into the cliff face like a swallow's nest. A picnic area with wooden tables is laid out on a terrace before the lively stone spring and a further staircase ascends to the unlocked sanctuary.

A sign on the door says to keep it closed at all times (and to not leave any candles burning) but the sign is in Greek and almost none of the hikers are Greek or can read it. The door is open and the interior is much as you'd expect from a wild site such as this: a bare cave with a concrete floor inside the stone wall, a wooden ceiling and a couple of ornate candlesticks. The location is more impressive than the space itself, which may once have been a hermit's residence or refuge but is now probably a site for occasional local festivities or dedications.

Of greater interest is the idea of a sanctuary here in the middle of Arcadia, in the heart of the forest, midway between two already quite remote villages. A sanctuary from what? You have to walk at least an hour in any direction before finding another building and that building is a convent on the edge of a cliff. How far away do people need to get before they can find tranquillity?

I was sitting at one of the picnic benches beneath the looming cliff when it came to me. One of the features of truth as a discovery is that it has to be far away - whether in the past, the future or just the distance. It's a journey. It's a pilgrimage. The road to truth or enlightenment has to be long enough that you experience separation between your previous state of ignorance or delusion and the new state of realisation. Change is required and change takes time. The journey itself is the discovery. I wasn't walking to Magoulia or to Langadia; I was walking to shed the trash surrounding and blocking my perception. I was walking to walk. The act of constant movement is the natural state of the human animal. Almost every Greek I'd met had asked me the same two initial questions: *Από πού είσαι; Πού πας;* - Where are you from? Where are you going? Two points: departure and destination. But the question occurs in-between. We are always in the middle of the trail.

These thoughts were interrupted by the arrival of the same two German girls I'd seen while drying my tent just outside Vytina. I'd heard them before they appeared at the top of the stairs, one of them expressing the surprise I'd felt on looking higher to glimpse the sanctuary in the cliff face. I noted their brief hesitation at encountering an unexpected lone male and we nodded silent greetings.

One (or both) of them was wearing deodorant so powerful that it seemed inimical and invasive in this place. Though a standard cosmetic scent, and entirely normal in the urban world, it struck me as aberrant - an alien element. I probably smelled like something pulled glutinous from a peat bog after my two nights camping without a shower, but I'd not smelled anything this synthetic since the diesel pall of Kifissou central bus station in Athens. I filled my water bottles and moved on.

I was making a note on the trail a little further on when two other walkers came past. The two women were a little older than the Germans and they seemed actively upset to see me standing to one side with my foot up on a rock - so upset that they didn't even acknowledge my existence.

They passed without speaking, without looking, their eyes fixed on the ground.

This upset me. I was no threat to them. Of course, they didn't know this. Now I was faced with the problem of continuing and making them nervous as they heard me approaching. If I overtook them but later decided to stop again, the whole process would repeat. I took out my map and saw that an offshoot path went to something called Agios Anagyris. Another sanctuary? Whatever - going there for half an hour would give the women time to get out of range.

The monopati was heavily overgrown and blocked by bushes or fallen limbs. It passed alongside a ploughed rocky field planted with nut trees (almond?) and emerged on to a gravel road. Agios Anagyris, as I should have guessed from the blue map font, was a natural spring pouring from a stone arch topped with a painted Orthodox icon - apparently the saint to whom the spring is dedicated. The water emerged into a carved stone bowl and down a long, green-moss beard. A perfect picnic location.

I chilled my banana and avocado in the spring's stone bowl and laid out my other meagre supplies: half a pastelli bar and a bag of almonds. It was a simple lunch but a delightful one in this place that felt utterly isolated. The spring must have been built to serve mules and people at a time when a path connected tiny Lasta to the north with Magoulia. Now, the only person to pass a few times each year was the farmer maintaining those almond trees at the end of a dead-end gravel offshoot. The spring, meanwhile, flows solitary, decade after decade, amid bees and birdcalls.

I brewed some coffee - why not? - and ate the pastelli for dessert. Before leaving, I left a coin, a votive offering, beneath the Byzantine-style painted icon of Agios Anagyris. I hope it remains there under the saint's protection.

The path continues through forest, occasionally emerging to reveal sweeping ranges of forested peaks. By the Gavros spring, you look out across a valley to the scattered red roofs of Vytina (right) and Nimfasia (left), both of which seem very distant. There's a brief section reminiscent of Zygovitsi's outskirts - all eroded angles and flood-washed clefts - before Magoulia appears attractively on its south-facing hillside. A dog began to bark the instant I saw the village.

I was approaching along the main asphalt road when a car coming from the village stopped beside me. The driver was a Black man who addressed

me in English with an African accent. Did I want a coffee? I was briefly confused. Was he asking me on a date? No - it seemed that he ran a café in Magoulia and had just closed up for the day. If I wanted, he'd go back and open for me. It was a kind (and enterprising) offer but I'd just had coffee and I wasn't planning to spend much time in the village. He drove on.

Magoulia is very appealing. Many of the houses are renovated stone buildings intermixed with ruins - like Dimitsana, I thought, but without tourist development. I passed the closed café and a taverna with people dining on a terrace overlooking the view, continuing to the old town square beneath a massive and ancient plane tree whose multiple trunks emerged from one girthy base. Chairs and tables belonging to the guesthouse-taverna were set out under the tree but it seemed nobody was there to sell me a drink.

A sign under the tree indicated that it had existed before and during the Revolution. Magoulia had been the birthplace of Theodore Kolokotronis' aide-de-camp Fotis Chrysanthopoulos. The sign had been erected by the Morias21 initiative, a collaboration between various private and governmental bodies aimed at enticing the worldwide Greek diaspora back to the Peloponnese in 2021 for the bicentennial commemoration of the War of Independence. Various self-guided itineraries promised to steer visitors to the most significant sites of Greek identity, notably in Arcadia and Messinia.

As previously noted, Arcadia was never the same bucolic ideal for the Greeks as it was for the Romans and successive aesthetic traditions. For the Greeks, Arcadia is more a heartland of national identity. The wild nature, the ancient mythology, the monasteries with their libraries and secret schools represent Hellenic DNA.

Perhaps even more importantly, Arcadia (along with Messinia and the Mani) is the region that nurtured and supplied the ferocious fighters who would rise against the Turks at the Church's bidding. Arcadia was known for its klephts and brigands, who lurked in the mountains and forests beyond the reach or control of the Ottomans. They were the ancestors of men who'd retreated from the towns after the initial Ottoman invasion to escape taxation, conversion or conscription, and who lived as rebel guerrilla elements. When the time came to rise, these men would form the basis of an irregular Greek army - in actuality more of a semi-cohesive collection of militia groups loyal to clan leaders.

Traveller James Tennent observed the klephts first-hand and had much to say about them:

"In point of education, the Klephts were of course deplorably deficient. Their days were spent in their limeri solely in the pursuit of manly sports and the practice of athletic games, throwing the discus, or practising at a target with their arms. Literature and the refinements of polished life were alike unheard of and unvalued, and their only learning consisted in the traditionary ballads of their tribe, which recorded the valour and exploits of their forefathers.

"In personal agility, their feats were almost beyond credibility. Niko Tsaras, one of their most renowned heroes, was said to have leaped over seven horses abreast, and instances were numerous in which a Klepht, completely armed, had outrun a charger at the acme of his speed. Nor was their endurance of bodily pain less astonishing than their active energy. Inured to hunger, thirst and watching, their enterprises were never impeded by considerations of personal suffering or protracted privations, and engagements without number are recorded in which the Klephts have sustained the combat for three successive days and nights without resting food or slumber.

"The acutest torments inflicted on them by the Turks, when by chance they became their prisoners, could seldom elicit even a look of suffering; and death itself accompanied by all its ingenious horrors was looked upon as less terrific than the insults of slavery and the loss of freedom ...

"The charms of a life such as theirs are inconceivable to the civilized natives of a lower world; like the Alpine hunter, their delights were local sensations in which mankind in general could never sympathise and whose recital is calculated to create amazement rather than congenial emotion. When, as it some times happened, they made a truce with their oppressors and descended to the plains; or when, as was usual, the severity of the winter drove them from their lofty fastnesses to the valleys below, they felt like

strangers amidst their countrymen and, casting wistful glances to the snowy summits of the hills, they seemed longing to return to the freedom of their mountain homes. With their countrymen they were objects of the most intense admiration and respect; their exploits were in every mouth ..."

Another class of warrior was also known among the Arcadian peaks and valleys. The *armatoles* were men armed and paid by the Turks to maintain order in the remoter parts of Greece. Tough and lethal, they were often klephts or ex-klephts known and respected among local populations, treading a fine line between pleasing the Turkish paymaster and representing the Greek community. When the revolution began, such men became the officers and strategists. The revolutionary firebrand Nikitas "the Turkeater" Stamatelopoulos, who fought alongside his uncle Kolokotronis and who famously went through three swords in the battle of Dervenakia near Nafplio had been an *armatole*. So, too, had Kolokotronis.

William Greg met such a heavily armed figure near the Temple of Apollo at Bassae near Andritsaina. Though no longer in Ottoman employ, the man was clearly a senior military presence who had heard about a foreigner in his region and come to investigate:

"While thus occupied, my attention was suddenly attracted by the appearance of three figures ascending the mountain in the direction of the temple. When they were within a short distance of it, one of them separated himself from his companions and came directly towards the spot where I was sitting. He was dressed in the full costume of the country and the rich jacket, white kilt and embroidered greaves shewed his fine martial figure to full advantage. He wore a yataghan and pistols in his belt, and the usual broad-bladed *cimeter* at his side. He seemed to be in the prime of life and had the air and manner of one accustomed to command and conquer. As he came towards me. I rose to meet him and, after a silent and somewhat formal salutation, he addressed me in very good Italian and with that easy politeness which I had often had occasion to remark as distinguishing the

higher orders of his countrymen. He told me that he lived near Andrizzena and that he was just setting out on an excursion to the other side of the mountain, when, hearing that some foreigners had been seen moving in the direction of the temple, he turned so far out of his way to pay his respects to them and offer them any service in his power during their stay in this part of the country, I was not surprised by this extreme attention towards unknown strangers, having already met with several similar instances since my arrival in Greece."

Evidently, the Greek had learned his Italian among the pockets of Venetian resistance to the Ottomans - on Corfu or Zante, in Nafplio or Monemvasia. Greg captured a fragment of this man's speech for posterity, coincidentally recording a crucial element in the understanding of Arcadia itself:

"'Signor,' he continued, 'yonder valley you admire because you say that it looks as peaceful as if it had never heard a sound but the bleating of flocks and the song of the reapers and the murmur of the brook that waters it. You are from a peaceful land and to you, perhaps, to be peaceful is to be happy. But I have seen that valley when it resounded with the shouts of victory and when the waters of yonder stream ran red with Moslem blood. This, to a Greek, was a sweeter sight than the quiet mountains and the flocks and corn and trees and river and all we see before us now.'"

And there you have it. The Arcadia of the foreign visitors was a semi-mythical aesthetic realm - a subject for poetry and painting. For the Greeks, it was and partially still is the blood-soaked and lawless hinterland where tyrants were slaughtered and freedom won. Magoulia was an attractive old village to me: a charming and traditional place to sip something pleasant in the shade of an aged plane tree. Had that same tree once acted as a gallows for Ottoman justice or sheltered wounded soldiers dragged from the battlefield?

Magouliaana-Valtesiniko: Tradition and Trout

I sat for maybe half an hour under the plane tree making notes. My plan was to camp somewhere before the next village of Valtesiniko, but it would be my last night in the tent. Uncertainty about the buses from Langadia meant I needed to be there the day before rather than arrive early to find I'd already missed the only bus of the day (or week). Thus it was, with great joy, that I used the rare internet connection to book a room in Langadia, where I'd be able to have a shower and sleep in a bed like a human.

Camping had its attractions and advantages, but I'd spent too little time in these villages, usually passing through very early when everything was closed. It would have been good to spend a night in each one, accommodation permitting, and to absorb more of the atmosphere - to talk to some living member of the population rather than to its ghosts. The distance between villages, however, can sometimes make this logistically tricky. Between Dimitsana and Zygovitsi is fewer than two hours, but the next leg is at least six. Some of the villages are small enough that an hour or two will exhaust their possibilities, while others might repay a few days' residence, taking in satellite walking routes. This is the benefit of the new 1,700km Peloponnesian network, whose multiple connecting paths allow you to create bespoke routes.

The trail out of Magouliaana climbs sharply to the top of the village, where you find the remains of at least twelve stone-based threshing floors (see the satellite image on Google Maps). Some of these retain their features while others have sunk into the earth and are visible only from above. It's a fascinating throwback to a time when locally grown wheat or barley would have been harvested with sickle or scythe and carried on donkeys to be winnowed here where the wind blew unimpeded. Clouds of

chaff would have filled the sky, settling like snow on the surrounding trees and banks. Then the grain would have been put in sacks and carried to the mills.

It's all gone now. The wood and iron farm implements are in cultural museums or nailed to stone walls in guesthouses as rustic decoration. You generally don't see or hear a donkey. The whole route is littered with the relics of lost agriculture: tumbled buildings, crumbling terraces, nut and fruit trees grown wild because nobody has cropped them seasonally in decades.

Romanticising is naïve, of course. It's easier to buy bread in the village bakery than to make it yourself. It's easier to use a washing machine than a flat stone by the river. Nobody is going to lament the loss of a past in which the majority of each day was spent in hard manual work, just subsisting. Still, the old Arcadia - the notion of a traditional rural Arcadia that lures visitors - is all around. The threshing floors, like the old bridges, are examples of significant labour invested in a future far beyond the individual lifetime.

All of the villages on the Mainalon Trail, with the odd exception of Nimfasia, are designated as traditional settlements. This imprimatur comes from the Ministry for the Environment, Physical Planning and Public Works, though evaluation and identification are seemingly solely by presidential decree. The criteria for being a traditional settlement are broad and ambiguous but may include:

- Retaining an unchanged image of the past and local character.
- Being a landscape, space or area of particular natural beauty.
- Having natural formations that accompany or surround buildings.
- Having distinct architectural heritage in terms of style, building technique or materials.
- Having a distinct urban form and unique social and historical features.

Traditional settlements are found all over mainland and island Greece, with the majority in the Peloponnese. Arcadia alone has around fifty. However, a

lawyer might debate some of the defining features. What is meant by an "unchanged image?" How to categorise "local character?" What are "historical features?" Architectural traditions and materials are more easily identifiable, but many of the criteria are more like a feeling or a sense of tradition. How many old stone houses make a tradition? Is it important how many are ruins?

The idea of traditional settlements is valuable but the vagueness of terms is relevant to the concept of Arcadia. It is history; it is heritage; it is tradition; it is continuity - but in the end it's something almost ineffable. Zygovitsi and Vytina are both traditional settlements, though their commonality is found mostly in the presence of stone structures and being located in Arcadia.

The benefits of being a traditional settlement are dubious. In theory, these are protected villages, but the protection comes in the form of not being able to change, of being chained to the past. Populations are already low and decreasing, but any new houses have to be consistent with the architectural tone. That's expensive. Existing buildings have to be preserved using traditional skills - again, expensive. Unemployment tends to be high and the population elderly. Villages at high altitudes and in remote settings face harsh winters and poor transport links. Is this the price of remaining frozen in a historical bubble of traditionalism?

The more successful places such as Vytina, Dimitsana and Langadia face different problems. The influx of seasonal visitors puts pressure on water supply and waste management, which can lead to pollution of the pristine natural settings. Electricity supply intended for a population of fifty may struggle with 500 summer residents. Such locations might benefit from solar or hydropower, but the unsightly hardware would go against traditional aesthetics.

This is the uncertain balance of maintaining a vision of traditional Arcadia. Nostalgia and tradition are powerful enchantments, but we live in a modern world. How much does it cost to support an illusion? Maybe Nimfasia doesn't have the accreditation because it has too many modern houses. Maybe it doesn't want to be a traditional settlement because the terms are onerous and retard development.

I kept walking. A short stretch through the fir forest led me to a dense tunnel of grasping and thorny reeds that pulled off my hat and scratched my

head well enough to draw blood. It was an opportunity to open my bag and use my packet of antibacterial wipes, bought for precisely this occurrence.

A field of glinting glass and coloured paintwork through the trees suggested a large and busy car park - something I hadn't expected on these wild village outskirts. It was the Manna Hotel, a plush 5-star establishment occupying what used to be the old Mana Sanatorium built in 1929 by Macedonian hero Pavlos Melas and his sister Anna with donations from the Greek diaspora.

The hotel is another face of Arcadia. Its website offers a "retreat in the ancient fir forest of Mount Mainalo" and invites guests to "lose yourself in the depths of its history," to indulge in "authentic hospitality and allow yourself to surrender here, where time stops, the body is rejuvenated, the mind is emptied, and the eyes are filled with nature ... forests, lakes and rivers with crystal water that offers experiences of absolute well-being." Activities include mushroom hunting, canoeing in the river, mountain biking, horse riding, and honey harvesting. Children only above the age of eleven are welcome. It's a fascinating construct, containing many of the Arcadian tropes we've seen so far. The natural setting is pristine and unspoilt to the extent that merely being in it is a cure and a balm, whether or not you have tuberculosis. The rustic arts are a bridge to a simpler, purer time. The history is rich but unspecific - no streams running with Muslim blood, or reeking klephts drying animal skins in their rafters. The overall effect is an amalgam of the European and the Greek notions of Arcadia.

The cars and all of the activity made me nervous somehow. It was the most modernity I'd seen in a few days and it seemed alien, as if I'd stepped into the future. I was dirty, smelly, bleeding and carrying my bed on my back. I didn't belong to this world. At least, not for another day. I stopped by the nearby austere stone church (more like a mausoleum) to make some notes and to see if my scalp wound had congealed.

This part of the route is suggested for families with young children and feels like the longest level stretch of the entire Mainalon Trail. It follows a brook over numerous low-level, wood-plank bridges through airy forest beside flower meadows. The walking is very easy - so much so that the distance passes and movement becomes almost automatic. It's pleasant, but a blur. I realise that I'm not making the same effort to read or notice the landscape. There are no turns, no need to seek the aid of waymarkers, no fallen trunks to negotiate or rocky inclines to analyse for optimum foot

placement. The easy path, to burnish a tired metaphor, is less rewarding.

I realised that I was tired. Maybe because I'd slept badly for the previous two nights. Maybe because I'd been carrying weight for days. Maybe it was an effect of being so mentally alert for so long. Every day, every minute, had brought new impressions, new views, new smells, new directions, new thoughts. Stemnitsa seemed very far in the past and the villages since had blurred into a single place unless I concentrated. Was this mental deterioration, or an enhanced state?

A few times on the trail, I'd thought about an incident in Norman Mailer's 1970 book about the Apollo 11 mission: *Of a Fire on the Moon*. He describes a press conference with the astronauts in which the journalists became ever more frustrated with the answers they were receiving. They wanted to hear about the wonder, the magic, the unimaginable privilege of being the first humans to walk on the surface of this moon that all humanity had gazed upon, conjectured and deified since the dawn of consciousness. But Armstrong, Aldrin and Collins could only talk about payloads, vectors, bum rates and statistical probability. It was all science. Nothing more than science.

Finally, Armstrong caved in to the repeated questions, to the humanist goading. Going to the moon, he said, almost angry that he had to say it, was akin to a trout swimming upstream to spawn. It's just what humans were made to do. It's an instinct to go further, to explore. In fact, the astronauts were dissimulating. They'd been employed to follow an inflexible set of procedures without fault and virtually without thought. Their paymasters didn't want imagination or wonder in their astronauts. That was dangerous. Wonder wasn't something you could test or measure. It was unpredictable.

Once on the moon, however, Aldrin and Armstrong went to pieces, relatively speaking. Their timing was out. They were distracted. Armstrong had to be reminded to collect moon rock - his number-one priority in case immediate evacuation proved necessary. Clearly, they were ecstatic to be on the moon. Search for the photograph taken of Armstrong by Aldrin just after the two had climbed back into the capsule. His eyes are bloodshot after sleeping so few hours, but he's grinning like a man who's just walked on the moon. He looks as high as he is above the Earth.

The relevance? My daily walking on the trail - the rhythm, the repeated movement, the receptivity to new stimuli - created a mental state. It's well established that sustained movement or exercise provokes endorphin

secretion, encourages self-reflection, enhances awareness and improves mood. It's a common experience that taking a walk or a swim or a bike ride in the middle of a complex cerebral task allows the brain to "turn off" while still working subconsciously on the problem. Out of nowhere, it seems, a solution or a realization invariably appears.

It's primitive. It's the trout instinct. Thinking and moving, exploring and discovering are our natural condition. In those prehistoric ages when we were hunters and gatherers, humanity created language, stories and cosmologies long before writing became necessary to keep records, trade or connect different peoples over distance. To move ever onwards and to discover is - or was - to be fully alive. However tired I felt on this penultimate leg, my mind was clear and free. I didn't want the trail to end.

It was only 4.00 pm but the flower meadows beside the track offered the best place to camp before Valtesiniko. Earlier in the trip, the idea of waiting four or five hours for nightfall would have been very frustrating, but I felt totally relaxed. I pitched the tent early because it looked like rain and I cooked some lentils with a bay leaf I'd plucked from a tree near Stemnitsa. Bees hummed constantly over the flowers.

The rain started after I'd eaten: very light but reason enough to get inside the tent. It was barely dusk but I was content lying on my sleeping mat and listening to the patter on the tent fly. I'd secretly been hoping it would rain at least one day to justify the amount I'd spent on good equipment and, possibly, permit me to use my rain poncho the following day.

A few people - all women - have asked me since if I wasn't afraid camping alone in the forest. It's another indication of how life for women is so different to what men take for granted. In my mind, I was invisible once darkness fell. Who was going to attack me after dark if they couldn't even see me or know where I was? I'd hear them coming long before they'd be able to see the tent. Why would they attack me anyway? For some small amount of cash? The worst that could happen, I thought, was a boar-related incident or inadvertently angering someone whose land I'd used. Not so for women. Just being a woman was reason enough to be attacked. Real-life cases have shown how (usually local) men have followed them out of villages and accosted them when they were far from help.

I stress that this has never happened on the Mainalon Trail as far as I'm aware. But that doesn't matter. The experience of women worldwide is that being alone in a secluded place is dangerous because of men. Few women,

I've been told, would have hiked the route in the same way I did and that's a great shame. It's shameful.

I woke, as I had for the previous two dawns, to a single cuckoo calling. It had rained more in the night and the tent fly was heavy. I packed everything, my breath steaming, and set off for Valtesiniko, where I expected to find a bakery selling spanakopita and other highly calorific items.

I was already close to the town. The track followed a gravel road almost to the village's periphery. I could see it built down the slope of its hill: large relative to other villages on the trail. A well-preserved kalderimi took me through dew-heavy meadows and abandoned agricultural space up into the streets.

Valtesiniko, like Vytina, feels like a self-sufficient village: a modern and thriving place with many tavernas, various accommodation options, a post office and even a large school. The many houses are a combination of beautifully renovated stone and new-builds. Its population of around 340 (down from almost 700 two decades ago) makes it one of the larger villages on the trail, though it seems many of the houses are inhabited only in the summer months when families come from big cities for the cooler conditions.

Historically, the place was an agricultural hub living from forestry and livestock. Its ten churches indicate a much larger population in the nineteenth century. Nowadays, Valtesiniko's fame is more for woodcarving and as a tourist centre. It wasn't the sort of place visited by the Grand Tourers because it didn't connect ancient sites and hadn't been mentioned by Pausanias. It was entirely unknown and invisible to them within the forested folds of these mountains. Their notion of Arcadia was remote temple ruins or vanished cities, but Valtesiniko was another level of remoteness.

The small store was closed as I walked along the main street but I felt sure a bakery would be serving early agricultural traffic. A café was open and I went in, scanning for a display unit stacked with freshly baked spanakopita. There was none. I asked the woman if she had any. No. Was there a bakery in the village? No, she told me - it was only a small village. Was there, in fact, any food to be had in the café? No.

Panic fluttered in my empty stomach. All I had in the backpack was an

empty pastelli packet that maybe contained a few crumbs of sesame. But the woman was reconsidering ... She had some cake. Did I want some cake? Indeed I did. I wanted all of her cake.

I sat out on the terrace by the road and she brought me a kind of chocolate Battenberg-style sponge cake without the marzipan coating. Accompanied with a large and very good Greek coffee, it was the best breakfast I'd had since Dimitsana. Was the cake actually for customers, I wondered, or had she taken pity on this hungry hiker and offered me a family dessert? I ate it very slowly, savouring every small bite and licking my fingers at the end. Men wearing forest camouflage and driving battered Toyota pick-ups stared at me as they drove past.

Though trees shaded the road, there didn't seem to be an obvious centre - a place for the people to gather - as there had been in Stemnitsa, Magoulia, Nimfasia and Zygovitsi. Was this a symptom of modernity? Maybe the road had been widened and subsumed the old centre, which wasn't missed because it was no longer needed.

Again, I'd arrived too early to really appreciate the place. It would have been great to eat lunch at a taverna and watch the locals in the evening, but I had my reservation in Langadia and after that a reservation in Nafplio for two nights (with no guarantee of getting there). I also wanted to revisit a favourite restaurant in Athens before flying home. The ideal would be to spend three weeks or a month in Arcadia, staying in one village for a few nights and doing all of the various trails before moving onto the next. Stemnitsa has a few variants, while both Vytina and Eláti allow you to explore longer tracks to Chrysovitsi and Alonistena. With the newly unveiled Peloponnesian routes, you could happily spend three months hiking. Time is the issue.

Valtesiniko-Langadia: Lost and Found

I ascended steeply out of town, past the handsome stone-built school. My bag was heavy with the still-wet tent and enough water for the five-hour stretch ahead. The panoramic views above Valtesiniko were of wooded peaks and cultivated valley basins fading off into the distance. From here on, the path would be dense forest track opening periodically into broad wildflower meadows that would once have been filled with sheep or goats but now were alive with bees. As with every day so far, the sky was clear and the sun warm.

I got briefly lost in one of these fields. The path seemed to go straight but no markers appeared after a while and there were multiple tracks. I went back and eventually discovered that the trail followed the field's left-hand perimeter along a low, stone wall. The rigmarole of reorienting myself was also an opportunity to extend and dry the tent.

A lone Dutch woman passed as I was re-rolling the dry tent. She asked if I'd camped on that spot. She was perhaps sixty- five or older and wore compression sleeves on her knees but carried no pack. Her husband, she told me, was waiting for her where the trail met the road. We'd cross paths twice more before I reached her husband maybe ten minutes before she did. They were retired and spending three months in Greece, driving around the Peloponnese and visiting the islands.

The final leg of the Mainalon Trail is a little like a "greatest hits" compilation of the whole: mossy, fir-forest tunnels, flower meadows, epic views across the valleys from ridgelines, naked erosion scars, trees in blossom. The paths are broken stone, compacted earth, dilapidated kalderimia and gravel roads. Birds and bees make the only sounds. It's all so serenely beautiful, but by now you're spoiled. You've seen it before. The

people who start the walk in Langadia experience this part with fresh eyes, but with the disadvantage of the colossal climb facing them from the Lousios to Stemnitsa.

An open area of floral hummocks known as Grilas Point has a sign describing how it used to be a mineral-sand mine, with miners scraping off the surface to gather one of the ingredients of mortar. They would transport the sand for processing in wooden boxes balanced carefully on the back of mules. You'd never guess this history from the landscape alone, which has a vague sense of having been worked or shaped but no clue as to how or when.

This is so often the case with Arcadian landscapes. Human activity is present in walls, terraces, unnatural lines of trees or clearings in the forest, but the facts are often lost beyond human memory - or soon will be. We know how a threshing floor was used even if nobody has used one in half a century, but only grandfathers and grandmothers now know the name or use of certain implements and practices.

A few times on the trail, I noticed fresh donkey dung and hoped to meet some relic of the early twentieth century moving between villages on paths constructed three or four hundred years before that. But I never saw the animals or their handlers. They may be living in houses distant from the path, distant even from the villages - parts of Arcadia known only to some few souls, where the notion of internet is as speculative and fantastic as the worship of Poseidon in equine form.

Shortly after Grilas Point, there's another area that seems to have been even more worked. Various stone buildings lie tumbled, terraces are overgrown and threshing floors gleam fracturedly white through the grass and flowers. This was once the centre of some prolonged and significant operation - perhaps the production of foodstuffs to feed Langadia and other villages. A disintegrating but identifiable kalderimi passes beneath a corridor of trees planted to shade it. Dozens of people must have worked here for centuries, season after season, but now there was only one hiker from a different country observing the remains of history's receding tide.

Langadia appeared over the next rise: a large village tumbling down its slope into the lushly forested valley. The population of around 400 makes it the second largest after Vytina (560), though that number was more than 3,300 in 1950. The saddle provides a magnificent view but was the start of some serious problems for me.

The signpost points towards different destinations, but the arrow to Langadia was (to my eyes) an equilateral triangle while the others were isosceles triangles clearly indicating one direction. The Langadia triangle didn't seem to point anywhere in particular, except possibly back the way I'd come. The arrow might as well have been spinning. There were three likely routes: up to the left, down to the right or straight on towards the village. None of those options had any waymarkers that I could see.

Perhaps I was tired and thinking of my lunch. The village seemed so very close - twenty minutes, maybe. I started to walk straight on a well-worn path going directly to the village - but not a single marker appeared. I went back to the sign but still couldn't figure out where the path might be. Earlier in the trip, I would have taken some time to explore until I found a marker, but now I was hot and hungry. I decided that the well-worn path was well worn for a reason. I could see a gravel road snaking round to the village by a water mill mentioned in the trail notes and the path almost certainly intersected with it further down the hill. So ...

The path vanished after about ten minutes. Just totally faded out. Why did it even exist? Dozens of walkers making the same mistake? By now, there was no going back. The gravel road was the other side of a deep ravine - perhaps 300 metres in a straight line from where I stood. OK - into the ravine. I set off down the near-vertical slope of high grass, thorns and prickly bushes. It was uncomfortable but manageable. When finally I reached the lowest point, a dry creek bed, I saw that someone had erected a chain-link fence the other side. It was a heavily rusted fence that must have been there for fifty years or more - utterly purposeless until the moment this Englishman arrived at it. The owner of the fence, if he was even still alive, had triumphed in preventing someone from setting foot on his wild, impenetrable and futile scrub.

Was I angry? Just a little. I decided to follow the dry creek bed. Water descends, right? It'd take me right into the village. Except the foliage was so dense and the rocks so difficult that I simply couldn't pass. I would have to go back up to the sign on the saddle and start again. I'd now wasted forty minutes beating about the bushes in the hot sun.

The ascent was worse. I'd lost the place where I'd descended and this patch was even more overgrown - so dense that I literally couldn't go through it, around it, or over it. Tangles of thorns were waist high, concealing gullies and rocks. I had to charge up the 45-degree incline like a

rugby player, shouldering aside bushes and stamping on anything that would allow me access. I was sweating. I was breathing heavily. I was afraid that I might actually die here from exhaustion or dehydration or both, to be found nibbled and sinewy six months later because, well, who'd be stupid enough to try and walk through this?

I finally made it back to the Judas path that had led me here and drank my last mouthful of water. My forearms were scratched and my trouser leg was ripped. The back of my underpants contained scratchy leaves and twigs. I marched back towards the sign on the saddle muttering vile oaths, stopping only when surprised by an enormous tortoise walking towards me. "You, too?" I said.

I'd like to report that I found the marked track - but that didn't happen. I saw a gravel road just metres from where I was and decided it must be the same gravel road I'd seen before. Nobody would build a fence across a road, right? I darted into another scree-slippery declivity and bounded onto the road in a cloud of dust and frustration. Now it was just a matter of strolling a kilometre or so to my lunch.

Except the road curled around the cursed hill I'd just descended and started going in the opposite direction to Langadia rather than crossing the ravine. I kept walking, mostly out of anger, and saw that the road was just following the contours. In no time, it crossed and started to rise on the other side of the dry creek and I saw a waymarker. Somehow, I was back on the trail. The original path, I believe, had been up and to left while looking at the sign. I'd discounted it because it was doubly in the wrong direction as far as I could tell.

I passed a spring with a trough and got down on my knees to plunge my head under the freezing flow, filling my hat with water and putting it on so the water poured over my torso. I was hot. And thirsty. And hungry. And happy not to be dead in a gully.

The gravel road became an asphalt road, which became some walls then a village. Directly in front of me was a tavern with chairs set out under a large plane tree. An old Greek woman sat alone there. I would never normally go to the very first place I see but there were extenuating circumstances. I strode/limped up the woman and I asked if I could eat. It was still quite early for lunch.

She replied that she could do eggs and potatoes. Eggs and potatoes. It was not ideal. Was the place actually closed? Was it even a taverna or just

her house? It would have felt rude to simply walk away in search of something more satisfying. Did she have a menu? Yes indeed she had a menu.

She went into the tavern and came out with the kind of menu I'd been dreaming about: a laminated sheet featuring all of the classic Greek dishes. Stuffed peppers, stuffed vine leaves, grilled meats, *tsatziki*, *fasolada*. But I was hesitant. I knew that a small taverna in a village doesn't always have everything listed on the menu. What have you got? I asked.

Bifeki, patatas, horiatiki. Three things. From the whole menu. Beefburgers, fried potatoes and a salad. Eggs if I wanted. I ordered it all and a beer. I'll be honest - my expectations were not high. She hadn't wanted to cook and it didn't seem like this was the most popular place in town. On the other hand, I didn't want to move for at least the next hour or so.

It was magnificent. The burgers were homemade, massive and delicious. The chips were plentiful and the salad may have been one of the best Greek salads I've had, with deep-red, homegrown tomatoes and feta made probably less than a kilometre from the table. I sat in the shade of the plane tree and gorged myself, the old woman sitting with me and nodding appreciatively at my appetite. Like grandmothers everywhere, she derived great pleasure from feeding people.

A car arrived with three out-of-town Greeks and they took the table behind me, ordering the *bifteki*, *patatas* and *horiatiki*. I listened to their conversation, which focused on the quality of the food. These vegetables, these tomatoes, this cheese - they were traditional products. You couldn't find this kind of quality in the city. Arcadia was the magic ingredient in the food and in the setting. I pulled leaves from my trousers and leaned bloatedly back in my chair, my plates polished clean, and asked if there were any desserts. A *baklava*, maybe? Some *loukoumades*? A *bougatsa* as big as a mattress?

No. Nothing like that.

My accommodation was officially a luxury suite. It had three beds, a sofa, an armchair, a kitchen, a working fireplace and an enormous corner balcony with views over the village and a forested valley so thickly verdant that it could have been a Jamaican or Puerto Rican scene. The first priority was a shower with all of my clothing swilling at my feet in the soapy water. I'd have to walk around in just my underpants for the next two or three hours as

everything dried on the balcony.

The proprietress had said she'd enquire for me about buses the following day (a Sunday). In Athens, I'd asked the ticket seller on the Arcadia desk what time buses ran from Langadia to Tripoli and she'd looked at me as if I'd asked her about rocket schedules to Saturn. She called somebody, but they didn't know either. Somebody called her back and she jotted down the details. On weekdays, there was a school bus to Tripoli at 7.30 am. At the weekend, the only possibility was to get a connection in nearby Karkalou. What time did it leave? Early.

Early. That wasn't terribly specific. I took stone-paved staircases down through the town as I had in Stemnitsa, hoping to find the station or at least a ticket office. It's a village of many handsome stone buildings mixed with other derelict stone buildings - a place that had obviously been important in the past. The stonemasons of Langadia were famed for their skills, thanks partially to the requirement to build on such steep mountain slopes, and many of the houses are very grand. The memorials to fallen war heroes had a lot of names.

I couldn't find any trace of a bus station, a ticket office or a printed timetable, though the terrace overlooking the valley has a list of taxi drivers across Mainalon. Would it be so very difficult to print a bus timetable and post it here? Over 4,000 walkers had passed through this village in the previous year alone, most of them needing to return to Tripoli. The KTEL Arcadia website didn't list any buses from Langadia and the details given to someone who called them in Tripoli on my behalf were wrong or misleading. They'd said there was a bus to Stemnitsa only on Tuesdays without mentioning other possible connections. It's almost as if they don't want you to use the buses.

I appreciate it may not be cost effective to make more buses available to remoter villages like Langadia or Stemnitsa, though at least five walkers needed to get to Tripoli on the same day as I did. Maybe a minibus with a maximum of ten seats could be used? Maybe there could be a registration scheme where hikers sign up and pay in advance - a minimum of five per trip? - so that it becomes more cost effective. One of the aims of the Mainalon Trail is to bring more people into these depopulated regions to aid the local economy. The taxi drivers are benefiting hugely, but is the infrastructure responding adequately? I repeat that the trail was inaugurated ten years ago and has so far seen tens of thousands of walkers.

The proprietress got back to me saying that she'd been unable to locate anyone who knew how the buses operated on a Sunday. She must have hosted dozens, possibly hundreds, of trail hikers. She lived in the village. But even she couldn't tell me what time the bus to Karkalou might leave the following morning, if indeed there was such a bus. Would I have to stay an extra night because nobody knew how to leave? Would I have to hitchhike to Tripoli the next morning?

My quest for a bus timetable was at least an opportunity to stroll around the village. The church of the Taxiarches on the main street looks older than its construction date of 1808. It was partially destroyed by Ibrahim Pasha in 1825 in reprisals for the revolutionary uprisings and today seems weathered by many centuries. Perhaps it's an effect of the altitude, the climate and the kind of stone. The clock tower beside the church is uglier, austere like a tombstone, and was built in 1910 with the donations of rich Langadians living in America.

A clock was a curious choice of gift. Those far-away Arcadians carried memories of their homeland, nourished them, shared them with successive generations and wove them into nostalgic reveries of the old country, the heartland. The clock represented a continuity of time to those emigrants: the village still existed across the ocean, so distant as to be almost inaccessible, but connected by a known hour. The Langadian in California or New York could look at his watch and think, "It's 4.00 pm now in the village - which they know thanks to our clock."

But the clock was also a droll, even a mocking insistence on modernity. The exact hour and minute had not only been irrelevant for most of the village's history but also unknowable. People had worked according to the rising and setting of the sun, the heat of the day, the season's necessities. Now here was a clock documenting every minute of the village's slow slide into obscurity, its depopulation and its once-grand stone houses falling vacant, falling down. Who in Langadia in 1910 needed to know that it was exactly 4.02 pm?

The largest building in the village is the now defunct Hotel Langadia. I don't know why it failed, but I have a theory. Places like this and like Vytina attract a mostly Greek clientele in the winter. They come for the fairytale snow on firs and the glow of traditional restaurants amid the night's chill. Such an experience favours the small guesthouse or the boutique hotel, which evoke a cosy and romantic ambience. A massive hotel may be fine at

a beach resort, but the mountains are different. It's not an escape if you're sharing a dining room with 100 other people.

The Manna Hotel near Magoulia is larger but offers a different proposition. It is a destination in itself: a step even further and more remote than the villages near it. It's an escape from the escape.

I asked the owner of my accommodation what Greeks associate with Arcadia. Her first answer: the mythology. Pan, the dryads etc. Then the revolutionary history: the warriors, the Church. For the younger generation, who didn't know or care about mythology or history, Arcadia was a place of pretty villages. The ruined stone houses were pieces of a stage set evoking a non-specific past. You could buy your locally produced honey or cheese and an embroidered cushion cover. You could order the rooster or the goat in red sauce. You were in Arcadia.

It was inevitable that I'd dine in the village. I chose the taverna under the huge old plane tree because it looked like it might once have been the village's old centre. It was where people naturally congregated. And by some mysterious law of attraction, most of the hikers I'd seen on the trail were in the same place at the same time: the German girls I'd seen at the Syfrida sanctuary, the Dutch walker and her husband, and the women who hadn't registered my presence near the Agios Anagyris spring.

I ordered gigantes and stewed lamb - both excellent. At neighbouring tables, Greeks ordered, *stifado* or rooster in red sauce, praising the traditional ingredients and lauding the pleasures of Arcadia. I'd noticed on my earlier stroll that the cooks were actually an Asiatic couple and I thought again of the African café proprietor in Magoulia. Did they represent the first wave of a new Arcadia?

Now that were no longer on the trail, I could approach the Germans without undue weirdness. Did they happen to know what time the bus left for Karkalou the next morning - if it existed - and did they know where I might get tickets? They had booked a taxi for 11.00 the next morning. Did I want to go with them? *Absolut ja* I wanted to go with them! Now I'd be able to spend more time in bed and eat the breakfast I thought I was going to miss due to an early bus.

I sat at my table picking my teeth and finishing my beer. This was my last night on the trail. I was tired and contented to have completed something, but also sad that I wouldn't be walking for hours the following

day (I'd be waiting five hours in Tripoli for the Nafplio bus). Being in the forest amid the relative silence of birds and bees had become a state of mind - a level of unaccustomed tranquillity. Would I be able to tale that with me? Would I be able to recall the sensations of being by the Zarziou bridge, or at river's edge along the Lousios, the Mylaon? Would I be able to transport myself back to the butterflies and buttercups of ancient Gortys?

Breakfast was served on a terrace off the main road, overlooking the valley. It was a cool morning but the village was awash with the warm, buttery scent of yellow spartium. A service was underway in the church and the priests' mellifluous chanting carried across the street. The spanakopita was homemade; the fried eggs, jam and honey were locally produced; the water was from a spring and the coffee was excellent. There was also a glass of iced pomegranate juice - a nice mythological touch. Persephone, daughter of Demeter, had sealed her fate as queen of the underworld by eating six pomegranate seeds. Thereafter, she would have to spend six subterranean months a year as the upper world passed through autumn and winter. Would this drink bind me to a Langadian return? Was the clock tower ticking that duration for me?

Along the trail, I'd toyed with the idea of picking a favourite village. Magouliana's plane-shaded square had seemed the most authentic. Eláti's majestic solitude was appealing. Dimitsana's setting was impressive. Vytina and Langadia had plenty of spirit. But Stemnitsa, the starting point, had risen to the top of my ranking. It was traditional without being a cliché, developed without being a tourist trap, faded but not a ghost of itself. It also had a lot of walking tracks.

The café beneath the plane tree was full of taxi drivers awaiting their fares. I joined them and watched as the church ejected its congregation: all women of a certain age, all dressed to impress. They poured chattering onto the café terrace and ordered coffees, juices, pastries. It was one of the few instances I'd seen of village life. Most of the others had been seemingly empty, or I'd glimpsed only the early-morning traffic.

Life would go on here, and in Stemnitsa, in Vytina, in Eláti without me. But Arcadia would always be here as it always had been. Its meanings were now deeper and richer for me than before.

Arcadia Found?

It would be easy to conclude that Arcadia, like anywhere else, means something different to different people at different times. For many Greeks, it's the heart of the Peloponnese, which itself was the heart of the Greek Revolution in the 1820s. Its klephts-turned-freedom-fighters, its militant priests and its cliff-top monasteries make it a cradle of modern Greek identity and independence.

For a younger generation with less interest in or knowledge of their past, Arcadia is a rural idyll of forests and mountains, clear air and transparent rivers - something like the Alps, the north of Scotland or Alaska. Not a mythical realm but a real place. It's where you go to escape the city's heat and noise. It's a modern brand encompassing purity, simplicity, health, tradition and heritage. It's also something of a national secret: where Greeks go in the winter to enjoy the snow - a place of their own, away from the usual tourist infrastructure.

Then there's the mythology, specifically Pan and the nature nymphs. The whole of Greece has mythological roots, but Pan is specific to Arcadia. He was born and lived there as Poseidon occupied the seas. Elsewhere in Greece, the gods were omnipresent. They could appear at will and take the form of other people or animals. Pan was native to one place and synonymous with it forever thereafter. Pelasgus, meanwhile, was seen by some as the first man: the progenitor not only of Greeks but of all humans and of human civilisation.

For much of the later twentieth century, Arcadia was also a place of abandonment, depopulation, ruin and poverty. Agricultural cultivation largely vanished with the emigrants, leaving villages of illustrious ruins, overgrown paths and outdated transport links. It became a forgotten region, its long decline blamed on Ottoman stagnation but also a victim of modernity's march to urbanisation and industrialisation.

For non-Greeks since at least Polybius, Arcadia has been an Edenic ideal of perpetual spring, piping shepherds, benign beauty, gurgling brooks and winsome sheep. The gentleman travellers soon discovered it was few of these things. Rather, it appeared to be dirty, poor, ignorant, lice-ridden, corrupt and forgotten. As Bayard Taylor wrote, Arcadia was "the musical name of a beautiful impossibility."

To this extent, Arcadia seems little different to any other town or region. Places change and so do perceptions of them. However, all of the various perceptions of Arcadia have common traits that together build towards a persuasively consistent idea.

Isolation

Arcadia has always been conceived as a place distant in space, time and knowledge. The ancient Greeks built temples and sanctuaries here, distant from any larger towns, because holy places require pilgrimages and natural settings that encourage divine awe. The healing god Aesklepios needed clear air, silence, pure water and isolation as part of his worship. The Temple of Apollo at Bassae/Andritsaina was built on top of a mountain to be closer to the god, its prayers and sacrifices entering the upper aether.

Only Polybius, of the ancient writers, had seen the place and even then perhaps just a part of it. Successive poets and artists constructed an abstract aesthetic: an imagined realm that notionally existed but was never visited. Pausanias went there, but his descriptions were often vague and used names that didn't correspond with modern versions. Towns and villages he described in the second century AD had vanished by the time later travellers came looking for them so even the reality became a semi-fiction.

Arcadia's fame as a nest of klephts, fugitives and brigands was similarly due to its relative inaccessibility. The mountains, rivers, forests and passes were difficult and dangerous for the Turks to police, relying on local *armatoli* to do the job. Though *kalderimia* were built, there were also paths and tracks that only the Greeks knew and which no Turk would risk unless in large, armed groups.

When the Grand Tourers came, they had no maps. There were no adequate walking maps apart from Pausanias' ambiguous itineraries. A dragoman or other local guide was required to lead the European gentlemen to temples that had been lost for so long that no Greek or Turk knew their

origins.

Even in the twenty-first century, Arcadia feels remote. Dimitsana is only around 110km from Nafplio (the nation's first capital and one of Greece's biggest towns in the early nineteenth century) but the trip isn't easy unless you have a car. To be in any of the Mainalon Trail's villages is to feel that you are far from everything else. If another village is visible through the peaks, it is a far-away smudge of red rooftops. Many Greeks or foreign motor tourists who visit Arcadia see only the villages without venturing further for hours along narrow paths into the forest. They are in Arcadia without seeing most of it.

Some Arcadian villages such as Vytina, Dimitsana and Langadia are well known within Greece, if less so internationally. Outside Greece, there are people - as my taxi driver said - who think that the only Tripoli is in Libya and that Megalopolis, like Gotham or Metropolis, simply doesn't exist. Places such as Nimfasia, meanwhile, are unknown among Peloponnesian Greeks. There's no reason to know this or many of the other obscure villages with no touristic profile.

In short, this region in the centre of the populous and popular Peloponnese has retained a remarkable degree of mystery and unknowability. It's still a considerable effort to reach the Lousios riverbed or the Zarziou bridge.

Antiquity

It seems absurd to talk about antiquity in Greece. However, Arcadia is perceived as ancient even among ancient civilisations. Early historians considered that its population existed before the supposed Dorian and Achaean invasions from the north, remaining undiluted by them. Indeed, the Arcadians were thought to be indigenous. They were the *proselinos*, who had existed before the moon appeared in the sky.

Arcadia was also the site of Pelasgus' birth, according to the Arcadians who spoke to Pausanias. Pelasgus was the first man and the progenitor of all successive human civilisation. There is, of course, no evidence for these myths, but it is important that they exist and existed at a very early stage - already ancient 2,000 years ago.

The antiquity of Arcadia bestows a privilege of truth and purity on its landscape. When the old gods died, when different civilisations took

control, when waves of migrants blended populations, Arcadia retained a sense of being a source: a pocket of unchanged identity stretching back before written history. This, along with its remoteness, helped make it a font of national identity.

Consistency

Delphi was once known across the ancient world as an oracular site. For centuries, it drew pilgrims seeking truth and insight. But that fame faded with the passing of the ancient gods. Not so Arcadia, whose profile as a rural idyll, a utopia, has persisted since before Theocritus and Polybius until today. The Roman poets such as Virgil built on the writings of those early Greeks, both of which remained alive in the European aesthetic traditions until the revival sparked by Sannazaro, Sidney and their successors. A search of a song-lyric website in 2025 found 369 lyrics and forty-one artists referencing Arcadia, including Lana Del Rey's "Arcadia" (2021) and Caroline Polachek's "Arcadia" (2014 - album and single). In 2020, Stockholm's National museum ran an exhibition entitled "Arcadia - A Paradise Lost," gathering various art-works on the theme.

What explains this persistence of the Arcadia trope? History has shown us that the real Arcadia, though beautiful, is no earthly paradise of eternal spring and happiness. The people who reference it have usually never been there and may not even know that a place called Arcadia actually exists.

Distinctiveness

Idealised places have existed throughout history. There was Eldorado with its limitless gold. There was Cockaigne, the imaginary medieval land of pleasure and excess. There was the New Jerusalem of the Old Testament. The ancient Japanese had Mahoroba, a far-off land of bliss and peace. The ancient Chinese had Mount Penglai. Russian folklore has the Oponokoye Kingdom at the edge of a flat earth, where life was easy and nobody had to work.

The difference is that those places were imaginary. Their locations might have been guessed at or inked on maps of unknown regions, but they existed more in hope and fantasy. New Jerusalem was indeed in Jerusalem - but a possible future Jerusalem. Arcadia had existed since the start of

recorded time and continued to exist as its legend developed.

The fact that so few people visited even while burnishing the rural-idyll trope makes the place even more remarkable. The concept was stronger and more durable than the place - even though the place existed. When later it became a centre of the revolutionary spirit, the legend and the reality were joined again.

Pan was another feature of Arcadia's distinct conception. Those other places had their related mythologies and features, but Pan travelled. He began in the forest darkness and was celebrated there, but he soon became a pan of the wider Greek pantheon before being embraced by the Roman Empire. The spirit of Arcadia spread to grottos and shrines far distant from the mountains of Mainalon.

Infernal features

One curious element of the Arcadian construct is the opposite side of its utopian coin. It was an idealised paradise - a kind of heaven - but it was also aligned with hell. Pan was a musician, a dancer, a drinker and a singer - but also terrifying and capable of rages that alarmed the entire forest. He slept in dark dells and subterranean spaces. It's no accident that early representations of the homed, goat-legged god are now perceived as satanic.

Arcadia was and is a place of dramatic contrasts. The gentle Mylaon and sapphire-glinting Lousios seem benign enough, but they vanish occasionally into impenetrable gorges that roar and echo. They disappear into the limestone crevices beneath the earth, flowing in darkness, and erupt icy cold from obscure orifices. Many have identified the Greek underworld's river Styx with the Mavroneri ("black waters") that emerges from a ravine on Mount Chelmos. It is in the north Peloponnesian region of Achaea today but was anciently part of Arcadia. Herodotus identified this as the Styx and Pausanias was given the same information by locals.

William Leake believed that Gortys had connections with the Melaeneae or Meleneae. Melaina was a nymph who in Leake's time was sometimes confused with the chthonic (underworld) nymph Melinoë, daughter of Persephone and Hades himself. His attribution was probably due to the partially subterranean nature of the Lousios and the depth of the site inside the gorge.

Arcadia/Utopia

Apart from the geographical reality of Arcadia, there's also the notion of Arcadia in the sense of an ideal location or state of being that does not and cannot exist because its perfection has been irrevocably lost. It is unattainable except in the realm of dreams and imagination.

A utopia, on the other hand, is notionally a goal to aim for: a better way of living based on the flaws of current systems. Utopias may be unrealistic due to the inherent contradictions and selfish drives of humanity, but they are conceived as possible futures, whereas Arcadias are in the past and gone.

The concept of Arcadia is purest among the poets and painters who never saw or knew the reality, though the beauty of real-life Arcadia was enough to persuade some visitors that it was just as described by the ancients. Some of them attempted to reformulate its wild mountains and dark gorges into a new definition of Arcadian beauty. On the whole, it was better to believe that its ideal form had been corrupted by time and by history.

The true Arcadia?

My time on the Mainalon Trail was enlightening. Beyond the beautiful landscapes and the villages, spending five days in nature gave me a sense of living a more primitive life - the kind of life humans lived before civilisation, when we roamed mountains and forests in search of food or territory.

It occurred to me that this was humanity's natural state as animals. Our intelligence and millennia of civilisation may have dulled the base instincts, but it's a mere blink in evolutionary terms. If we feel happy, energised and alive amid the trees or atop a cliff, it's because we belong there more than inside a small room, inside a building, inside a city. And it occurred to me that Arcadia - the true essence of Arcadia - is an ancestral memory, a behavioural and conceptual atavism. An unformed longing for pre-civilised freedom.

Consider Pan. He was a god born of Arcadia. His animal nature, with anthropomorphic features, is typical of the earliest representations of human spirituality. The Löwenmensch figurine, for example, discovered in

Germany's Hohlenstein-Stadel, is an ivory sculpture of a man's body with a lion's head. We have no idea what it represents, but it is clearly a combination of nature's violence and mankind's attempts to live with it. The piece's age is estimated at between 35,000 and 41,000 years old.

Pan was an intercessor god. He came from the mysteries of nature - the darkness, the danger - to aid man's progress into the unknown. He had human traits but also animal appetites. Why did he sometimes create panic? Panic is a group behaviour seen in animals including humans. When there's a fire or a bomb threat, when the plane makes an emergency landing, when shots are heard in a shopping centre, people lose all rationality and rush the exits even though some will inevitably die in the crush. Architects and engineers design spaces with exactly this reaction in mind, trying to mitigate it.

Panic was, and is, also used by human hunters who frighten a herd into a confined space to be penned, or off a cliff to die without the danger of a fight. It is an animal reaction that, to the rational but primitive human mind, seems to come from nowhere - a conflict that needs resolving. Where does it come from? From the god who provokes it. From Pan.

Who did Pan principally protect? The herdsman and shepherds. These people were among the first representatives of the Neolithic societies that shifted from being nomadic hunters and gatherers to stationary farmers. They maintained herds rather than having to seek food, but they still had to pasture their animals, which meant braving the dark passes and forested dells. The shepherds were something akin to the priests or monks of their transitional period, straddling two worlds with the help of their intercessor god.

Pan's divine/satanic nature represents the fear and unpredictability of the unknown and the triumph of human ingenuity. The concept of Arcadia as a paradise that is also adjacent to hell reveals the shift between civilisation's securities and the hunter's perpetual uncertainty. Thus is the notion of Arcadia as a fossilised artefact of one of humanity's greatest adaptations.

Arcadia is primarily conceived as a paradise because it represents an entirely forgotten but better time. Those other ideal places such as Cockaigne or the Oponokoye Kingdom were often folk concepts perpetuated by peasant classes who had worked for centuries and who dreamed of an easier life. Their hardships were a direct result of civilisation, which allocated each person a responsibility that became a life sentence of

work. To grow the grain. To mill the grain. To make the bread. To raise the livestock. To kill the livestock. What had been a precarious but freer existence had been sacrificed for the ease of not having to seek food or shelter each day.

That sense of a freer time, I believe, is still with us in our reactions to nature. It has echoed throughout all of human civilisation and can be found in most world religions. Eden is the obvious example with its initial population of two and a benign nature that supplied everything they could need - but also a threat in the form of the serpent and of knowing too much. In Zoroastrianism and the religions that followed or grew out of it, paradise was a perfect place where humans and gods lived together: an earthly origin but also a place of return (heaven).

Among the eastern religions, the difference is minor. Nirvana is not necessarily a place but a state of ultimate happiness and quietude: a sense of being at one. Was I feeling something similar as my senses reached out into the forest and the core of myself lost its weight? Was that the state of innocence we had before civilisation taught us to exist within confined terms and roles? In Hinduism, Brahman is the essential reality of the universe beyond individual existence: a natural law and state.

We clearly have an innate urge towards a better state that we've lost or that remains out of reach until we can learn how to access it. Such tropes are common in religion, mythology and art, but their common characteristic is their inaccessibility. They are too far, too difficult, too lost.

Arcadia still exists, as it has beyond our ability to know its past. We will never know what, if any, facts lie behind the myths of Pelasgus or Lykaon, though we do know that the area has been inhabited for a very long time. The Asea valley has revealed chipped stone tools from the Middle/Upper Palaeolithic period of around 38,000 years ago - long before humans formed into towns to cultivate land or livestock. Those Arcadians were hunters and fisherman pursuing mammoths, as finds have shown.

Arcadia is not alone in being somewhere we can feel a connection to a condition lost long ago. Nature in general can awaken that feeling, Arcadia, however, is very little changed since the days our pre-civilised, prehistoric antecedents walked its mountains. This place famed as a paradise, an idyll, a primitive form of pure nature, is still there and still inspires songs, dreams, adventures. Eden is forever lost, but Arcadia's peaks remain on the horizon.

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APPENDIX

Tips for the Mainalon Trail

The trail's difficulty is rated as "moderate" but such things are relative. There are no technical stretches such as scrambles or chains but there are many steep ascents and descents, often over loose rock or dry leaves. Based on my experience and on conversations I had with other walkers, here are some suggestions:

Shoes: You don't need full walking boots with a high ankle unless you have ankle problems or unless that's what you prefer. The variety of trail surfaces favours something a little more flexible. I wore approach shoes with a square heel and a Vibram sole. An Australian couple I met in Dimitsana, thinking that the trail was mostly forest, had decided to wear only running shoes and had been uncomfortable on the Stemnitsa-Dimitsana leg.

Poles: You probably don't need to take poles if you're young and carrying only a daypack. If you have knee or back issues (like me), or if you're carrying a larger, heavier pack [me again), then poles are very helpful on the steep inclines and for balance. They are also notionally useful to fend off charging dogs, though this is an unlikely scenario.

Clothing: Some people will tell you that shorts are inadvisable in close forest terrain due to the threat of ticks. You're sharing the trail with boar, fox, badger and possibly wild goats. Kermes oak has scratchy leaves like holly and there are occasionally thorny bushes. Of course, trousers can be hot in summer so you might consider taking both - or those zip-off trousers. For similar reasons, a long-sleeved shirt is worth considering. A wide-brimmed hat is useful for the many open stretches, and may also protect your head from low foliage.

Water: If you're walking long stretches, replenish bottles from springs when available. The water is excellent and some walkers have said they

drank more than expected due to the heat and the exertion. Be aware that not all springs marked on the map may have water.

Transport: The bus timetables to and from Stemnitsa and Langadia are notoriously difficult to predict and may change according to the season. Many of the options are early school buses that don't run in the hottest months. Any details you can find online or from calling the station may not be accurate. Local taxi drivers are now accustomed to taking hikers between villages, but for ten times more than the bus costs. If you meet other hikers in Athens or Tripoli or on the trail, ask about their plans - it might be possible to share ta-xis and save money.

Facilities: As of 2025, there are small shops in Stemnitsa, Dimitsana, Vytina, Valtesiniko and Langadia. All of those villages have places to eat, as do Eláti, Zygovitsi and Nimfasia, though opening hours may be seasonal in the smaller towns. Accommodation is also available in (or close to) all villages, but there may be only one place with a handful of rooms so a booking is useful.

Navigation: The waymarkers are sufficiently clear and plentiful that you really don't need a map or GPS. That said, it's better to be safe. A map is a useful way of orienting yourself in the wider landscape and a compass is occasionally useful when faced with multiple tracks. A few walkers get momentarily lost if they miss a marker or if, like me, they intuitively follow the direction the path seems to go. There are numerous occasions when the direction is counterintuitive. Reorienting is simply a question of going back to the last marker and looking around.

Payments: Carry cash in case the smaller village businesses don't take cards.

Timings: The timings between villages are estimates rather than promises. I generally found the timings generous even though I was stopping often to make notes or take photos. Longer sections such as Zygovitsi-Eláti and Valtesiniko-Langadia took the time predicted. Generally, it's better to allow yourself extra time to enjoy the trail and explore the villages.

Weather: Weather is changeable in this mountain region. There may be snow into April or even the beginning of May. Some sections may be closed due to snow in mid-winter. Be prepared for rain even in summer and take care in the bottom of narrow river gorges such as the Lousios during or after storms. River levels can rise quickly.

The high centre of Arcadia can be ten degrees cooler than the Peloponnesian coast or plain, especially at night. This isn't a big problem if you're staying in accommodation, but mornings, or an evening meal on a restaurant terrace, might be cooler than you expected.

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Glossary

Agogiates: Horse-handlers employed by travellers to carry them and their luggage.

Albaneses: An obsolete word for Albanian emigrants into Greece.

Bakshish/baksheesh: A bribe or a tip under Ottoman rule.

Bardouniots: Muslim brigands in Greece who had fled Ottoman authority.

Briam: Oven-roasted vegetables.

Bougatsa: A dessert of filo pastry filled with custard or cream depending on region.

Cimeter/scimitar: A single-edged, curved sword used by the Turks and appropriated by Greek fighters.

Demogerontes: Village elders.

Dimarchus/dimarchos: Town or village mayor.

Dragoman: An official guide and expedition leader with local knowledge, hired by foreign visitors.

Frank: A northern European - a name originating with the mostly French Crusaders who entered Greece in the thirteenth century.

Fustanella: A pleated white kilt - the traditional dress of Greek men in the nineteenth century.

Janissary: A member of an Ottoman military corps that often policed and accompanied foreign travellers.

Kalderimi/a: A form of cobbled stone path built by the Ottomans all over Greece.

Kastro: A Greek word for castle that forms many place names. E.g. Paleokastro (old castle).

Khan: A large house in a village offered for rent to travellers.

Klepht: Usually a fugitive Greek or Albanian living among the mountains and forests while surviving on banditry, extortion and highway robbery.

Konaki: A guesthouse.

Limeri: A refuge, retreat or lair in the mountains.

Linus: In Greek mythology, Linus of Thrace was a musician and master of eloquent speech.

Loukoumades: Small doughnut balls, usually served drenched in honey or syrup.

Monopati/a: A narrow path whose literal meaning is "to walk alone" or in single file.

Morea: The old word for the Peloponnese, named after its resemblance to the shape of a mulberry leaf - morus.

Para: Ottoman currency: a coin or "piece."

Pasha: A regional governor or authority in the Ottoman Empire.

Porte: The central government or authority of the Ottoman Empire.

Postillion: Someone who rides a harnessed horse that pulls a vehicle, rather than driving from behind like a coachman.

Spanakopita: A "spinach pie" made of filo pastry, spinach and occasionally onions or feta cheese.

Stifado: A stew of beef lamb or rabbit (depending on region) with pearl onions.

Sumpter: Weight-bearing/pack animals.

Tambour: A circular or rounded stretch of wall.

Tripolitsa: The old name for modern Tripoli.

Tsipuro: A strong alcoholic spirit like ouzo, traditionally offered to monastery visitors.

Voivode: A local governor or ruler.

Yataghan: A curved, short Turkish sabre or long knife.

Welkin: The sky.

Xenodochio/a: A guesthouse, inn or hotel.

Zechin/sequin: A gold ducat minted by the Republic of Venice from 1284 to 1797.

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